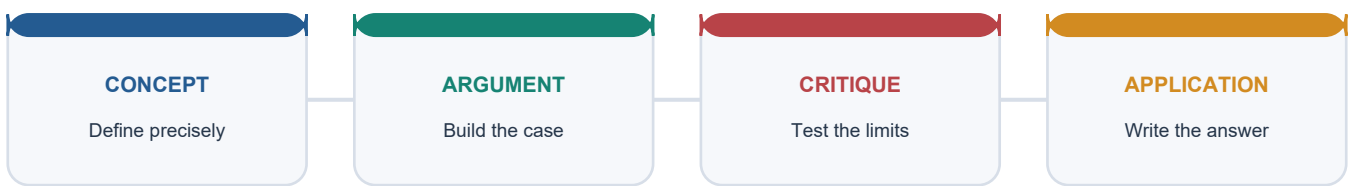


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Mīmāṃsā - Complete Learning Session

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Mīmāṃsā - Complete Learning Session

Catalogue identity: Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper I - Indian Philosophy · Syllabus item 18. **Official syllabus wording (verbatim, printed spelling retained):** Mimamsa: Theory of Knowledge. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit term in IAST follows immediately in brackets. **Evidence discipline:** doctrine, textual attribution and previous-year wording follow the repository's canonical owners. Facts are separated from interpretation, and genuinely contested matters are reported as contested. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never presented as official keys.

Package practice counts

Component	Count
Teaching sessions in the Basic block	19
Core diagnostic multiple-choice questions	24
Remedial diagnostic multiple-choice questions	8
Total diagnostics	32
Solved previous-year questions	14 (all primary-owned by syllabus item 18)
Original solved Mains models	6 (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)
Consolidated register parts	19 (A-S)
ASCII master flow panels	24

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

How this Basic block is organised

The nineteen sessions below run in teaching order, not in source order. Each session opens with a definition, gives a gateway idea in plain language, shows the concept before it argues it, then supplies the named evidence, the answer-grabbing line, the must-write keywords, a worked answer-paragraph model, the exam route, the traps and a rapid revision strip.

Everything needed for a complete 10-, 15- or 20-mark answer on any of the fourteen previous-year questions owned by this syllabus item is inside this Basic block. The Optional Advanced block near the end of this document is enrichment; **no core answer depends on it.**

The printed syllabus clause for this item is three words long - Mimamsa: Theory of Knowledge. - and that brevity is a trap rather than a mercy. Mīmāṃsā's theory of knowledge is not a free-standing epistemology bolted onto a ritual manual. It is an epistemology **built to secure supersensible duty without a God**, and every one of its famous doctrines exists because that project needed it. The sessions therefore follow the system's own load-bearing order: first the project, then the instruments, then the theory of error and self-awareness that the instruments force, then the philosophy of language that the scripture forces, then the authorlessness and injunction-theory that the duty forces, and only then the metaphysics of self, liberation and the rejected creator.

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
1	The project: inquiry into duty (dharma-jijñāsā) and why epistemology serves it	Fixes the purpose that explains every later doctrine
2	Textual lineage and the Pūrva/Uttara ownership boundary	Separates what Mīmāṃsā owns from what Vedānta owns
3	The two sub-schools - Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara - and why the split matters	UPSC almost never asks generic Mīmāṃsā
4	Intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya): thesis, fourfold formulation, argument	The system's foundation stone

Session	What it settles	Why it comes here
5	The extrinsic rival (parataḥ-prāmānya), the dream objection, Sāṃkhya and Buddhist positions	The 2025 comparison and the standard critical paragraph
6	The map of knowledge-sources: why six for Bhāṭṭa and five for Prābhākara	The irreducibility principle that governs the whole list
7	Perception, inference, comparison and testimony as Mīmāṃsā states them	The four shared instruments, with the Nyāya contrasts
8	Why memory is not a means of valid knowledge	The 2020 and 2024 questions, and the novelty condition
9	Postulation (arthāpatti): structure, the stout Devadatta case, irreducibility	The 2022 and 2024 questions
10	Non-cognition (anupalabdhi) and the reality of absence (abhāva)	The 2021, 2023 and 2025 questions
11	Theories of error: the four rival accounts, stated precisely	The 2022 twenty-marker
12	How cognition is known: threefold awareness, knownness, after-cognition	The 2024 twenty-marker
13	Does self-luminosity entail intrinsic validity?	The 2018 twenty-marker, settled by an intra-Mīmāṃsā counterexample
14	Sentence-unity and the two rival semantics	The 2024 ten-marker
15	Universals or particulars, exclusion (apoha), and the rejected sound-burst (sphoṭa)	The 2023 fifteen-marker
16	The authorless Veda (apauruṣeyatva) and the circularity charge	The 2019 ten-marker
17	Injunction, impelling force (bhāvanā), obligation (niyoga), unseen potency (apūrva), duty and the hermeneutic canons	Where the epistemology becomes an ethics
18	Mīmāṃsā without God (nirīśvaravāda)	The school's most counter-intuitive and most examinable position
19	Self, liberation, inter-school debates, criticisms and the graded verdict	The evaluative close every high-mark answer needs

One-line map of the whole topic. Mīmāṃsā secures a supersensible duty by making cognition innocent until proven guilty, by admitting every irreducible way of knowing, by explaining error without surrendering that innocence, and by grounding scripture in the absence of an author rather than in the perfection of one.

SESSION 1 - THE PROJECT: INQUIRY INTO DUTY, AND WHY EPISTEMOLOGY SERVES IT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Earlier Mīmāṃsā (**pūrva-mīmāṃsā**) is the school that asks one question and builds an entire theory of knowledge to answer it: *how can a human being know what he ought to do, when what he ought to do cannot be seen, touched or inferred from anything visible?*

Technical definition. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā is **inquiry into duty (dharma-jijñāsā)**. Its controlling formula is **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah** - duty (**dharma**) is that good which has Vedic injunction (**codanā**) as its distinguishing mark. Because duty so defined is supersensible, the school's epistemology is inseparable from its hermeneutics: a means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) is never discussed in the abstract alone, but always in relation to the *kind of object* it can disclose.

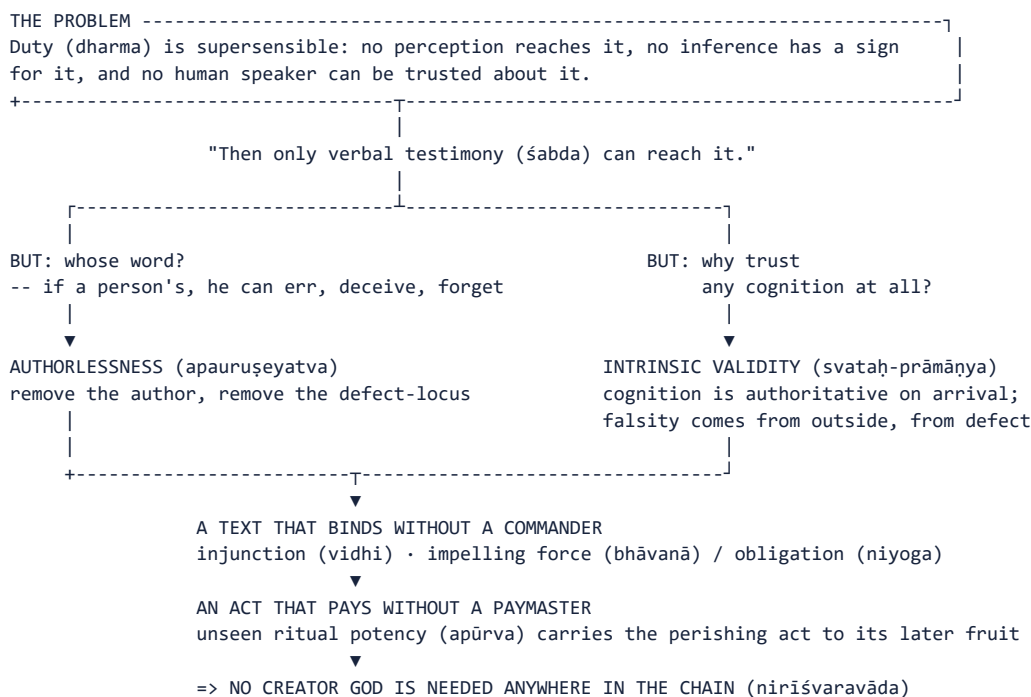
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Think of a legal system with no legislature and no judge, only a statute book that nobody wrote and nobody can amend. Everything that matters - what is obligatory, what is forbidden, what counts as correct performance - must be read out of the text itself. There is no author to consult about intention, no sovereign to appeal to for clarification, and no divine enforcer to guarantee that the text is true.

If that is your situation, two things become urgent at once. First, you must show that the text carries authority *by itself*, since there is nobody behind it to lend authority to it. Second, you must show that reading and knowing are generally reliable, since if cognition in general needed external certification, the reading of that statute book would need it too - and there is nothing outside to supply it.

That is the whole of Mīmāṃsā in one image. Its famous doctrines - intrinsic validity, the six knowledge-sources, the theories of error, the eternal word, the impersonal injunction, the unseen potency, the rejection of a creator - are not a shopping list. They are the load-bearing walls of a single building whose purpose is to make an authorless command knowable and binding.

VISUAL - WHY EACH DOCTRINE EXISTS



What the diagram shows: every celebrated Mīmāṃsā doctrine is a repair to a specific hole that opens the moment you decide that duty is supersensible and that no person may be trusted with it. Read the column downwards and the school stops looking like a ritual curiosity and starts looking like a tightly argued anti-sceptical system.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The school begins from duty, not from being.** Jaimini's opening inquiry is into what ought to be done, not into what metaphysically is the case. The orientation is action-guiding rather than speculative-theological, and this single fact explains why Mīmāṃsā develops a philosophy of language and a theory of injunction that no purely metaphysical school needs.
2. **Instruments are matched to objects.** Perception (**pratyakṣa**) reveals what is presently sensible. Inference (**anumāna**) extends beyond the present where a reliable relation is already established. Neither reaches duty, ritual efficacy, or a fruit that will mature after death.
3. **Therefore verbal testimony (śabda) becomes central, and specifically Vedic testimony.** In Mīmāṃsā, testimony is *not* a fallback used when perception fails. It is the **only** route to supersensible duty, which is why the school gives it a philosophical dignity that Nyāya, for all its acceptance of testimony, never quite gives it.
4. **Defending the Veda therefore requires defending cognition itself.** If a cognition were

suspect until certified from outside, Vedic cognition would hang on some further authority - and that authority would need certifying in turn. Mīmāṃsā refuses the dependence at the root by holding that validity is intrinsic (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**) and invalidity extrinsic.

5. The minimum metaphysics is deliberately sparse but strong enough to carry the epistemology.

The school is broadly **realist**: enduring objects stable enough to be known, named and acted upon; a **plurality of selves**, each a knower, agent and enjoyer; moral and ritual responsibility that therefore makes sense; and a moral order regulated by action and unseen potency rather than by a divine dispenser.

6. Three enabling propositions do the work. Knowledge is possible because objects are real.

Ritual obligation is possible because injunction is meaningful. Future fruit is possible because action leaves an unseen potency. Remove any one and the system loses a wall.

7. **Error must be exceptional, not constitutive.** A school that lets falsity into the normal structure of cognition cannot leave the ground floor; the ritual instruction it exists to protect would collapse into permanent uncertainty. Hence Mīmāṃsā's theories of error are engineered to quarantine error rather than to generalise it - a point Session 11 develops.

8. **The result is a general epistemic realism, not a ritualist's convenience.** ANALYSIS: Read narrowly, the school looks like ritual apologetics. Read philosophically, **svataḥ-prāmāṇya** is a fully general theory of default epistemic entitlement that happens also to secure scripture. Both readings have textual support; the second is the one that earns marks.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: **Jaimini, Mīmāṃsā-sūtra*** - organises the inquiry into duty and Vedic interpretation; the source of the formula **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah**.
- FACT: **Śābara, Śābara-bhāṣya*** - the foundational surviving commentary through which the aphorisms are classically read.
- FACT: **Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, Ślokavārttika and Tantravārttika*** - the Bhāṭṭa line's epistemology, semantics and polemic.
- FACT: **Prabhākara Miśra, Br̥hatī*** - the Prābhākara line, with **Śālikanātha** as a major later expositor.
- ANALYSIS: Standard modern presentations - Chatterjee and Datta, C. D. Sharma, Radhakrishnan - supply the survey vocabulary in which UPSC questions are usually phrased.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā's theory of knowledge is not an epistemology that happens to defend a scripture; it is a scripture-defence that had to become a general epistemology, because a text with no author can borrow no authority from anywhere outside cognition itself.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
inquiry into duty (dharma-jijñāsā)	Names the school's project in its own vocabulary
codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah	The defining formula; one Sanskrit clause worth several sentences
Vedic injunction (codanā / vidhi)	Marks duty as <i>commanded</i> , not discovered
supersensible (atīndriya) object	Explains why testimony is not a fallback here
intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya)	The load-bearing epistemic thesis
realism about objects and selves	The presupposition without which the thesis is subjectivism
unseen potency (apūrva)	The bridge from perishing act to later fruit

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's epistemology is best understood as instrumental to its practical project: the school theorises knowledge because it must secure a duty that nothing visible can disclose. **Named evidence.** Jaimini opens the *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* with the inquiry into duty and defines duty by its distinguishing mark, Vedic injunction - **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah** - and Śābara's commentary reads the whole system through that clause; Kumārila and Prabhākara then divide over *how* the injunction binds without dividing over *that* it binds. **Analysis.** Because duty is supersensible, perception and inference are structurally disqualified, testimony becomes the sole competent instrument, and the reliability of testimony cannot be borrowed from a speaker who does not exist. The school is therefore forced upward from hermeneutics into general epistemology, and it arrives at intrinsic validity not as a pious preference but as the only position that does not generate an infinite regress of certifiers. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The dependence runs both ways, and that is also the school's exposure: if the general theory of cognition fails, the defence of scripture fails with it. Mīmāṃsā's epistemology and its scriptural authority rise and fall together, which is exactly why Nyāya attacks the epistemology rather than the scripture.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - "How does Mīmāṃsā establish the authority of Vedic knowledge?" The framing paragraph of that answer is this session; the machinery is Sessions 4 and 16.

- Every 15- and 20-mark Mīmāṃsā answer can open from here, because stating the project in one sentence immediately explains why the doctrine under examination exists at all.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing that Mīmāṃsā "is only ritualism." The ritual orientation is real; the epistemology is general. Say both.
2. ANALYSIS: Treating **śabda** as a secondary or emergency source. In Mīmāṃsā it is the *only* competent source for its own proper object.
3. ANALYSIS: Confusing **pūrva-mīmāṃsā** with **uttara-mīmāṃsā** (Vedānta). Session 2 fixes the boundary.
4. ANALYSIS: Saying the school "has no metaphysics." It has a deliberately minimal but load-bearing realism about objects, selves and moral order.
5. ANALYSIS: Importing God anywhere into the chain. Session 18 shows the school removes God *on purpose*.

RAPID REVISION

- Project = **dharma-jijñāsā**; formula = **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah**.
- Duty is supersensible => testimony is the only competent instrument => scripture must be self-valid => cognition in general must be self-valid.
- Minimum metaphysics: real objects, plural enduring selves, agent-enjoyer identity, unseen potency, beginningless moral order.
- Error must remain exceptional or the whole instructional project collapses.
- Lineage: Jaimini -> Śābara -> Kumārila / Prabhākara.

SESSION 2 - TEXTUAL LINEAGE AND THE PŪRVA / UTTARA OWNERSHIP BOUNDARY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. "Mīmāṃsā" means reverential investigation. The word names two different investigations of the same corpus: the **earlier** one (**pūrva-mīmāṃsā**) investigates the action-guiding, ritual portion and asks what must be done; the **later** one (**uttara-mīmāṃsā**, that is, **Vedānta**) investigates the Upaniṣadic portion and asks what ultimately is.

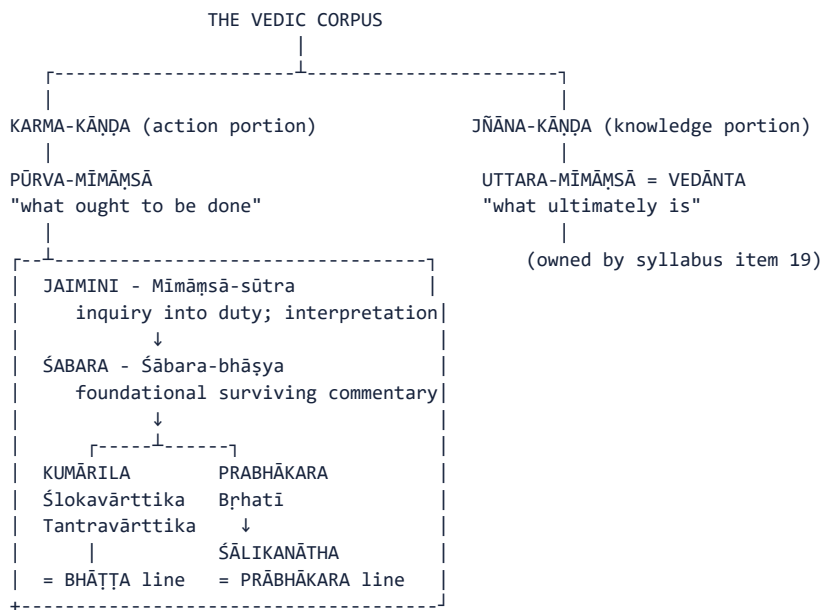
Technical definition. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā owns injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority and ritual interpretation; Uttara-Mīmāṃsā owns the Brahman-centred interpretation of the Upaniṣads. The traditions are historically related and share the premise of Vedic authority, but ANALYSIS: Vedānta must not be allowed to absorb Mīmāṃsā's independent ownership of the four items just listed.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two commentators are handed the same library. One turns to the volumes that tell people what to do and asks, "What exactly is being commanded, by what rule do I read it, and how does an act performed now pay out later?" The other turns to the volumes that describe what is, and asks, "What is the one reality these sentences are pointing at?"

They are not rivals about the library's authority - both accept it absolutely. They are rivals about what the library is *for*. That single disagreement generates almost every Mīmāṃsā-Vedānta clash you will ever be asked about, including whether a sentence like "you are that" (**tat tvam asi**) needs to be reinterpreted as supporting an injunction.

VISUAL - THE LINEAGE AND THE BOUNDARY



OWNED HERE, NOT BY VEDĀNTA: injunction · duty · authorless verbal authority · ritual exegesis
OWNED THERE, NOT HERE: Brahman · māyā · superimposition · identity-sentences as final

What the diagram shows: a single trunk with two branches of inquiry, and a two-generation commentarial ladder inside the earlier branch that ends in the two rival sub-schools whose quarrel supplies most examinable Mīmāṃsā content.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Jaimini's Mīmāṃsā-sūtra is the base text.** It organises the inquiry into duty and into the rules by which Vedic sentences are interpreted. It is a manual of *how to read a command*, and its epistemology is embedded in that task.
- Śabara's Śābara-bhāṣya is the foundational surviving commentary.** ANALYSIS: This matters for source control: much of what a candidate calls "Jaimini's view" is in fact reached through Śabara. Say "as read through Śabara" when the point is commentarial.
- Kumārila Bhaṭṭa establishes the Bhāṭṭa line** through the *Ślokavārttika*, the *Tantravārttika* and related works - six knowledge-sources, the reality of absence, contrary-apprehension in error, knownness as the route to knowing that one knows, and word-priority in semantics.
- Prabhākara Miśra establishes the Prābhākara line** through the *Brhatī*, with *Śālikanātha* as a major later expositor - five knowledge-sources, no separate instrument for absence, non-discrimination in error, threefold self-luminous awareness, and sentence-priority in semantics.
- Textual chronology is debatable; doctrinal ownership is not.** CAUTION: Dates, the relative priority of Kumārila and Prabhākara, and the internal layering of the commentaries are genuinely disputed in scholarship. What the examination requires is the *doctrinal* map: Jaimini-Śabara supply the shared frame; Kumārila and

Prabhākara build rival epistemic and semantic architectures on it.

6. **The ownership firewall has a practical payoff.** When a question mentions "the Mīmāṃsakas" alongside "the Advaita Vedāntins" - as the 2018 twenty-marker does - you are being asked to keep two Vedic schools apart, not to blend them. When a question says only "Mīmāṃsā," you must still name the sub-school whose doctrine you are stating.

7. **Where the boundary is genuinely contested.** ANALYSIS: Pūrva- and Uttara-Mīmāṃsā share vocabulary (*vidhi*, *arthavāda*, *ekavākyatā*, *apauruṣeyatva*) and the later Vedāntic use of Mīmāṃsā hermeneutics is real. Report the sharing; do not let it dissolve the difference in purpose, which is what actually gets tested.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Jaimini, *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra*; Śābara, *Śābara-bhāṣya*.
- FACT: Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, *Ślokavārttika*, *Tantravārttika*; Prabhākara Miśra, *Bṛhaṭī*; Śālikanātha as later Prābhākara expositor.
- FACT: The doctrinal boundary statement: Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā owns injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority and ritual interpretation; Uttara-Mīmāṃsā owns the Brahman-centred reading of the Upaniṣads.
- ANALYSIS: Chronology and attribution details are reported by the tradition and by modern scholarship with varying confidence; keep them as background, not as assertions.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Pūrva- and Uttara-Mīmāṃsā are not two levels of one doctrine but two answers to the question of what a scripture is for; the earlier school reads the Veda as a command and the later reads it as a disclosure, and almost every quarrel between them is a consequence of that one difference.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
earlier inquiry (pūrva-mīmāṃsā)	Correct self-designation of the school
later inquiry (uttara-mīmāṃsā) / Vedānta	Names the boundary partner precisely
action portion (karma-kāṇḍa)	Locates the school's textual base
Jaimini · Śābara · Kumārila · Prabhākara · Śālikanātha	Attribution precision
Bhāṭṭa line / Prābhākara line	The two architectures, not two moods
ownership firewall	Prevents Vedāntising the answer

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's doctrinal identity is fixed by a lineage and by a boundary: a two-stage base that both sub-schools share, and a firm separation from the Vedānta that reads the same corpus for a different purpose. **Named evidence.** Jaimini's *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra*, read through Śābara's *Śābara-bhāṣya*, supplies the shared frame; Kumārila's *Ślokavārttika* and Prabhākara's *Bṛhaṭī*, extended by Śālikanātha, build the two rival systems on it; and the traditional division of labour assigns injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority and ritual exegesis to the earlier inquiry.

Analysis. The lineage explains the shape of the doctrine. Because the base text is a manual of interpretation rather than a metaphysical treatise, both sub-schools inherit an obligation to explain sentence-meaning, and because both inherit the same defence of the text, their differences concentrate in epistemology and semantics rather than in scriptural loyalty. **Qualification.** CAUTION: The relative chronology of Kumārila and Prabhākara and the internal layering of the commentaries remain scholarly disputes; an answer should therefore assert doctrinal ownership confidently and historical sequence cautiously.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2018, Q8(a), 20 marks** - the question expressly ranges over Naiyāyikas, Mīmāṃsakas and Advaita

Vedāntins; the boundary taught here is what keeps the three columns from bleeding into one another.

- Any question that says "according to Mīmāṃsakas" is implicitly asking you to name **which** Mīmāṃsakas.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Calling Kumārila's school "Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa's" school. **Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa** is the sceptical Cārvāka-adjacent author; **Bhāṭṭa** names the Kumārila line. The similarity of names is a genuine examination hazard.
2. ANALYSIS: Attributing to Jaimini what is available only through Śabara.
3. ANALYSIS: Letting "Mīmāṃsā" silently mean "Vedānta" because both accept the Veda.
4. ANALYSIS: Presenting contested dates as settled facts.
5. ANALYSIS: Writing "the Mīmāṃsā view" on error, absence or semantics without naming a sub-school - on every one of those three, there is no single Mīmāṃsā view.

RAPID REVISION

- Jaimini -> Śabara -> (Kumārila = Bhāṭṭa) and (Prabhākara -> Śālikanātha = Prābhākara).
- Earlier inquiry = action portion, duty, injunction, exegesis. Later inquiry = Upaniṣads, Brahman.
- Firewall: injunction · duty · authorless verbal authority · ritual interpretation stay here.
- Bhāṭṭa ≠ Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa.
- Assert doctrine confidently, chronology cautiously.

SESSION 3 - THE TWO SUB-SCHOOLS, AND WHY THE SPLIT MATTERS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Mīmāṃsā comes in two working versions. Kumārila's version (**Bhāṭṭa**) is willing to admit extra entities and extra instruments whenever a phenomenon refuses to be reduced. Prabhākara's version (**Prābhākara**) is economical, and prefers to explain the same phenomenon with machinery it already has.

Technical definition. The Bhāṭṭa sub-school accepts six means of valid knowledge including non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**), defends contrary-apprehension (**viparīta-khyāti**) in error, denies self-luminosity of cognition and explains awareness of cognition through the object's acquired knownness (**jñātātā**), and holds connection-of-the-denoted (**abhihitānvayavāda**) in semantics. The Prābhākara sub-school accepts five means, rejects a separate instrument for absence, defends non-discrimination (**akhyāti / vivekākhyāti**), affirms self-luminosity through threefold awareness (**tripuṭi-saṃvit**), and holds denotation-of-the-connected (**anvitābhidhānavāda**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two engineers are given the same brief. The first says: "If a phenomenon behaves differently from everything else on my list, it gets its own line on the list, even if the list grows." The second says: "Adding a line is a confession of failure; find the phenomenon a home in what you already have."

Both are good engineers, and both are building the same bridge - Vedic authority, realism, ritual efficacy, intrinsic validity. But the first ends up with six instruments, a real category of absence and a genuinely false cognition in illusion; the second ends up with five instruments, no separate absence and no false cognition anywhere. ANALYSIS: Notice that the disagreements are not independent eccentricities. Each follows from the same instinct applied to a different case.

VISUAL - ONE INSTINCT, SIX CONSEQUENCES

SHARED MĪMĀMSĀ COMMITMENTS (both sub-schools)

Vedic authority · realism about objects and selves · ritual efficacy through unseen potency
intrinsic validity of cognition · irreducibility as the test for admitting an instrument

BHĀṬṬA (Kumārila): admit what resists reduction, and pay the ontological cost

PRĀBHĀKARA (Prabhākara): economise and avoid positing extra faculties

1. SIX instruments of knowledge
2. absence (abhāva) is REAL, known by non-cognition (anupalabdhi)
3. error = contrary apprehension (viparīta-khyāti): a real false cognition
4. cognition NOT self-luminous; inferred from the object's knownness (jñātātā)
5. semantics: words denote first, then connect (abhihitānvayavāda)
6. motivation: the desired fruit moves the qualified agent (bhāvanā-vāda)

- FIVE instruments of knowledge
- absence is the bare locus, PERCEIVED; no separate instrument needed
- error = failure to DISCRIMINATE two valid cognitions; NO false cognition
- cognition IS self-luminous; knower, known and knowing revealed together
- semantics: words denote only as connected (anvitābhīdhānavāda)
- motivation: the command itself binds (niyoga-vāda) - duty for duty's sake

=> UNITY IN DIFFERENCE: both remain Mīmāṃsā because the shared row above never breaks.

What the diagram shows: a single shared foundation, two opposite methodological instincts, and six paired consequences that a good answer can reel off in order. Learning the table as a table is worth more than learning six isolated facts.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **UPSC almost never asks for "generic Mīmāṃsā."** Of the fourteen previous-year parts owned by this syllabus item, six name Bhāṭṭa or Prabhākara explicitly, and several more are unanswerable without the distinction. Writing an unattributed "Mīmāṃsā view" of error, absence or sentence meaning is a factual error, not merely a stylistic weakness.
2. **The split is architectural, not superficial.** It reaches the accepted list of instruments, the explanation of absence, the explanation of illusion, the self-luminosity of cognition, the theory of sentence meaning, and the source of ritual motivation. Six different fault lines, one underlying tectonic difference.
3. **Kumārila's instinct: multiply where the phenomenon demands.** Kumārila is willing to admit an extra instrument (non-cognition), an extra ontological category (absence with its counterpositive), and an extra property (knownness) whenever collapsing them would distort what is actually cognised.
4. **Prabhākara's instinct: economise where a simpler explanation is available.** He explains absence by perception of the bare locus, error by non-discrimination, and knowledge of cognition by self-luminosity - in each case avoiding a new posit.
5. **Both keep the roof on.** Both accept the Veda's authorless authority; both are realists; both accept ritual efficacy through unseen potency; both accept intrinsic validity; both apply irreducibility as the admission test for an instrument. ANALYSIS: A high-scoring answer says this explicitly: it is **unity in difference**, and the unity is what makes the differences *intra-school* disputes rather than a schism.
6. **A warning about "economy."** ANALYSIS: It is tempting to score Prabhākara as the more rigorous thinker because his system is leaner. That is an evaluative judgement, not a doctrinal fact. Kumārila's reply is that economy purchased by distorting the phenomenon is false economy - precisely the argument he makes about absence in Session 10.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, *Ślokavārttika* - six instruments, reality of absence, contrary apprehension, knownness.
- FACT: Prabhākara Miśra, *Bṛhatī* - five instruments, bare-locus perception, non-discrimination, threefold awareness.
- FACT: The paired-consequence grid is the canonical Bhāṭṭa-versus-Prābhākara master table used across the previous-year corpus.

- ANALYSIS: Both sub-schools' accounts of liberation are late and comparatively thin; report this rather than manufacturing symmetry (Session 19).

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Bhāṭṭa-Prābhākara dispute is not six quarrels but one: whether a philosopher should enlarge his inventory to fit the phenomenon or trim the phenomenon to fit his inventory - and every examinable difference between them is that single instinct applied to a fresh case.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
Bhāṭṭa (Kumārila) / Prābhākara (Prabhākara)	Correct attribution is half the mark
irreducibility test	The shared admission rule for instruments
six versus five instruments	The single most-tested numerical fact here
unity in difference	The evaluative sentence examiners reward
economy versus fidelity to the phenomenon	Frames the dispute philosophically

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The internal division of Mīmāṃsā is systematic: a single methodological difference between admitting and economising generates the whole grid of Bhāṭṭa-Prābhākara disagreements. **Named evidence.** Kumārila's *Ślokaṇvārttika* admits non-cognition as a sixth instrument, treats absence as a real content with a counterpositive, and posits knownness as a property of the cognised object; Prabhākara's *Brhātī* declines each posit, explaining absence by perception of the bare locus and cognition by its own self-luminosity in the threefold awareness. **Analysis.** Read together, the two systems show that the disputes are not independent: admitting non-cognition and admitting a genuinely false cognition are the same instinct, and declining both is the same economy. This is why the sub-school label predicts the position on every other question, and why examiners can safely pair "Bhāṭṭa" with "anupalabdhi" or "Prabhākara" with "akhyāti" in a single clause and expect the rest to follow. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The instinct-level explanation is an analytical reconstruction, not a statement either thinker makes about himself; and leanness alone does not establish superiority, since Kumārila's standing reply is that a system must be as large as the phenomena it explains.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2022, Q7(a), 20 marks** - why Prabhākara and Kumārila differ on erroneous cognition *despite* sharing intrinsic validity. The "unity in difference" frame is the question's actual demand.
- **2024, Q5(d), 10 marks** and **2025, Q6(c), 15 marks** - both are explicitly Bhāṭṭa-versus-Prābhākara questions.
- **2023, Q6(b)** and **2021, Q6(c)** - both require you to know which sub-school owns the doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: **Prabhākara accepts five, not six.** This is the single most repeated Mīmāṃsā error.
2. ANALYSIS: Assigning threefold awareness to Bhāṭṭa or knownness to Prabhākara. They are exactly reversed.
3. ANALYSIS: Assuming that because Prabhākara affirms self-luminosity he must also be the one who admits more instruments. He affirms self-luminosity *because* it is the economical move.
4. ANALYSIS: Presenting the split as a sectarian schism. Both remain orthodox Mīmāṃsakas.
5. ANALYSIS: Treating "Bhāṭṭa" as a personal name. It names the school of Kumārila **Bhaṭṭa**.

RAPID REVISION

- One instinct, six consequences: instruments · absence · error · self-luminosity · semantics · motivation.

- Bhāṭṭa = 6, real absence, contrary apprehension, knownness, word-priority, fruit-motivation.
- Prābhākara = 5, bare locus, non-discrimination, threefold awareness, sentence-priority, command-motivation.
- Shared: Vedic authority, realism, unseen potency, intrinsic validity, irreducibility test.
- Say "unity in difference" once, explicitly.

SESSION 4 - INTRINSIC VALIDITY: THESIS, FOURFOLD FORMULATION AND THE ARGUMENT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A cognition does not arrive neutral and then wait for a certificate. It arrives already claiming to be true, and it keeps that claim unless something later defeats it. Truth is the default setting; falsity is a fault imported from outside.

Technical definition. Intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda) holds that a cognition is valid by its own very occurrence under normal causal conditions: the same conditions that generate the cognition generate its validity, and the cognition presents itself as trustworthy without a further validating cognition. **Invalidity (aprāmāṇya)** is extrinsic in both respects - it arises from a defect (**doṣa**) and becomes known through a sublating cognition (**bādhaka**), contradiction or practical failure.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Compare two legal systems. In the first, every person is guilty until a court proves them innocent. In the second, every person is innocent until a court proves them guilty. Both systems admit that guilty people exist; they differ about where the burden of proof sits before any court has spoken.

Mīmāṃsā runs the second system for cognitions. A cognition walks in with its rights intact. If you want to strip it of authority, *you* must produce the defect or the contradiction. And the reason Mīmāṃsā insists on this is not generosity. It is that in the first system no trial could ever begin, because the court's own cognitions would themselves be under suspicion, and so on without end.

VISUAL - THE FOURFOLD FORMULATION AND WHERE EACH SCHOOL STANDS

Every theory of validity must answer FOUR questions, not one:

	ORIGIN (utpatti) "what MAKES it so?"	ASCERTAINMENT (jñapti) "how is it KNOWN to be?"
VALIDITY (prāmāṇya)	MĪMĀṂSĀ: INTRINSIC same causes make the cognition and its truth	MĪMĀṂSĀ: INTRINSIC cognition presents itself as trustworthy, unaided
INVALIDITY (aprāmāṇya)	MĪMĀṂSĀ: EXTRINSIC needs a DEFECT (doṣa): bad light, distance, organ-damage, dream-state	MĪMĀṂSĀ: EXTRINSIC needs a DEFEATER (bādhaka) contradiction, correction, failure, defect-awareness

COMPARATIVE PLACEMENT (learn as a four-row strip)

MĪMĀṂSĀ	validity intrinsic	• invalidity extrinsic	<- the position under study
NYĀYA	validity extrinsic	• invalidity extrinsic	<- the chief rival
SĀMĀNYA	validity intrinsic	• invalidity intrinsic	<- agrees on half
BUDDHIST	validity extrinsic	• invalidity intrinsic	<- the exact mirror-image

(Sāṃkhya and Buddhist placements follow standard survey presentation.)

What the diagram shows: the doctrine is a claim about a two-by-two grid, and Mīmāṃsā occupies exactly one cell-pattern in it. Candidates who memorise only "validity is intrinsic" lose the marks that live in the other three cells - and lose the comparative strip that the 2025 question asks for by name.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **What the thesis is a thesis about.** It concerns the epistemic status with which a cognition

presents itself. ANALYSIS: It is *not* a claim about psychological confidence, and *not* a licence for dogmatic refusal to revise. It describes how a true cognition (**pramā**) initially functions.

2. **The core statement.** Every cognition carries *prima facie* validity unless and until defeated.

3. **The regress argument, in the school's own steps.**

(i) A cognition is meant to disclose an object. (ii) If every cognition needed another cognition to validate it, the validating cognition would itself need validation. (iii) That generates an infinite regress (**anavasthā**). (iv) To avoid the regress, some cognition must be accepted as valid without external validation. (v) The most economical view is that *each* cognition is *prima facie* valid on its own.

4. **The argument from lived practice.**

(vi) We in fact live by trusting cognitions unless a defeating condition appears. (vii) Practical life therefore confirms default trust rather than default doubt. (viii) Hence validity is intrinsic and invalidity adventitious. (ix) If later confirmation were required for *every* cognition, no first action could ever be rationally launched. (x) Therefore epistemic economy favours intrinsic validity. (xi) The burden of proof lies on the challenger, not on every fresh cognition.

5. **The presupposition that keeps it from collapsing into subjectivism.** FACT: The argument presupposes **realism**: cognitions are aimed at real objects and normally succeed in disclosing them, and normal causes tend toward truth rather than arbitrary fabrication. ANALYSIS: Without that background realism, "self-certification" would be exactly the vice critics accuse it of being. Mīmāṃsā wants object-directed cognition with default warrant, not a mind congratulating itself.

6. **The distinction that decides most answers.** ANALYSIS: **Intrinsic validity is not infallibilism.** It does not say every cognition is indefeasible; it says every cognition *begins* with *prima facie* authority. What is intrinsic is default validity, not guaranteed incorrigibility. This one sentence, written explicitly, is worth more than a paragraph of exposition.

7. **The worked example.** FACT: I see a pot on the floor. I do not suspend judgement pending a certificate; I walk around it, pick it up, or refer to it. Only if I later discover poor light, hallucination or contradiction do I revoke the cognition. The ordinary structure of experience already *is* the doctrine.

8. **Why the doctrine is central rather than incidental.** Mīmāṃsā must secure Vedic authority without God. If all validity were externally conferred, the Veda too would need an external certifier, and that certifier would need one. By making validity intrinsic, the school blocks scepticism at the starting point - and it does so with a general theory in which perceptual, inferential and verbal knowledge all participate alike. **The Veda is secure because cognition as such is secure.**

9. **Standing objection and standing reply.**

WRONG: *Objection*: if cognition is intrinsically valid, error should be impossible. FACT: *Reply*: error occurs when an **extrinsic defect** intervenes; intrinsic validity is only *prima facie* validity under normal conditions.

10. **Two further objections worth carrying into an answer.**

WRONG: *Intrinsic validity licenses gullibility*. FACT: It is defeasible and welcomes correction. WRONG: *Later correction shows the invalidity was already intrinsic*. FACT: It shows only that a previously unnoticed defect was operating. WRONG: *Why call a cognition valid before checking correspondence?* FACT: Because correspondence-checking must itself begin from some trusted cognition.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa, *Ślokaṇvārttika* - the classical Bhāṭṭa defence of intrinsic validity.
- FACT: Prabhākara Miśra, *Br̥hatī* - the Prābhākara defence, which reaches the same thesis by a route that never admits a false cognition at all (Session 11).
- FACT: The four-cell formulation of origin and ascertainment for validity and invalidity is the standard scholastic frame in which the doctrine is stated and compared.
- ANALYSIS: The Sāṃkhya (intrinsic-intrinsic) and Buddhist (extrinsic-intrinsic) placements are reported as they are standardly presented in survey literature; state them as the received comparison.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Intrinsic validity is Mīmāṃsā's refusal to let scepticism set the terms of the debate: it does not claim that cognition cannot be wrong, only that doubt is parasitic on a trust that must already be in place before any doubt can be raised.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya)	The thesis itself
origin (utpatti) / ascertainment (jñapti)	Shows you know it is a four-cell doctrine
defect (doṣa) / sublating cognition (bādhaka)	The two extrinsic routes to invalidity
infinite regress (anavasthā)	The argument's engine
defeasible default warrant	The precise English of the thesis
not infallibilism	The distinction that most answers omit
true cognition (pramā)	Correct technical name for the valid product

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's intrinsic validity is a thesis about the burden of proof in epistemology: a cognition is entitled to be believed on arrival, and it is invalidity, not validity, that must be earned from outside. **Named evidence.** Kumāṛila's *Ślokavārttika* argues that if each cognition required another for validation, the validator would require a validator and an infinite regress (**anavasthā**) would follow; the school accordingly assigns intrinsic status to both the origin and the ascertainment of validity, while assigning defect (**doṣa**) and defeater (**bādhaka**) to invalidity alone. **Analysis.** The argument is doubly powerful because it is simultaneously anti-sceptical and anti-regress: it explains why practical life can begin at all, and it removes the need for any external certifier - which is exactly what a school defending an authorless text requires, since no such certifier is available to it. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The thesis buys its strength by relocating the difficulty: everything now depends on being able to identify a genuine defect or defeater, and Nyāya's standing complaint is that Mīmāṃsā has not shown how default trust differs from credulity when no defeater happens to present itself. CAUTION: Whether the doctrine truly escapes circularity or merely moves it into the notions of "defect" and "defeater" remains contested.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2025, Q5(c), 10 marks** - the main points of difference between intrinsic and extrinsic validation; the four-cell grid *is* the answer's skeleton.
- **2018, Q8(a), 20 marks** - whether self-luminosity entails intrinsic validity; you must have the precise thesis before you can deny the entailment (Session 13).
- **2022, Q7(a), 20 marks** - how two schools that both accept intrinsic validity nonetheless split on error (Session 11).
- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - Vedic authority; this doctrine supplies half the mechanism.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Equating intrinsic validity with infallibility. It is *defeasible* default warrant.
2. ANALYSIS: Stating only the validity row and omitting the invalidity row. The doctrine is a pair.
3. ANALYSIS: Confusing intrinsic **validity** (svataḥ-prāmāṇya) with self-luminosity (svayamprakāśatva). Different questions, different answers (Session 13).
4. ANALYSIS: Attributing extrinsic validity to Buddhism *and* extrinsic invalidity to it. The standard Buddhist placement is extrinsic validity with **intrinsic** invalidity.
5. ANALYSIS: Forgetting the realism that the doctrine presupposes, and thereby making it sound like

self-congratulation.

RAPID REVISION

- Grid: validity intrinsic in origin *and* ascertainment; invalidity extrinsic in both.
- Engine: infinite regress (**anavasthā**) + lived default trust + epistemic economy.
- Presupposition: realism. Distinction: default warrant ≠ incorrigibility.
- Strip: Mīmāṃsā I/E · Nyāya E/E · Sāṃkhya I/I · Buddhist E/I.
- One-line trap-killer: "*prima facie* validity, not infallibility."

SESSION 5 - THE EXTRINSIC RIVAL, THE DREAM OBJECTION, AND THE COMPARATIVE STRIP

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Nyāya's answer to the same question is the opposite one: a cognition does not certify itself; you find out that it was true by acting on it successfully, or by a later cognition that agrees with it.

Technical definition. **Extrinsic validity (parataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda)** treats both the origin and the ascertainment of validity as extrinsic relative to the mere occurrence of the cognition. Its two classical routes of verification are **successful practical activity (pravṛtti-sāmarthya)** and **confirming later perception (saṃvādi-pratyakṣa)**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

You see water shimmering in the distance. Nyāya says: walk over, touch it, drink it. If the action succeeds, the cognition is certified. That is a perfectly sensible policy - it is roughly how laboratories and law courts operate.

Mīmāṃsā's reply is not that testing is bad. It is that testing cannot be what *makes* a cognition true, because you had to trust something in order to start walking. The very act that is supposed to confer validity presupposes validity already in place. Nyāya, says the Mīmāṃsaka, is quietly living on credit from a bank it claims not to have.

VISUAL - THE ATTACK, THE COUNTER-ATTACK AND THE DECISIVE DISTINCTION

NYĀYA'S TWO ROUTES

- (1) successful activity
(pravṛtti-sāmarthya) -->
"I drank it, so it was water"
- (2) confirming later perception
(saṃvādi-pratyakṣa) -->
"I touched it, so I saw right"

MĪMĀṂSĀ'S THREE COUNTER-MOVES

- (A) ACTION PRESUPPOSES TRUST
to act on a cognition is already to rely on it; Nyāya uses what it postpones
- (B) REGRESS RETURNS
if cognition-2 validates cognition-1, what validates cognition-2? and cognition-3?
- (C) THE DECISIVE DISTINCTION
VALIDITY ITSELF ≠ ASCERTAINMENT OF IT
later success can DISCLOSE or CONFIRM validity; it cannot GENERATE it

NYĀYA'S BEST SHOT - THE DREAM / MIRAGE OBJECTION

dreams and mirages arise spontaneously, feel entirely normal, and are FALSE



MĪMĀṂSĀ'S REPLY - "APPEARANCE OF NORMALCY IS NOT NORMALCY"

dream -> extrinsic defect: exhaustion, sleep-state, internal disturbance
mirage -> extrinsic defect: heated air, optical distortion
=> these cognitions do NOT arise from fully normal truth-producing conditions
=> the principle survives: cognition under genuinely normal conditions is valid

What the diagram shows: the dispute is not a clash of intuitions but a clash over one distinction. If validity and the ascertainment of validity are the same thing, Nyāya wins; if they come apart, Mīmāṃsā wins. Write that sentence and the comparison paragraph writes itself.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **State the rival fairly first.** Nyāya is the chief opponent on validity. In the contrast as it is taught, Nyāya holds that a cognition becomes accepted as valid by appeal to something outside itself - successful activity, or a later confirming perception.

2. The Mīmāṃsā criticism, in its seven steps.

(i) If action-success is needed before validity is granted, one must act before one is entitled to trust the cognition. (ii) But that action itself presupposes some trust already. (iii) So Nyāya secretly relies on what it officially postpones. (iv) If a later cognition validates the earlier one, a further cognition must validate the validator. (v) The regress returns. (vi) Therefore later success can at most *confirm or disclose* validity, not *generate* it. (vii) Mīmāṃsā accordingly separates **validity itself** from our reflective **ascertainment** of it - and that separation is what weakens Nyāya's challenge.

3. The dream and mirage objection, and why it is the strongest one.

WRONG: Dream-cognitions and mirage-cognitions arise spontaneously and feel normal to the subject, yet they are false. If normal-*looking* cognitions can be false, why privilege intrinsic validity? FACT: The Mīmāṃsā reply distinguishes *appearance* of normalcy from *actual* normalcy: in dreams there is a defect such as exhaustion, sleep-state or internal disturbance; in mirages there is heated air and optical distortion. These are abnormal cases and therefore do not falsify a thesis about cognition produced under genuinely normal conditions.

4. **Sāṃkhya: the ally that goes too far.** FACT: Sāṃkhya is commonly represented as taking both validity *and* invalidity to be intrinsic - truth and falsity are each disclosed from within cognition. Mīmāṃsā agrees with Sāṃkhya against Nyāya on the intrinsic side of validity, but refuses to make invalidity equally intrinsic: falsity does not self-announce at birth; it is discovered through later defeat.

5. **Buddhism: the exact mirror-image.** FACT: Buddhist epistemologists are often presented as taking validity to be extrinsic - tied to causal efficacy or successful function - and invalidity to be intrinsic, revealing itself in failure. FACT: Mīmāṃsā rejects the asymmetry with a sharp empirical point: **if falsity were intrinsic, illusion should announce itself as illusion immediately - but illusion deceives precisely because it does not.**

6. **Default trust as the structure of embodied life.** FACT: Human life would stop if every cognition had to wait for prior certification. Crossing a road, reading a page, recognising a friend, obeying an instruction - all presuppose immediate trust. Mīmāṃsā converts this practical inevitability into an epistemic principle: **doubt is parasitic upon a more basic trust.**

7. **The distinctions the examiner is checking.** FACT: Validity ≠ certainty. FACT: Intrinsic validity ≠ incorrigibility. FACT: Extrinsic invalidity means falsity arises from an external defect, not that error is impossible. FACT: Later confirmation is not the *source* of truth but one way of detecting correction or stability.

8. **Where the pressure genuinely remains.** ANALYSIS: Nyāya can press that Mīmāṃsā has drawn the line between warranted default trust and mere credulity by *stipulation*: the defect is invoked whenever the cognition turns out false, which risks making "abnormal conditions" a label applied after the fact. A critical answer should record this rather than declare a knockout.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The two Nyāya verification routes, **pravṛtti-sāmarthya** and **saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**, are the standard pair cited in the contrast.
- FACT: Kumāṛila's regress objection and the validity/ascertainment distinction are the Bhāṭṭa line's central replies.
- FACT: The dream-mirage objection with the defect-based reply is the canonical exchange.
- ANALYSIS: Sāṃkhya's intrinsic-intrinsic and the Buddhist extrinsic-intrinsic placements are reported as standard survey presentation rather than as the last word on either school.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Nyāya's test is a test of our knowledge that a cognition was valid, not of the validity it already had; once that distinction is drawn, successful action turns out to be evidence of truth rather than its manufacture - and the regress Nyāya feared reappears on its own side of the argument.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
extrinsic validity (parataḥ-prāmānya)	Names the rival exactly
successful activity (pravṛtti-sāmarthya)	Nyāya's first route
confirming perception (saṃvādi-pratyakṣa)	Nyāya's second route
validity versus ascertainment of validity	The move that wins the argument
appearance of normalcy ≠ normalcy	The reply to dreams and mirages
doubt is parasitic on trust	The anti-sceptical thesis in one clause

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The Mīmāṃsā-Nyāya dispute over validation is decided by a single distinction between a cognition's validity and our subsequent ascertainment of it. **Named evidence.** Nyāya certifies cognition by successful activity (**pravṛtti-sāmarthya**) and by confirming perception (**saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**); Kumārila replies that acting on a cognition already presupposes trusting it, and that a validating cognition would itself need validation, restoring the infinite regress (**anavasthā**) Nyāya was meant to escape. **Analysis.** The reply does not deny that testing is epistemically useful; it re-describes what testing does. Confirmation discloses a validity the cognition possessed from the moment of its occurrence, which is why we can say a belief "turned out to have been true" rather than "became true" - and Nyāya's own practice of provisional reliance concedes the point in action. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The Mīmāṃsā victory is local rather than total: it shows that later success cannot *generate* validity, but it does not by itself show how to distinguish warranted default trust from credulity in cases where no defeater ever appears, which is where Nyāya's pressure continues.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2025, Q5(c), 10 marks** - "Delineate the main points of difference between intrinsic and extrinsic validation in classical Indian philosophy." This session and Session 4 are the whole answer; the four-school strip is what makes it "in classical Indian philosophy" rather than merely Mīmāṃsā-versus-Nyāya.
- **2018, Q8(a), 20 marks** - the Naiyāyika column of that three-column answer is built here.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Presenting Nyāya as denying that cognitions are ever true. It denies only that they certify themselves.
2. ANALYSIS: Forgetting that Nyāya has **two** routes, not one.
3. ANALYSIS: Reversing the Sāṃkhya and Buddhist placements - a very common slip.
4. ANALYSIS: Writing the dream objection without the defect-based reply, which converts a strong answer into a summary of the opponent.
5. ANALYSIS: Claiming Mīmāṃsā "refutes" Nyāya outright; the residual pressure about credulity is part of a critical answer.

RAPID REVISION

- Nyāya routes: successful activity · confirming perception.
- Mīmāṃsā counters: action presupposes trust · regress returns · validity ≠ ascertainment.
- Dream/mirage: appearance of normalcy is not normalcy; defect is extrinsic.
- Sāṃkhya I/I (ally, too far); Buddhist E/I (mirror-image, refuted by non-self-announcing illusion).
- Residual pressure: how is default trust distinguished from credulity?

SESSION 6 - THE MAP OF KNOWLEDGE-SOURCES: WHY SIX, WHY FIVE, AND WHAT ADMITS ONE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A list of knowledge-sources is not a list of topics. It is a list of structurally different ways a fresh true cognition can be produced. Mīmāṃsā's list is longer than its rivals' because it thinks at least two ways of knowing cannot be squeezed into the others without distortion.

Technical definition. A means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) is the operative source of a fresh true cognition; the resulting cognition is **pramā** or **pramiti**; its object-guided consequence is practical engagement. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā accepts **six**: perception (**pratyakṣa**), inference (**anumāna**), comparison (**upamāna**), verbal testimony (**śabda**), postulation (**arthāpatti**) and non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**). Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā accepts the first **five**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Imagine a workshop with a rule posted on the wall: *no new tool may be bought if an existing tool can do the job without damaging the work*. That single rule explains the whole disagreement about list-length across Indian philosophy. Sāṃkhya thinks three tools suffice. Nyāya thinks four. The Prābhākara thinks five. The Bhāṭṭa thinks six.

Nobody is counting casually, and nobody is inflating for prestige. The question in every case is whether a particular cognition - knowing that Devadatta eats at night, knowing that there is no pot on the table - can be produced by an existing tool *without remainder*. **Irreducibility**, not enthusiasm, is the admission test.

VISUAL - THE COMPARATIVE LIST AND THE TWO CONTESTED SEATS

	pratyakṣa	anumāna	upamāna	śabda	arthāpatti	anupalabdhi	
	perception	inference	compar.	testim.	postulation	non-cognition	
SĀMKNHYA							= 3
NYĀYA							= 4
PRĀBHĀKARA							= 5
BHĀṬṬA							= 6

+---- THE TWO SEATS BY WHICH ----+
MĪMĀMSĀ EXCEEDS NYĀYA

THE ADMISSION RULE (shared by both sub-schools)

Admit a new instrument ONLY where a type of knowledge cannot be reduced to another instrument WITHOUT REMAINDER or WITHOUT CIRCULARITY.
perception directly given objects
inference sign-based mediated knowledge
testimony verbally transmitted content
comparison resemblance-based identification
postulation resolves EXPLANATORY TENSION among known facts
non-cognition discloses ABSENCE under fitness conditions
▲
neither of these two arises through signhood
or through positive direct perception => irreducible

AND ONE FAMOUS EXCLUSION: MEMORY (smṛti) is NOT on any list - it reproduces, and a pramāṇa must produce a FRESH cognition (novelty, anadhigatatva).

What the diagram shows: three facts in one frame - the comparative counts, the exact two seats that distinguish Mīmāṃsā, and the admission rule that justifies them. The fourth fact, memory's exclusion, sits at the bottom because it is the negative application of the same rule and is separately examined in Session 8.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Why enumeration matters at all.** A list of instruments is a map of irreducible

knowledge-sources. Schools differ because they disagree about whether a type of cognition can be reduced to another. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā is therefore not "generous"; it is *defending irreducibility*.

2. **The one-line definitions you must be able to give.**

FACT: **Perception**: immediate knowledge produced by sense-object contact. FACT: **Inference**: mediate knowledge arising from a sign through known concomitance. FACT: **Comparison**: fresh knowledge that a previously known but

now absent object is similar to a presently perceived object. FACT: **Verbal testimony**: valid verbal testimony, especially Vedic testimony regarding duty. FACT: **Postulation**: necessary postulation of an unseen fact to reconcile incompatible known facts. FACT: **Non-cognition**: knowledge of absence through non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present.

3. The justification argument, in eight steps.

(i) Perception handles directly given objects. (ii) Inference handles sign-based mediated knowledge. (iii) Testimony handles verbally transmitted content. (iv) Comparison handles resemblance-based identification. (v) Yet some cognitions arise neither through signhood nor through positive direct perception. (vi) Postulation resolves contradiction-like tension among known facts. (vii) Absence-cognition, for Bhāṭṭa, discloses what is *not* there under proper conditions. (viii) If these cannot be reduced without circularity, they deserve independent status.

4. **What the list is not a list of.** ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā is not multiplying faculties psychologically. It is distinguishing **logical structures of knowing**. An instrument is identified not by its topic but by *the way the cognition is generated*.

5. **The three-term vocabulary you should use precisely.** FACT: The **instrument (pramāṇa)** is the operative source; the **true cognition (pramā / pramiti)** is what it produces; **successful action (pravṛtti-sāmarthya)** is the object-guided consequence. Successful action may *confirm* correspondence but, on Mīmāṃsā's view, does not manufacture validity after the cognition has arisen - which is precisely how this session connects back to Session 5.

6. **The link that earns marks in "knowledge of knowledge" questions.** ANALYSIS: Once instrument, product and confirmation are separated, the sub-school split becomes intelligible: Prābhākara says the cognitive episode manifests knower, known and knowing together; Bhāṭṭa infers the cognition from the object's acquired knownness. The three-term distinction is the bridge from Session 6 to Session 12.

7. **The summary formula.** FACT: Bhāṭṭa = six. FACT: Prābhākara = five. FACT: The difference turns on **non-cognition**. FACT: The whole list is governed by **irreducibility**, not by inflation.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The comparative table Sāṃkhya 3 / Nyāya 4 / Prābhākara 5 / Bhāṭṭa 6 is the canonical grid.
- FACT: Kumāṛila's admission of **anupalabdhi** and both sub-schools' admission of **arthāpatti** are the two seats by which Mīmāṃsā exceeds Nyāya's fourfold list.
- FACT: The **pramāṇa / pramā / pravṛtti-sāmarthya** three-term distinction is owner-stated and is the correct technical vocabulary.
- ANALYSIS: Later Advaita lists also run to six; do not use that to blur the Mīmāṃsā-specific argument for the two extra seats.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā's longer list of knowledge-sources is not epistemic generosity but epistemic honesty: it refuses to call a cognition "inference" merely because inference is already on the list, and it pays for that refusal with two extra entries it can independently justify.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)	The unit being counted
true cognition (pramā / pramiti)	The product, distinguished from the means
irreducibility test	The rule that licenses the count
six for Bhāṭṭa, five for Prābhākara	The single most-tested numerical fact
the two extra seats: postulation and non-cognition	Where Mīmāṃsā exceeds Nyāya
novelty (anadhigatatva)	Why memory is excluded

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's enumeration of knowledge-sources is governed by a single admission rule, and the school's distinctive length follows from applying that rule honestly rather than from any taste for multiplicity. **Named evidence.** Against Sāṃkhya's three and Nyāya's four, the Prābhākara admits postulation (**arthāpatti**) as a fifth and Kumārila admits non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) as a sixth, because the cognition that Devadatta eats at night arises from explanatory tension rather than from a sign, and the cognition that no pot is on the table arises from qualified non-apprehension rather than from positive perception. **Analysis.** Because instruments are individuated by the *manner* in which the cognition is generated and not by subject matter, reduction must be resisted wherever the manner differs; and the same rule that admits two extra instruments simultaneously excludes memory, which reproduces rather than produces. The list is thus internally consistent in both directions. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: Nyāya and the Prābhākara reply that the rule is being applied too liberally - Nyāya to both extra seats and the Prābhākara to the sixth alone - so the count itself is philosophically contested and should be presented as a defended position rather than as a neutral fact about Indian epistemology.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2022, Q6(c), 15 marks** - establishing postulation as an *independent* instrument requires this session's admission rule before Session 9's specific arguments.
- **2023, Q6(b), 15 marks** - presenting non-cognition as a valid means requires the same frame.
- **2020, Q5(c)** and **2024, Q8(c)** - memory's exclusion is the negative use of the same rule.
- Any comparative question benefits from the four-school count strip in a single line.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: **Prābhākara accepts five.** Writing "Mīmāṃsā accepts six" without qualification is wrong for half the school.
2. ANALYSIS: Saying Mīmāṃsā "rejects inference." It rejects **reductionism about inference**, which is a different thesis (Session 7).
3. ANALYSIS: Treating the list as a psychology of faculties rather than a taxonomy of logical structures.
4. ANALYSIS: Putting memory on the list because it is often true and often useful.
5. ANALYSIS: Forgetting that comparison in Mīmāṃsā is *not* the Nyāya word-reference account (Session 7).

RAPID REVISION

- Counts: Sāṃkhya 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa 6.
- Extra seats: postulation (both sub-schools) and non-cognition (Bhāṭṭa only).
- Rule: admit only where reduction fails without remainder or without circularity.
- Vocabulary: instrument -> true cognition -> successful action; the last confirms, never creates.
- Memory excluded by the novelty condition (**anadhigatatva**).

SESSION 7 - PERCEPTION, INFERENCE, COMPARISON AND TESTIMONY AS MĪMĀṂSĀ STATES THEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The four instruments Mīmāṃsā shares with its rivals are not shared *identically*. Each carries a Mīmāṃsā-specific twist, and each twist is examinable: perception is realist and two-staged; inference is accepted but not allowed to swallow everything; comparison is defined by a *similarity* cognition rather than by learning a word; and testimony is split into a personal kind that can fail and an impersonal kind that cannot.

Technical definition. Perception (**pratyakṣa**) is immediate knowledge from sense-object contact, occurring first as **indeterminate perception** (**nirvikalpaka-pratyakṣa** / **ālocana-jñāna**) and then as **determinate perception** (**savikalpaka-pratyakṣa**). Inference (**anumāna**) is standard sign-based cognition through known concomitance (**vyāpti**). Comparison (**upamāna**) yields the new cognition that a remembered, presently absent object is similar to a

perceived one. Testimony (**śabda**) divides into **personal** (**pauruṣeya**) and **impersonal** (**apauruṣeya**), and by function into **fact-stating** (**siddhārtha-vākya**) and **action-enjoining** (**vidhāyaka-vākya**).

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Four familiar tools, four small but decisive modifications.

The first tool, perception, gets a two-stage handle: you first register *that something is there*, and only then register *what it is*. Mīmāṃsā insists the second stage unpacks what the first already held - it does not invent a false label.

The second tool, inference, is left almost untouched, which is itself the point: Mīmāṃsā has no quarrel with inference, only with the claim that all mediate knowledge *is* inference.

The third tool, comparison, is re-aimed. Nyāya uses it to learn what a word means. Mīmāṃsā uses it to learn that an absent remembered thing resembles a present perceived one. Getting this backwards is one of the most reliable ways to lose marks on this topic.

The fourth tool, testimony, is split down the middle: a human speaker can be ignorant, partial or forgetful, and an authorless text cannot. That single split is the hinge on which Session 16 turns.

VISUAL - THE FOUR SHARED INSTRUMENTS AND THEIR MĪMĀṂSĀ-SPECIFIC TWISTS

1. PERCEPTION (pratyakṣa) - realist, immediate, and TWO-STAGED
nirvikalpaka (indeterminate) --> savikalpaka (determinate)
"something is present" "this is a white moving cow"
(non-verbal, pre-classificatory) (qualified by class, quality, action, name)
=> the second stage INTERPRETS what was implicitly available; it does not FALSIFY it
=> this is the anti-Buddhist move: the given is not a bare unique particular
ANALYSIS: SUB-SCHOOL SPLIT INSIDE PERCEPTION: is the cognition itself revealed? see Session 12
2. INFERENCE (anumāna) - accepted in fully standard sign-based form
smoke seen + smoke-fire concomitance known --> fire inferred
=> Mīmāṃsā has NO general hostility to inference
=> it opposes only REDUCTIONISM ABOUT INFERENCE (i.e. "all mediate knowing is inferential")
3. COMPARISON (upamāna) - the most misreported instrument
MĪMĀṂSĀ: saw a cow earlier ► now perceives a wild ox (gavaya) ► NEW cognition:
"the previously seen cow is SIMILAR to this gavaya"
not perception (the cow is absent) · not memory (the similarity was not known before)
· not inference (no universal concomitance is used)
NYĀYA: prior testimony "a gavaya is like a cow" ► later perception ► learns the
WORD-OBJECT relation
DO NOT write the Nyāya mechanism as the Mīmāṃsā definition.
CAUTION: Śābara is sometimes read as allowing a wider analogical form (e.g. reasoning from
one's own experienced self to other selves); the similarity-cognition account is the
safe exam default.
4. TESTIMONY (śabda) - split by SOURCE and by FUNCTION
BY SOURCE: personal (pauruṣeya) - depends on a competent speaker; inherits speaker-defect
impersonal (apauruṣeya) - Vedic; intrinsically valid in the domain of duty
BY FUNCTION: fact-stating (siddhārtha-vākya) · action-enjoining (vidhāyaka-vākya)
Kumārila recognises the fact/injunction distinction while making injunction central;
Prabhākara more radically reads cognition and language through action-guidance.
=> Testimony here is NOT a fallback after perception fails: it is the ONLY route to duty.

What the diagram shows: what is shared and what is modified, instrument by instrument, with the two highest-frequency error sites flagged - the Nyāya comparison mechanism and the treatment of testimony as a second-best source.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Perception is shared, realist and immediate.** Both sub-schools accept it as the most basic disclosure of sensible objects. What they dispute is not the instrument but its *reflexive structure* - whether the cognition reveals itself along with the object (Session 12).
2. **The two stages of perception, and why they matter beyond perception.** FACT: Indeterminate perception is the first non-verbal awareness that an object is present, prior to explicit classification and predication. FACT: Determinate perception grasps the object as qualified by class, quality, action and name. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā treats the determinate stage as *interpretation of what was implicitly available*, not as the invention of an

unreal predicate - and that reading is the school's defence of realism against the Buddhist claim that perception delivers only a non-conceptual unique particular, and against any view on which classification necessarily falsifies the given. This anticipates Session 15's defence of real universals.

3. **Inference: accepted, and protected from its own imperialism.** FACT: Where smoke is seen and the smoke-fire concomitance is known, fire is inferred. The school has no general hostility to inference. ANALYSIS: Its distinctive move is only to deny that *all* mediate cognition is inferential - which is why an answer must never say "Mīmāṃsā opposes anumāna." It opposes reductionism about anumāna, and Sessions 9 and 10 are the two places where that opposition does real work.

4. **Comparison, stated correctly.** FACT: Having previously seen a cow, one later perceives a wild ox (**gavaya**) in the forest as similar to it; from the perceived similarity of the present wild ox to the remembered cow, one gains the new cognition "*the previously seen cow is similar to this gavaya.*" FACT: It is not perception, because the cow is not presently sensed; not memory, because its similarity to this new animal was not previously known; not inference, because no universal concomitance is used. ANALYSIS: The Nyāya contrast - learning the word-object relation from prior testimony - must not be written as the Mīmāṃsā definition. CAUTION: A wider analogical reading of Śābara exists; report it as a reading, and default to the similarity account.

5. **Testimony, and the reason it is dignified here.** FACT: In ordinary matters testimony depends on a competent source; in matters of duty the decisive verbal source is the Veda. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā therefore gives testimony a philosophical dignity it rarely receives elsewhere: **it is not a fallback after perception fails; it is the only route to supersensible duty.**

6. **The two classifications of testimony.** FACT: By source: personal testimony (**pauruṣeya-śabda**) depends on a competent human speaker and remains vulnerable to speaker-defect, whereas impersonal testimony (**apauruṣeya-śabda**) is Vedic and intrinsically valid in the supersensible domain of duty. FACT: By function: testimony may state an existent fact (**siddhārtha-vākya**) or enjoin action (**vidhāyaka-vākya**). FACT: Kumāṛila recognises the distinction while making injunction central to Vedic purpose; Prabhākara interprets cognition and language through action-guidance more radically still.

7. **Where this session hands off.** The personal/impersonal split is the entry point to Session 16 (authorlessness); the fact/injunction split is the entry point to Session 17 (injunction theory); the two-stage perception is the entry point to Session 15 (universals).

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The indeterminate/determinate pair, with **ālocana-jñāna** as the alternative name for the first stage and "*this is a white moving cow*" as the standard illustration of the second.
- FACT: The wild-ox (**gavaya**) case, stated in the Mīmāṃsā similarity form and expressly distinguished from the Nyāya word-reference form.
- FACT: The fourfold testimony grid: personal/impersonal by source, fact-stating/action-enjoining by function, with Kumāṛila and Prabhākara positioned on it.
- CAUTION: The wider analogical reading of Śābara on comparison is reported as a possible reading, not as the school's settled definition.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā keeps every instrument its rivals keep, and quietly re-tunes each one: perception is allowed two stages so that classification does not become falsification, inference is honoured but forbidden to annex its neighbours, comparison is redefined around similarity rather than vocabulary, and testimony is promoted from a convenience to the sole competent witness of duty.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
indeterminate (nirvikalpaka) / determinate (savikalpaka)	The two-stage realism
wild ox (gavaya) similarity-cognition	The correct comparison mechanism
personal (pauruṣeya) / impersonal (apauruṣeya) testimony	The split that grounds Vedic authority
fact-stating (siddhārtha) / action-enjoining (vidhāyaka)	The functional split
anti-reductionism about inference	Prevents the "Mīmāṃsā rejects inference" error
concomitance (vyāpti)	Needed to state what inference requires and postulation lacks

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The four instruments Mīmāṃsā shares with its rivals are each modified in ways that serve the school's realism and its defence of Vedic authority. **Named evidence.** Perception is analysed into an indeterminate stage (**nirvikalpaka**) and a determinate stage (**savikalpaka**) in which the object appears as qualified by class, quality, action and name; comparison is defined by the new cognition that a remembered cow is similar to a perceived wild ox (**gavaya**) rather than by learning a word's reference as in Nyāya; and testimony is divided into personal (**pauruṣeya**) and impersonal (**apauruṣeya**) sources. **Analysis.** Each modification is doing work elsewhere in the system: the two-stage account of perception blocks the inference from "classification is conceptual" to "classification is false"; the similarity account of comparison keeps a genuinely non-inferential form of knowing on the list; and the personal/impersonal split isolates exactly the defect-locus that authorlessness will later be used to eliminate. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The modifications are not free: the realist reading of determinate perception is contested by Buddhist epistemologists who deny real universals, and CAUTION: the wider analogical reading of Śābara's comparison shows that even the school's own textual base is not uniform on the point.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2023, Q8(c), 15 marks** - universals or particulars; the two-stage perception is the epistemological support for Session 15's semantic answer.
- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - Vedic authority; the personal/impersonal split is the first move.
- Comparison and inference appear as supporting content in any question that asks why postulation or non-cognition cannot be reduced.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing the **Nyāya** comparison mechanism as Mīmāṃsā's. The single highest-yield trap in this session.
2. ANALYSIS: Saying Mīmāṃsā rejects or distrusts inference.
3. ANALYSIS: Treating determinate perception as a falsifying overlay on a pure given.
4. ANALYSIS: Treating testimony as an inferior, last-resort instrument.
5. ANALYSIS: Collapsing the source-split and the function-split into one classification; they are two independent cuts across testimony.

RAPID REVISION

- Perception: two stages; determinate interprets, does not invent.
- Inference: fully accepted; only reductionism about it is refused.
- Comparison: remembered cow <-> perceived wild ox; **similarity** cognition, not word-learning.
- Testimony: personal vs impersonal (source); fact-stating vs action-enjoining (function).
- Testimony is the *only* competent instrument for duty, not a fallback.

SESSION 8 - WHY MEMORY IS NOT A MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Remembering is not knowing-afresh. When you recall yesterday's temple visit, no new object is being disclosed to you; an old disclosure is being replayed. Mīmāṃsā, and Nyāya with it, therefore refuse memory a place among the instruments of valid knowledge - not because memory is unreliable, but because it is not *productive*.

Technical definition. Memory (*smṛti*) depends on a prior cognition and its latent impression (*saṃskāra*) and reproduces an already-cognised content. It therefore fails the **novelty condition** (*anadhigatatva*) that a means of valid knowledge must satisfy: a **pramāṇa** must generate a *fresh* true cognition of an object not already known through that route.

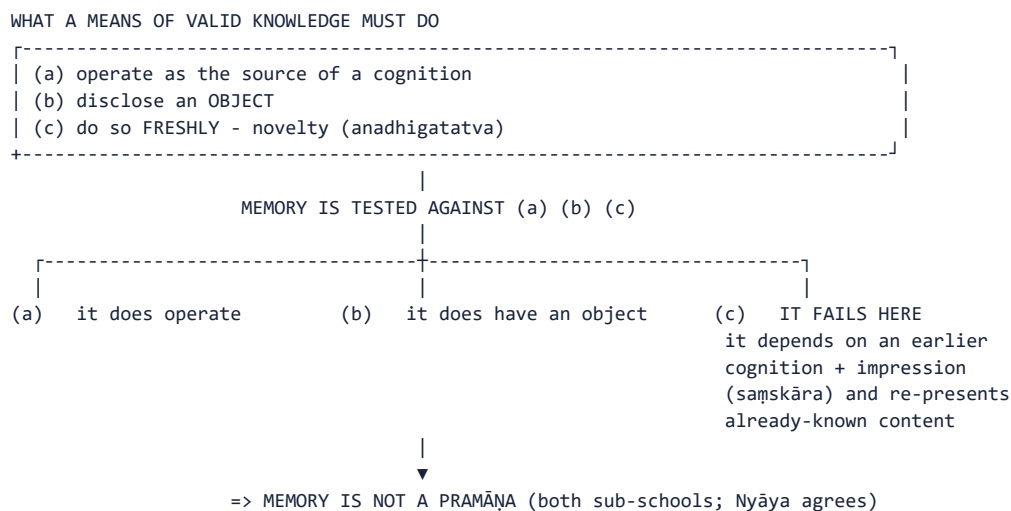
SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Two people bring you information about a room down the corridor. The first has just walked in, looked around, and come back. The second has never been today, but remembers what the room looked like last week and repeats it.

Both may be telling you the truth. Both may be useful. But only the first has *found something out*. The second has retrieved a finding. Mīmāṃsā's rule is that the title "means of valid knowledge" belongs to finding-out, not to retrieval - and it applies that rule even when the retrieval is perfectly accurate and even when it successfully guides action.

ANALYSIS: Notice the shape of the argument. It is not "memory often errs." That would make memory a *defective* instrument. The claim is stronger and cleaner: memory is not an instrument of that kind at all, because it does not do the job by which the kind is defined.

VISUAL - THE NOVELTY CONDITION AND WHO AGREES ABOUT IT



PRĀBHĀKARA'S FIVE STEPS

1. a *pramāṇa* must generate NEW cognition
2. memory depends on an earlier cognition and a latent impression
3. it reproduces old content
4. it does not reveal a new object as presently known
5. it is not a *pramāṇa*

NYĀYA'S CONCURRENCE

- memory presents what was already known
 - it is re-presentation, not fresh disclosure
 - hence not a *pramāṇa*
- => THIS IS WHY THE 2024 PAPER PAIRS
"the Prābhākaras AND the Naiyāyikas"
IN ONE QUESTION

ANALYSIS: WHAT THE EXCLUSION DOES NOT SAY

memory may be TRUE • memory may be USEFUL • memory may GUIDE ACTION successfully
- but usefulness is not enough for the title; NOVEL VALID DISCLOSURE is required.

ANALYSIS: AND WHERE MEMORY STILL DOES REAL WORK IN THE SYSTEM

comparison (*upamāna*) uses a remembered cow • non-discrimination error (*akhyāti*) uses a remembered silver • sentence-comprehension uses memory of the ordered series of sounds
=> memory is a working COMPONENT of cognitive life; it is simply not an INSTRUMENT.

What the diagram shows: the exclusion is a precise verdict on one of three conditions, not a character assassination - and the bottom panel prevents the common over-correction in which a candidate, having learned that memory is not a

pramāṇa, then writes memory out of the system altogether.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The thesis.** FACT: Memory is not a means of valid knowledge because it does not produce fresh object-knowledge.

2. **The Prābhākara argument, in the owner's five steps.**

(i) A means of valid knowledge must generate a new cognition of an object. (ii) Memory depends on an earlier cognition and a latent impression. (iii) It reproduces old content. (iv) It does not reveal a new object as presently known. (v) Therefore it is not a means of valid knowledge.

3. **Nyāya agrees, and this agreement is examinable.** FACT: Memory presents what was already known; it is re-presentation rather than fresh disclosure. ANALYSIS: This convergence is why the 2024 paper could legitimately pair "the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas" in a single question: on *this* issue the two rivals stand together, even though they are opposed on intrinsic validity, on error and on how cognition is known.

4. **The distinction that must be stated explicitly.** FACT: Memory may be true. FACT: It may be useful. FACT: It may guide action. ANALYSIS: But usefulness is not enough for the title of instrument; **novel valid disclosure is required.**

5. **The worked example.** FACT: Seeing a temple now is perception. FACT: Recalling yesterday's visit is memory. FACT: The latter is not new knowledge *of the temple*.

6. **Standing objection and reply.**

WRONG: *Objection:* memory can be the basis of successful conduct; why deny it the title? FACT: *Reply:* because an instrument is defined by the production of fresh knowledge, not by practical utility.

7. **The technical name for the condition.** FACT: The requirement is **novelty (anadhigatatva)** - literally, not-already-ascertained. Writing this term converts a good answer into a precise one.

8. **Where memory nevertheless remains indispensable.** ANALYSIS: Comparison requires a *remembered* absent cow; the Prābhākara analysis of error requires a *remembered* silver; sentence-comprehension on the Bhāṭṭa account requires memory of the ordered series of phonemes. The exclusion is a verdict about instrument-status, not about cognitive irrelevance - and an answer that shows this awareness reads as controlled rather than mechanical.

9. **A qualification worth one sentence in a critical answer.** ANALYSIS: Because the exclusion is definitional, it can be accused of settling by stipulation a question that other traditions treat substantively; the Mīmāṃsā reply is that the definition is not arbitrary but tracks a real difference between disclosing and retrieving.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Prabhākara Miśra's five-step argument, as it is standardly presented.
- FACT: The Nyāya concurrence on memory as re-presentation, which the 2024 paper presupposes.
- FACT: The novelty condition, **anadhigatatva**, as the technical name of the failed requirement.
- FACT: The temple example, and the general rule that utility does not confer instrument-status.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Memory is excluded from the instruments of knowledge not because it is unreliable but because it is unoriginal: it can be perfectly true and still fail the one condition that makes a cognition an instrument's product rather than its echo.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
memory (smṛti)	The subject of the verdict
latent impression (saṃskāra)	What memory depends on
novelty (anadhigatatva)	The failed condition, named
re-presentation, not fresh disclosure	The precise English formula
Prābhākara-Nyāya convergence	What the 2024 question is built on
utility ≠ instrument-status	The distinction most answers omit

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā denies memory the status of a means of valid knowledge on structural grounds: memory reproduces a content already cognised and therefore fails the novelty condition. **Named evidence.** Prabhākara argues that an instrument must generate a new cognition of an object, that memory depends on an earlier cognition together with its latent impression (**saṃskāra**), and that it therefore only re-presents; Nyāya reaches the same verdict by the same route, which is why the 2024 paper could ask about the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas together. **Analysis.** The verdict is definitional rather than evaluative, and this is its strength: it allows Mīmāṃsā to concede everything a defender of memory might want to say - that memory is often true, frequently useful and regularly action-guiding - while still denying it the title, because the title tracks the production of fresh disclosure and nothing else. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The move is not costless: it makes instrument-status turn on a definition that a rival could contest, and it sits somewhat awkwardly with the fact that memory remains an indispensable *component* of comparison, of the Prābhākara analysis of error, and of ordinary sentence-comprehension.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2020, Q5(c), 10 marks** - "Why is memory not a valid knowledge according to Mīmāṃsā?" This session is the whole answer.

- **2024, Q8(c), 15 marks** - "On what grounds do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas reject memory as a source of knowledge?" The convergence paragraph is the question's actual demand.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Answering that memory is excluded because it is *unreliable*. That is the wrong reason and loses the point of the argument.
2. ANALYSIS: Omitting **anadhigatatva**, the term the question is quietly testing.
3. ANALYSIS: Failing to state the Nyāya agreement in the 2024 question, which explicitly names both schools.
4. ANALYSIS: Over-correcting by claiming memory plays no role in Mīmāṃsā cognition.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing the exclusion of memory with the exclusion of *testimony about the past*; testimony remains an instrument.

RAPID REVISION

- Rule: instrument = fresh disclosure. Memory = retrieval. => excluded.
- Term: **anadhigatatva** (novelty / not-already-ascertained).
- Five Prābhākara steps; Nyāya concurs => 2024 pairing.
- True + useful + action-guiding ≠ instrument.
- Memory still works inside comparison, error and sentence-comprehension.

SESSION 9 - POSTULATION: EXPLANATORY NECESSITY AS A SOURCE OF KNOWLEDGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Two things you already know refuse to sit together. Something must be added to make them consistent, and the addition is not a guess - it is forced. That forced addition is knowledge, and Mīmāṃsā gives it its own name.

Technical definition. Postulation (arthāpatti) is the necessary postulation of an unperceived fact in order to remove an incompatibility (**anupapatti**) between facts already known. It is compelled explanatory supplementation: neither arbitrary conjecture nor standard inference. It comes in two forms - **postulation from perceived facts (dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti)** and **postulation from heard words (śrutārthāpatti)**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

A friend is visibly putting on weight. You also know, from repeated observation, that he never eats during the day. Now hold both facts in your mind at once. They will not settle. Bodies do not thicken on nothing.

Notice what happens next in your own mind: you do not *deduce* that he eats at night from some rule you already possessed. You had no rule "all stout day-fasters eat at night." What actually happens is that the two facts press against each other, and the pressure itself produces the third fact. The knowledge arrives as the *only way to let the first two stand*.

ANALYSIS: That is the exact phenomenon Mīmāṃsā is naming. It is not "the best available guess." It is the supplement without which what you already accept becomes untenable.

VISUAL - THE STRUCTURE, THE CASE, AND THE THREE ARGUMENTS AGAINST REDUCTION

THE BARE STRUCTURE

Fact A is known
Fact B is known
A and B CANNOT stand together
 unless C is admitted
C is postulated
necessity = explanatory reconciliation

THE CANONICAL CASE (Devadatta)

1. Devadatta is stout (perception)
2. He does not eat by day (testimony / repeated observation)
3. stoutness total absence of nourishment
4. => explanatory TENSION
5. resolve it: he eats at ANOTHER time
6. minimal sufficient postulate: AT NIGHT
7. night-eating is NOT perceived here
8. NOT supplied by memory either
9. POSTULATED - otherwise the data are inexplicable

TWO FORMS

dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti (from perceived facts) - the Devadatta case above
śrutārthāpatti (from heard words) - supplies what an utterance needs to be coherent:
 ellipsis, contextual completion
=> both are EXPLANATORY NECESSITY; the difference is only where the tension starts.

===== WHY IT IS NOT INFERENCE (anumāna) - three independent arguments =====

- (1) NO INDEPENDENTLY ESTABLISHED CONCOMITANCE
inference needs vyāpti known BEFOREHAND. We possess no prior universal rule
"all stout non-day-eaters eat at night." The engine is not vyāpti.
- (2) THE DIRECTION OF REASONING DIFFERS
inference: observed SIGN --> unobserved SIGNIFIED ("this sign indicates that fact")
postulation: explanatory TENSION --> reconciling POSTULATE
("without that postulate, THESE facts are inexplicable")
- (3) NO SUBJECT / REASON / PROBANDUM STRUCTURE
inference parses into pakṣa · hetu · sādhyā. Postulation has no hetu sitting in a pakṣa;
it has a CLASH of accepted facts and a demanded supplementation.

===== THE NYĀYA REDUCTION AND THE CIRCULARITY REPLY =====

NYĀYA: hetu = fatness, sādhyā = eating; vyāpti = "whoever is fat eats"
MĪMĀṂSĀ: that vyāpti is not INDEPENDENTLY known. If you say it is known, it was learned
from lived cases by exactly the tension-driven move under dispute.
=> THE REDUCTION USES AS ITS PREMISE WHAT POSTULATION ALONE SUPPLIES => CIRCULAR.

What the diagram shows: the whole of a 15-mark answer in one frame - structure, canonical case, two forms, three arguments and the circularity reply. Reproduce the frame in the exam and the marks are already allocated.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The core structure, stated abstractly.** FACT: Fact A is known. Fact B is known. A and B cannot stand together unless C is admitted. Therefore C is postulated. **The necessity lies in explanatory reconciliation.**

2. **The canonical case worked in full.** FACT: I know Devadatta is stout - possibly through perception. FACT: I know he does not eat during the day - possibly through testimony or repeated observation. FACT: Stoutness is incompatible with the complete absence of nourishment. FACT: The two known facts therefore produce explanatory tension. FACT: To resolve it I must posit that he eats at another time; the natural and sufficient postulate is that he eats at night. FACT: That night-eating is not directly perceived in this case, and is not supplied by memory; it is postulated because otherwise the known data remain inexplicable.

3. **The presuppositions.** FACT: Bodily conditions have intelligible causes. FACT: Stoutness normally requires nourishment. FACT: Rational cognition seeks coherence among accepted facts.

4. **The distinction inside the case.** ANALYSIS: The reasoning does not begin from a sign like smoke; it begins from *tension between facts*. And the output is not merely "he eats," but the **minimally reconciling postulate**. That word "minimally" is doing real philosophical work: it is what stops postulation from licensing extravagant explanations.

5. **The two forms.** FACT: **From perceived facts (dṛṣṭārthāpatti):** the Devadatta case. FACT: **From heard words (śrutārthāpatti):** what is required to make an utterance meaningful or coherent, including ellipsis and contextual completion. ANALYSIS: Both are forms of explanatory necessity, not tentative hypothesis; the distinction concerns only whether the initiating tension arises from perceived facts or from verbal material.

6. **The three arguments against reduction to inference.** FACT: *First - no independently established concomitance.* In inference the relation between reason (**hetu**) and probandum (**sādhya**) must be known beforehand. In postulation no independently established universal concomitance drives the transition; we do not already possess the rule "all stout non-day-eaters eat at night." The cognition arises because the facts would otherwise conflict. Its engine is not **vyāpti**. FACT: *Second - the direction of reasoning differs.* Inference moves from observed sign to unobserved signified. Postulation moves from explanatory tension to reconciling postulate. The logic is not "this sign indicates that fact" but "without that postulate, these facts are inexplicable." FACT: *Third - no subject/reason/probandum structure.* Standard inference parses into **pakṣa**, **hetu** and **sādhya**. Postulation lacks that form: there is no identified reason present in a subject from which a probandum is derived; there is a clash of accepted facts and a demanded supplementation.

7. **The Nyāya reduction and the circularity reply.** WRONG: Nyāya says fatness is the reason and eating the probandum. FACT: Mīmāṃsā replies that the proposed concomitance "whoever is fat eats" is not independently known; if one claims it is known, one is already relying on postulation-like reasoning from lived cases. FACT: **The reduction therefore uses as a premise exactly what postulation alone supplies, and is circular.**

8. **Postulation and modern explanatory reasoning.** ANALYSIS: Postulation resembles what modern philosophy calls inference to the best explanation, but the classical formulation is **stronger**: it is not "best among options," it is *the postulate without which the known facts remain untenable*. That necessity is why Mīmāṃsā grants it instrument-status - and stating this comparison, with the disanalogy attached, is the single best way to show comparative control in a 15-marker.

9. **Distinctions to write out.** FACT: Postulation ≠ mere guess. FACT: ≠ probabilistic hunch. FACT: ≠ standard inference. FACT: = explanatory postulation compelled by otherwise unresolved incompatibility.

10. **Two objections and their replies.** WRONG: *Any explanation could be relabelled postulation.* FACT: No - only postulations *necessary* to resolve an established incompatibility qualify. WRONG: *Why not reduce the whole process to hidden universal laws?* FACT: Because those universals are often themselves abstracted from the very explanatory move in question.

11. **The 2024 candidate case, worked in the Bhāṭṭa manner.** FACT: The candidate tops the examination. FACT: The candidate is never seen studying by day. FACT: Examination success is incompatible with no preparation at all. FACT: Therefore some unobserved preparation must be posited. FACT: The natural postulate is study at night

or otherwise outside observed daytime. ANALYSIS: The Nyāya framing - "wherever there is examination success there is preparation; this candidate has success; therefore this candidate had preparation" - misses the explanatory tension central to the original case and slides in a concomitance far too quickly.

12. **Where postulation reappears later in the system.** ANALYSIS: It is the instrument by which **unseen potency (apūrva)** is established (Session 17) and it supplies the *form* of the argument for authorlessness (Session 16). Postulation is thus not an epistemological ornament; it is load-bearing for the school's two most contested metaphysical posits.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The stout-Devadatta case in its nine steps - the canonical Indian illustration, to be used in almost every answer on this topic.
- FACT: The two forms, **dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti** and **śrutārthāpatti**.
- FACT: The three arguments against reduction, and the circularity reply to the Nyāya reduction.
- FACT: The 2024 candidate case as an applied Bhāṭṭa analysis, with the Nyāya inferential framing stated and criticised.
- FACT: Further example bank: a person never seen leaving home yet present at the office daily must leave at some unobserved hour. ANALYSIS: Use the canonical example first; modern examples only to illustrate.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Postulation is knowledge produced by the pressure of coherence rather than by the guidance of a sign: nothing points to Devadatta's night-eating, and yet nothing else will let his stoutness and his daytime fasting remain true together.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
postulation (arthāpatti)	The instrument itself
incompatibility (anupapatti)	The trigger condition, named
from perceived facts (dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti) / from heard words (śrutārthāpatti)	The two forms
concomitance (vyāpti)	What inference needs and postulation lacks
subject (pakṣa) · reason (hetu) · probandum (sādhya)	The structure postulation lacks
circular reduction	The reply that finishes the Nyāya attempt
minimally reconciling postulate	Prevents postulation from licensing extravagance

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Postulation is an independent means of valid knowledge because the cognition it produces is driven by explanatory incompatibility rather than by a previously established sign-relation. **Named evidence.** In the canonical case, stout Devadatta's daytime fasting and his stoutness cannot both stand unless night-eating is admitted; and Kumāriḷa's three arguments show that no prior concomitance such as "all stout non-day-eaters eat at night" is available, that the movement runs from tension to reconciliation rather than from sign to signified, and that no subject, reason and probandum can be identified in the case at all. **Analysis.** The Nyāya attempt to recover an inference by treating fatness as the reason therefore fails at its own first step, because the concomitance it needs - "whoever is fat eats" - is itself learned from lived cases by exactly the tension-driven move under dispute; the reduction consumes its own conclusion, and the charge of circularity is not rhetorical but structural. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: Nyāya can still press that the appeal to "explanatory necessity" is doing the work of a suppressed general premise, so the debate is best presented as a genuine disagreement about whether explanatory compulsion is epistemically basic, with Mīmāṃsā's stronger-than-modern formulation - necessity, not best-available - as its most defensible feature.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2022, Q6(c), 15 marks** - how Mīmāṃsakas refute the Nyāya reduction and establish postulation as independent. The three arguments plus the circularity reply *are* the answer.
- **2024, Q8(b), 15 marks** - the candidate who is never seen studying; the question asks for the Bhāṭṭa and the Naiyāyika explanations side by side, so both framings must be written.
- Supports **2019, Q5(e)** (the postulation-form of the authorlessness argument) and any question touching unseen potency.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Calling postulation "inference to the best explanation" without the disanalogy. The classical claim is *necessity*, not comparative merit.
2. ANALYSIS: Giving only one of the three arguments against reduction. All three are separable and all three are marked.
3. ANALYSIS: Forgetting the circularity reply, which is the move that actually defeats Nyāya.
4. ANALYSIS: Presenting only the modern candidate example and omitting Devadatta.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing the two forms, or treating verbal postulation as a mere sub-case of ellipsis-filling with no epistemic weight.
6. ANALYSIS: Writing that Prābhākara rejects postulation. He accepts it; it is his **fifth** instrument.

RAPID REVISION

- Structure: A + B incompatible without C => C postulated. Necessity = reconciliation.
- Case: stout Devadatta, no day-eating => night-eating. Minimal postulate only.
- Forms: perceived-fact and heard-word postulation.
- Three anti-reduction arguments: no prior concomitance · reversed direction · no subject/reason/probandum.
- Nyāya reduction => circular, because its concomitance is postulation-derived.
- Both sub-schools accept it; it is Mīmāṃsā's fifth instrument.

SESSION 10 - NON-COGNITION, AND THE REALITY OF ABSENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. You look at a well-lit table and know that the book is not there. That is a definite piece of knowledge, it guides what you do next, and it is not the same as merely failing to notice something. Kumārila says it needs its own instrument.

Technical definition. Non-cognition (anupalabdhi) is the independent means of knowing absence through the non-apprehension of what *would* be apprehended if present. The limiting condition is **fitness (yogyatā)**, so the instrument is precisely **yogyānupalabdhi** - non-apprehension of the *perceptible*. Its object, **absence (abhāva)**, is for Bhāṭṭa a real structured content with a **counterpositive (pratiyogin)**, the thing whose absence it is. ANALYSIS: The doctrine is characteristic of **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā; Prābhākara and Nyāya reject it as a separate instrument.**

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Three situations, and only one of them is knowledge of absence.

First: you glance at a cluttered desk in bad light and do not see your keys. You have not learned that the keys are absent. You have learned nothing.

Second: you stand in an empty room and wonder whether there are atoms in front of you. You do not perceive any. But atoms are not the sort of thing you would perceive even if present, so your non-perception tells you nothing about them either.

Third: you look at a bare, well-lit table from a normal distance with working eyes, and there is no pot. Here - and only here - your non-apprehension is informative, because *if a pot were there, you would have seen it*.

ANALYSIS: That conditional is the whole doctrine. **Fitness (yogyatā)** is what converts a non-event into a disclosure, and it is also what stops the doctrine from licensing every lazy inference from "I didn't see it" to "it isn't there."

VISUAL - THE FITNESS FILTER AND THE THREE-WAY DISPUTE

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[----- THE FITNESS FILTER (yogyatā) - all four must hold -----]
| • the absent object must be the KIND of thing perceivable if present
| • the LOCUS must be suitable
| • the SENSE ORGAN must be functioning
| • light, distance and attention must be PROPER
+-----]
|
| passes => yogyānupalabdhi => KNOWLEDGE OF ABSENCE
| fails  => mere non-noticing => NO KNOWLEDGE
"no pot on this bare, lit table before me"
"there are no atoms here" (atoms are not perceptible => filter fails)

```

===== KUMĀRILA'S SEVEN-STEP ARGUMENT =====

1. we DO know absences: "there is no pot on the table"
2. this cognition is DEFINITE and ACTION-GUIDING
3. not ordinary perception - perception gives POSITIVE content
4. not inference - inference requires a POSITIVE sign
5. not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case
6. an independent source is needed
7. that source is NON-COGNITION (anupalabdhi)

===== THE THREE-WAY DISPUTE =====

BHĀṬṬA absence (abhāva) is REAL, with a counterpositive (pratiyogin);
known by an INDEPENDENT instrument, anupalabdhi

PRĀBHĀKARA what is known is simply the LOCUS as unqualified by the absent object;
the bare-locus cognition already carries the negative differentiation;
no separate instrument - an ECONOMY thesis

NYĀYA accepts abhāva as a real category BUT says absence is DIRECTLY PERCEIVED:
"pot-absence-on-the-floor" is itself a perceptual object

=> NYĀYA AND PRĀBHĀKARA CONVERGE AGAINST BHĀṬṬA ON INDEPENDENCE - for different reasons.
ANALYSIS: Do not therefore say "Nyāya denies abhāva." Nyāya denies the separate INSTRUMENT.

===== WHY BHĀṬṬA REFUSES BOTH REDUCTIONS =====

to PERCEPTION: the table, its colour, shape and spread are perceptually given;
"absence of pot" is not a positive sensible datum of that kind.
Perceiving the empty table is ONE thing; cognising that the pot is
absent is ANOTHER.

to INFERENCE: inference needs a positive sign and known concomitance. If "not-seeing
the pot" is offered as the sign, one must explain why not-seeing has
evidentiary force - and that force ALREADY presupposes the relevance of
non-apprehension under fit conditions. => strained or circular.

What the diagram shows: the fitness filter that makes the doctrine respectable, the seven-step argument that establishes it, the exact three-way alignment of the schools, and the two refusals that hold the position together - everything a 15-mark answer on absence needs.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The thesis.** FACT: Non-cognition is the independent means of knowing absence through non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present.
2. **Kumārila's argument, in the owner's seven steps.**
 - (i) We do have knowledge of absence, such as "there is no pot on the table."
 - (ii) This cognition is definite and action-guiding.
 - (iii) It is not ordinary perception, because perception gives positive content.
 - (iv) It is not inference, because inference requires a positive sign.
 - (v) It is not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case.
 - (vi) Therefore an independent source is needed.
 - (vii) That source is **anupalabdhi**.
3. **The presupposition.** FACT: Absence is a genuine *object* of cognition; negative knowledge is not a mere linguistic shadow of positive perception.
4. **The distinction that keeps the doctrine honest.** ANALYSIS: Non-cognition is **not** simple ignorance and **not** "I failed to notice." It is a **determinate cognition that something is absent**.
5. **The fitness condition in full.** FACT: The absent object must be the kind of thing that would be perceived if present; the locus must be suitable; the sense organ must be functioning; conditions such as light, distance and attention must be proper. FACT: Only then does non-perception justify absence-cognition. FACT: Hence "no pot on the table" is knowable when the table is clearly before me, but "there are no atoms here" cannot be reached from non-perception, because atoms are not perceptible objects. ANALYSIS: **The doctrine is therefore carefully limited, and the limitation is itself the answer to the charge of subjectivism.**

6. **Why Bhāṭṭa denies reduction to perception.** FACT: Perception reveals what is positively present - table, colour, shape, spatial spread. FACT: "Absence of pot" is not itself a positive sensible datum of that kind. FACT: The perception of the empty table is one thing; the cognition that the pot is absent is another.

7. **Why Bhāṭṭa denies reduction to inference.** FACT: Inference requires a positive sign and known concomitance. FACT: In absence-cognition no independent positive sign is typically identified. FACT: If "not-seeing the pot" is offered as the sign, one must explain why not-seeing has evidentiary force - and that force already presupposes the relevance of non-apprehension under fit conditions. FACT: The inferential reduction is therefore either strained or circular.

8. **The Prābhākara rejection, stated fairly.** FACT: What we directly know is the locus. FACT: We perceive the table as bare, not occupied by the pot. FACT: No special faculty for "what is not there" need be posited. FACT: Therefore ordinary perception suffices. ANALYSIS: This is an **economy thesis**, not a denial that we know absences. WRONG: *Objection*: perception of a bare locus does not yet explain a determinate negative judgement. FACT: *Reply*: Prābhākara holds that the bare-locus cognition already carries the negative differentiation needed.

9. **The Nyāya rejection, stated precisely.** FACT: Nyāya also denies an independent non-cognition. FACT: It *accepts* absence (**abhāva**) as real but holds that absence is **directly perceived**: looking at the floor, I perceive "pot-absence-on-the-floor." ANALYSIS: So Nyāya and Prābhākara converge against Bhāṭṭa on *independence* while differing in their broader theories - and an answer that notes this convergence-with-divergence is doing exactly what "explain and examine" asks for.

10. **The ontological status of absence - the 2021 core.** FACT: Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā accepts **abhāva** as real. FACT: **It is not merely a feature of language.** FACT: **It has a counterpositive (pratiyogin)****, the entity whose absence is involved. FACT: Thus "absence of pot" is a *structured ontological content*, and negative cognition therefore has a real object.

11. **The intra-Mīmāṃsā debate on absence - the 2025 core.** FACT: Bhāṭṭa: absence is real and known by an independent instrument. FACT: Prābhākara: what is known is simply the locus as unqualified by the absent object; no separate instrument is needed. ANALYSIS: The 2025 question turns on precisely this divergence, and it must be answered as an *internal* Mīmāṃsā dispute, not as Mīmāṃsā versus Nyāya.

12. **Objections and replies.**

WRONG: *If absence is real, reality becomes overcrowded with negatives.* FACT: Bhāṭṭa accepts this ontological cost to preserve the reality of negative cognition. WRONG: *Non-perception is too subjective.* FACT: Only **yogyānupalabdhi** under fit conditions counts, never careless overlooking.

13. **The ordinary-life vindication.** FACT: Negative cognition is woven into daily life: no chalk on the tray, no key in the drawer, no bus at the stop. ANALYSIS: Philosophy must explain what everyday life constantly presupposes - and a school that could not account for these would be refuted by the tray, the drawer and the bus stop.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa's seven-step argument and his acceptance of real **abhāva** with a **pratiyogin**.
- FACT: The fitness condition **yogyānupalabdhi**, with the pot-on-the-table case and the atoms counter-case.
- FACT: Prābhākara's bare-locus economy thesis and its reply to the determinacy objection.
- FACT: Nyāya's perceptual account of absence - "pot-absence-on-the-floor" - and the resulting convergence with Prābhākara on independence.
- FACT: The decisive formula: **non-perception of what would be perceived if present**.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Kumārila's claim is not that nothing can be learned from failing to see; it is that something can be learned only when failing to see is *guaranteed to be informative* - and the entire doctrine of non-cognition is the specification of when that guarantee holds.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
non-cognition (anupalabdhi)	The instrument
fitness (yogyatā) / yogyānupalabdhi	The limiting condition that answers the main objection
absence (abhāva)	The object, and the 2021 question's subject
counterpositive (pratiyogin)	Shows absence is structured, not blank
bare locus, unqualified	Prabhākara's alternative, stated in his own terms
"pot-absence-on-the-floor"	Nyāya's perceptual formulation
non-perception of the perceptible	The decisive phrase

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā treats absence as a real object known by an independent instrument, because the determinate cognition of absence can be reduced neither to perception nor to inference without distortion or circularity. **Named evidence.** Kumārila argues that "there is no pot on the table" is definite and action-guiding, that perception delivers positive content while inference requires a positive sign, and that the resulting cognition therefore needs its own source - with **abhāva** accepted as real and structured by its counterpositive (**pratiyogin**), and with the fitness condition (**yogyānupalabdhi**) restricting the instrument to objects that would have been perceived if present. **Analysis.** The fitness condition is what converts the doctrine from a licence into a discipline: it explains why "no pot on this lit table" is knowledge while "no atoms here" is not, and it simultaneously defeats the inferential reduction, since any attempt to treat non-seeing as a sign must presuppose exactly the evidentiary force that fitness supplies. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The position is bought at an ontological price that Prabhākara and Nyāya both refuse to pay - the former by perceiving the bare locus, the latter by perceiving absence itself - so the honest verdict is that Bhāṭṭa preserves the phenomenology of negative cognition most faithfully while carrying the heaviest ontology.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2021, Q6(c), 15 marks** - the ontological status of absence and how it is known. Both halves are here: reality with a counterpositive, and non-cognition as the route.
- **2023, Q6(b), 15 marks** - Bhāṭṭa's view of non-cognition as a valid means of knowledge.
- **2025, Q6(c), 15 marks** - the Bhāṭṭa-Prabhākara debate on the nature of non-existence and its knowledge; answer it as an internal dispute.
- Supports **2022, Q6(c)**, since both extra instruments are defended by the same irreducibility logic.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Attributing non-cognition to Mīmāṃsā generally. It is **Bhāṭṭa's**; Prabhākara rejects it.
2. ANALYSIS: Saying Nyāya denies **abhāva**. Nyāya accepts absence and denies only the separate instrument.
3. ANALYSIS: Omitting the fitness condition, which is where the doctrine's respectability lives.
4. ANALYSIS: Describing non-cognition as "not noticing." It is a determinate positive verdict of absence.
5. ANALYSIS: Answering the 2025 question as Mīmāṃsā versus Nyāya rather than Bhāṭṭa versus Prabhākara.
6. ANALYSIS: Forgetting the **pratiyogin** in a question that asks about *ontological status*.

RAPID REVISION

- Formula: non-perception of what would be perceived if present.
- Filter: kind-perceptibility · suitable locus · working organ · proper light, distance, attention.
- Seven steps: we know absences -> definite -> not perception -> not inference -> not memory/comparison/ testimony -> independent source needed -> non-cognition.
- Bhāṭṭa: real absence + counterpositive + independent instrument.
- Prābhākara: bare locus, economy. Nyāya: absence directly perceived.
- Convergence: Nyāya + Prābhākara against Bhāṭṭa on independence only.

SESSION 11 - THEORIES OF ERROR, STATED PRECISELY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A piece of shell on the beach flashes in the sun and you reach for it, saying "silver." Something has gone wrong. But *what* exactly has gone wrong? Indian philosophy's four main answers to that question are four different theories of error, and Mīmāṃsā supplies two of them - one from each sub-school.

Technical definition. A **theory of error (khyāti-vāda)** explains what an erroneous cognition is and what its apparent object is. Prābhākara defends **non-apprehension of difference (akhyāti / vivekākhyāti)**; Bhāṭṭa defends **contrary apprehension (viparīta-khyāti)**; Nyāya defends **otherwise-apprehension (anyathā-khyāti)**; Advaita defends **indescribable-apprehension (anirvacanīya-khyāti)**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Ask four witnesses what happened on that beach.

Prābhākara: "Nothing false occurred. You truly perceived *this shining thing*, and you truly remembered *silver*. Your only failure was that you did not notice the two were different. There is no false cognition here to explain - only a missing discrimination."

Bhāṭṭa: "Something false did occur. Bad light and similar lustre made you cognise the shell **as** silver. That is one cognition, and it is wrong. But it is wrong because of a defect in the conditions, not because cognition is naturally unreliable."

Nyāya: "The silver is real - it exists elsewhere, in a shop or in memory's object - and it has been presented *here*, where it does not belong. Error is displacement."

Advaita: "The silver that appeared was neither real nor unreal; it was an indescribable something projected and later cancelled."

ANALYSIS: Note carefully: Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya are the pair most often conflated, because both admit a genuinely false cognition. The difference is what the "silver" is. For Bhāṭṭa it is a *wrong identification* of the shell; for Nyāya it is a *real object displaced from elsewhere*.

VISUAL - THE FOUR THEORIES, AND THE TWO THAT ARE ALWAYS CONFUSED

THE SHARED DATUM: a shell (nacre) lies before the subject, who says "this is silver" and reaches for it.

THEORY	SCHOOL	HOW SHELL-SILVER IS EXPLAINED	STATUS OF "SILVER"
akhyāti / vivekākhyāti (non-apprehension of difference)	PRĀBHĀKARA	TWO valid cognitions, not discriminated: perception of "this shining thing" + memory of silver	NO false silver at all
viparīta-khyāti (contrary apprehension)	BHĀṬYA	the shell is POSITIVELY miscognised AS silver; ONE erroneous cognition	really WRONG identification
anyathā-khyāti (otherwise-apprehension)	NYĀYA	REAL silver known elsewhere is presented HERE, wrongly	real, but DISPLACED
anirvacanīya-khyāti (indescribable-apprehension)	ADVAITA	an indescribable appearance is projected and sublated	NEITHER real nor unreal

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      ▲
      ▲
-- these two both admit a FALSE COGNITION, and are constantly conflated --
BHĀṬṬA: the object here is MISIDENTIFIED
NYĀYA : the object elsewhere is MISPLACED
=> "wrong identification" ≠ "right object, wrong location"

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===== HOW EACH MĪMĀṂSĀ THEORY PROTECTS INTRINSIC VALIDITY (the 2022 puzzle) =====

PRABHAKARA: protects EVERY CONSTITUENT COGNITION - perception valid, memory valid,
error located only in their conflation => no cognition is ever false
BHĀṬṬA : protects THE PRINCIPLE GOVERNING NORMAL COGNITION - falsity is admitted
but quarantined in DEFECT-RIDDEN conditions and known only extrinsically
=> SAME THESIS, TWO DEFENCE STRATEGIES. That is the whole answer to "in spite of
accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why do they differ?"

What the diagram shows: the four-column comparison every answer needs, the precise Bhāṭṭa-Nyāya distinction that most answers get wrong, and the reconciliation panel that answers the 2022 twenty-marker directly.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Why error is central rather than peripheral.** FACT: Any theory of intrinsic validity must explain illusion. If cognition is *prima facie* valid, what exactly goes wrong in false experience? ANALYSIS: The Mīmāṃsā theories of error are therefore not an appendix to the epistemology; they are its stress-test.

2. Prābhākara's non-apprehension of difference, in five steps.

(i) In the shell-silver illusion the subject validly perceives *this shining object here* - a perception of the shell's present appearance. (ii) The subject also recalls previously experienced silver, and that recollection is valid as memory. (iii) The mistake lies in the failure to distinguish these two cognitions. (iv) Because of this non-discrimination, one behaves as if the present object were silver. (v) There is no need to posit a separate false cognition over and above these two.

3. **The presupposition and the naming point.** FACT: Perception and memory can operate together in confused synthesis, and practical action can arise from such non-discrimination. ANALYSIS: **Akhyāti does not mean total non-apprehension.** It means non-apprehension of the *difference* between what is perceived and what is remembered - which is why the label **vivekākhyāti** ("non-apprehension of discrimination") is often more precise and is worth writing.

4. The standing objection to Prābhākara and his reply.

WRONG: *But the person says "this is silver," which sounds like one positive false judgement.* FACT: *Reply:* the utterance and the action can be explained by the fusion of two valid cognitions; a further false cognition is unnecessary. WRONG: *A second objection:* the theory underestimates the assertive force of illusion. FACT: *Reply:* non-discrimination can explain assertive behaviour without adding a false cognition.

5. **How this preserves intrinsic validity.** FACT: Every constituent cognition remains valid - the

presentational cognition of "this" is valid, the memory of silver is valid, and error lies only in their conflation. FACT: Therefore no individual cognition needs to be labelled false. ANALYSIS: This is Prābhākara's distinctive way of protecting the thesis: **he never has to admit a false cognition at all.**

6. Bhāṭṭa's contrary apprehension, in seven steps.

(i) In the shell-silver illusion the shell is before the subject. (ii) Due to bad light, distance, similarity of shine or sensory defect, the shell is miscognised. (iii) A single erroneous cognition arises: "this is silver." (iv) The cognition is false. (v) Its falsity, however, is due to *extrinsic defect*, not to cognition's intrinsic nature. (vi) Later correction occurs when the subject approaches and sees the shell clearly. (vii) Invalidity is then known extrinsically.

7. The presupposition and the distinction. FACT: False cognition is possible, but its cause lies in defect, not in the normal operation of cognition. ANALYSIS: Bhāṭṭa permits false cognition and does *not* thereby abandon intrinsic validity: validity belongs to cognition under normal conditions, whereas falsity belongs to defect-ridden conditions.

8. The standing objection to Bhāṭṭa and his reply.

WRONG: *If false cognition exists, why call validity intrinsic at all?* FACT: *Reply:* because falsity is not basic - it arises through abnormal interference and is recognised through later defeat. WRONG: *A second objection:* the theory grants too much to falsity. FACT: *Reply:* it grants falsehood only under abnormal conditions, thereby preserving the default truth of cognition.

9. The 2022 puzzle, resolved in four lines. FACT: Both accept intrinsic validity. FACT: They differ because they *locate error differently*. FACT: Prābhākara: no false cognition, only failure of discrimination. FACT: Bhāṭṭa: yes, a false cognition can occur, but only through defect and only known false extrinsically. ANALYSIS: **Hence one protects all constituent cognitions; the other protects the principle governing normal cognition.**

10. The rival theories, stated exactly. FACT: **Nyāya (anyathā-khyāti):** error involves the misplacement of a real object known elsewhere - the silver is real but displaced. FACT: **Advaita (anirvacanīya-khyāti):** the illusory object is neither fully real nor unreal, and is therefore indescribable. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā remains more epistemologically anchored and realist than either: it neither disperses the object elsewhere like Nyāya nor renders it metaphysically indeterminate like Advaita.

11. Why the behavioural fact matters. FACT: Reaching for the silver is the datum that both Mīmāṃsā theories must explain. FACT: Bhāṭṭa thinks a positive false judgement explains it best; Prābhākara thinks non-discrimination suffices. ANALYSIS: The debate therefore concerns philosophical psychology as much as epistemology, and saying so converts a descriptive answer into an analytical one.

12. Presuppositions common to both. FACT: Error must be explainable without collapsing trust in cognition. FACT: Memory and perception can interact. FACT: Defect and correction are intelligible features of cognitive life.

13. The critical verdict. WRONG: *Criticism:* both theories seem strained compared with common sense. FACT: *Reply:* they are sophisticated attempts to save default trust in cognition while accounting for illusion - Prābhākara by minimising false cognition, Bhāṭṭa by localising it in extrinsic defect. ANALYSIS: Report this as a graded verdict rather than as a knockout for either side.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The shell-silver (nacre-silver) case as the shared datum of all four theories.
- FACT: Prābhākara's five-step non-discrimination analysis, with **vivekākhyāti** as the more precise label.
- FACT: Kumārila's seven-step contrary-apprehension analysis, with defect and later correction.
- FACT: The four-theory contrast table: akhyāti (Prābhākara), viparīta-khyāti (Bhāṭṭa), anyathā-khyāti (Nyāya), anirvacanīya-khyāti (Advaita).
- FACT: The 2022 reconciliation: same thesis, two defence strategies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Prabhākara saves intrinsic validity by refusing to admit a false cognition anywhere, and Kumārila saves it by admitting one and then quarantining it in abnormal conditions; the disagreement is not about whether cognition may be trusted but about what price is worth paying to keep that trust intact.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
non-apprehension of difference (akhyāti / vivekākhyāti)	Prābhākara's theory, precisely named
contrary apprehension (viparīta-khyāti)	Bhāṭṭa's theory
otherwise-apprehension (anyathā-khyāti)	Nyāya's theory - must not be merged with Bhāṭṭa's
indescribable-apprehension (anirvacanīya-khyāti)	Advaita's theory
shell-silver (nacre-silver)	The shared datum
defect (doṣa) and later correction	How Bhāṭṭa keeps falsity extrinsic
conflation of two valid cognitions	The exact Prābhākara formula

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Prabhākara and Kumārila differ over erroneous cognition not despite their shared thesis of intrinsic validity but *because* of it: each is protecting that thesis, and each has chosen a different thing to protect. **Named evidence.** In the shell-silver case Prabhākara analyses the episode into a valid perception of "this shining thing" and a valid memory of silver whose difference is not apprehended, so that no false cognition is admitted at all; Kumārila admits a single erroneous cognition, "this is silver," and attributes it to defect - bad light, distance, similarity of lustre - with invalidity later disclosed by approaching and seeing the shell clearly. **Analysis.** The two strategies trade against each other precisely: Prabhākara keeps every cognition valid at the cost of explaining assertive illusion by a mere failure of discrimination, while Kumārila explains that assertive force straightforwardly at the cost of admitting a false cognition into a system built on default truth - and each cost is exactly what the other refuses to pay. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: Neither analysis is uncontested: the non-discrimination account is charged with underrating the positive force of "this is silver," and the contrary-apprehension account with granting too much to falsity; and both must be kept distinct from Nyāya's displacement theory, which admits a false cognition but locates its object elsewhere rather than misidentifying the one in front of the subject.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2022, Q7(a), 20 marks** - "In spite of accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why and how Prabhākara and Kumārila differ in their interpretation of erroneous cognition?" This session is the entire answer, and the reconciliation panel is its conclusion.
- Supports **2018, Q8(a)** and **2024, Q8(a)**, since both require a controlled Nyāya-Mīmāṃsā-Advaita comparison in which the error-theories often supply the sharpest contrast.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: **Equating Bhāṭṭa's viparīta-khyāti with Nyāya's anyathā-khyāti.** Both admit a false cognition, but Bhāṭṭa misidentifies *this* object while Nyāya displaces a *real object from elsewhere*. This is the single most valuable distinction in the session.
2. ANALYSIS: Translating **akhyāti** as "total non-apprehension." It is non-apprehension **of difference**.
3. ANALYSIS: Reversing the attributions - putting contrary apprehension on Prabhākara.
4. ANALYSIS: Writing only the two Mīmāṃsā theories when the question invites a four-column comparison.
5. ANALYSIS: Concluding that Bhāṭṭa abandons intrinsic validity because he admits false cognition.
6. ANALYSIS: Forgetting to answer the "*in spite of*" clause, which is the 2022 question's real demand.

RAPID REVISION

- Datum: shell-silver.
- Prābhākara akhyāti/vivekākhyāti: two valid cognitions, difference not apprehended; **no false cognition**.
- Bhāṭṭa viparīta-khyāti: one false cognition, caused by defect, corrected later.
- Nyāya anyathā-khyāti: real silver elsewhere, displaced here.
- Advaita anirvacanīya-khyāti: neither real nor unreal.
- 2022 answer: same thesis, two defence strategies - constituents versus principle.

SESSION 12 - HOW COGNITION IS KNOWN: THREEFOLD AWARENESS, KNOWNNESS, AFTER-COGNITION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. You know the pot. Fine. But how do you know *that you know* the pot? Is the knowing itself lit up in the act, or must you find it out afterwards - and if afterwards, by what route?

Technical definition. Prābhākara holds **threefold awareness (tripuṭī-saṃvit / tripuṭī-pratyakṣa)**: every cognition simultaneously reveals knower (**jñātṛ**), known (**jñeya**) and knowing (**jñāna**), because cognition is **self-luminous (svaprakāśa)**. Bhāṭṭa denies self-luminosity and holds that cognition is *inferred* from the object's acquired property of **knownness (jñātātā)**. Nyāya holds that cognition is known by a distinct second-order **after-cognition (anuvyavasāya)**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Three answers to the same question, and one very good analogy each.

Prābhākara: cognition is a **lamp**. A lamp does not need a second lamp to be seen; it shows itself in the very act of showing the room. So knowing shows itself in the very act of showing the pot.

Bhāṭṭa: cognition is a **painter**. A painter paints objects but does not paint himself. You do not see the painter; you see the painted canvas and conclude that a painter was here. Similarly, you find the pot now bearing the property of *having-been-known*, and from that you infer that a pot-cognition occurred.

Nyāya: cognition is an **event that a later observer reports**. You have the first-order cognition, and then a distinct inner awareness takes that cognition as its object: "I know the pot."

ANALYSIS: All three are trying to solve the same problem - how to stop an infinite regress of cognitions-of-cognitions - and each solves it differently. Say that once, and the comparison stops being a list and becomes an argument.

VISUAL - THREE SOLUTIONS TO ONE REGRESS

THE PROBLEM

if a cognition is NOT manifest in itself, another cognition must reveal it
... and that one needs a third ... and so on => INFINITE REGRESS

[--- PRĀBHĀKARA ---]			
ONE ACT, THREE DISCLOSURES	knower (jñātr)		
cognition is SELF-LUMINOUS	known (jñeya)		revealed TOGETHER, at once
(svaprakāśa)	knowing(jñāna)		
LAMP ANALOGY: a lamp reveals itself and other things at once			
REGRESS BLOCKED because no second cognition is ever required			
=> NO METACOGNITIVE GAP			
+-----			
[--- BHĀṬṬA ---]			
cognition is NOT self-luminous			
step 1: the object, having been cognised, acquires a NEW relational status			
step 2: that status is KNOWNNESS (jñātātā)			
step 3: observing the object's knownness, we INFER that a cognition occurred			
=> awareness of cognition is INFERENTIAL, not immediate			
PAINTER ANALOGY: it paints the world but not itself			
CONSEQUENCE: a temporal AND logical GAP - "I know" first, "I know that I know" after			
+-----			
[--- NYĀYA ---]			
first-order cognition reveals the object			
a LATER inner awareness takes that cognition as its OBJECT			
form: "I know the pot" / "I knew the pot" = AFTER-COGNITION (anuvyavasāya)			
=> neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness: SECOND-ORDER APPREHENSION			
=> REFLECTIVE GAP			
+-----			

SCHOOL	HOW COGNITION IS KNOWN	SELF-LUMINOUS	MECHANISM
PRĀBHĀKARA	simultaneously, in every cognition	YES	tripuṭi-saṃvit
BHĀṬṬA	inferred after the fact	NO	jñātātā => inference
NYĀYA	by a second-order cognition	NO	anuvyavasāya
no gap		inferential gap	reflective gap

What the diagram shows: the regress problem at the top, three engineered solutions in the middle, and the comparison table at the bottom. The three one-word gap-labels - none, inferential, reflective - are the fastest way to keep the theories apart under exam pressure.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- Why the issue arises at all.** FACT: Once object-knowledge is admitted, a second question appears: how is the cognition itself known? Is knowing self-revealing, inferred, or grasped in a second-order act? ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya diverge sharply here - and Mīmāṃsā diverges *internally*, which is what makes the topic examinable at twenty marks.
- Prābhākara's argument, in six steps.**
 - Cognition illuminates its object.
 - If cognition were not itself manifest, another cognition would be required to reveal it.
 - That second cognition would need a third, leading to regress.
 - Therefore cognition must reveal itself in the very act of revealing the object.
 - The subject is also disclosed as the one who knows.
 - Thus one act yields a threefold revelation: **jñātr, jñeya, jñāna**.
- Presupposition and precision.** FACT: Cognition is self-luminous (**svaprakāśa**); awareness need not wait for a reflective duplicate in order to be present to itself. ANALYSIS: This is **not** the claim that the self alone shines and the object is projected. It is the claim that cognition is immediately present *in* revealing the object - a distinction that separates Prābhākara from idealist readings.
- The lamp analogy and what it buys.** FACT: A lamp reveals itself and other things at once. FACT: The analogy supports epistemic economy and blocks the regress in one stroke.
- The standing objection to Prābhākara and his reply.**

WRONG: *Then why do we ever need reflective statements like "I know that I know"?* FACT: Reply: reflection is a later conceptual articulation of what was already manifest pre-reflectively. WRONG: *A second objection: simultaneous*

revelation confuses subject, object and cognition. FACT: *Reply*: they are simultaneously *disclosed*, not ontologically *collapsed*.

6. Bhāṭṭa's argument, in four steps.

(i) An object, after being cognised, stands in a new relation: it is now known. (ii) This new status is **jñātātā**. (iii) Observing the object's knownness, we infer that a cognition has occurred. (iv) Therefore awareness of cognition is inferential, not immediate.

7. **Presupposition, analogy and consequence.** FACT: Objects can bear relational properties grounded in cognition, and such properties can serve as inferential bases. FACT: Cognition is like a painter who paints objects but does not paint himself: it reveals the world but not itself directly, and its occurrence is established through what it leaves behind in the object. FACT: The consequence is a **temporal and logical gap** between first-order knowing and second-order awareness of that knowing: I know first; I know-that-I-know afterward.

8. The standing objection to Bhāṭṭa and his reply.

WRONG: *Knownness seems an unnecessary mysterious property.* FACT: *Reply*: Bhāṭṭa accepts this cost in order to avoid the stronger thesis of self-luminosity. WRONG: *A second objection*: ordinary self-awareness feels too immediate for inference. FACT: *Reply*: immediacy in experience need not equal non-inferential structure.

9. Nyāya's after-cognition, in four steps.

(i) First-order cognition reveals the object. (ii) A later inner awareness takes that cognition as object. (iii) It has the form "I know the pot" or "I knew the pot." (iv) Therefore knowing-that-I-know is neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness but second-order apprehension. WRONG: *Objection*: second-order awareness threatens regress. FACT: *Reply*: Nyāya treats the higher-order awareness as sufficient without endless repetition.

10. **The three-gap summary that keeps them apart.** FACT: Prābhākara = **no metacognitive gap**. FACT: Bhāṭṭa = **inferential gap**. FACT: Nyāya = **reflective second-order gap**. ANALYSIS: These are three distinct solutions to the same problem, and naming the problem - regress - is what turns a comparison into an argument.

11. **Why this session is worth twenty marks.** ANALYSIS: The 2024 question asks "How do I know that I know?" with all three schools named. The examiner is testing whether you can (a) state the regress problem, (b) give three mechanisms with their analogies, and (c) show that they are responses to one shared pressure rather than three unrelated opinions.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: Prabhākara's threefold awareness with the technical triad **jñātṛ / jñeya / jñāna**, and the lamp analogy.
- FACT: Kumārila's **jñātātā** with the painter analogy and the inferential structure it implies.
- FACT: Nyāya's **anuvyavasāya** in the form "I know the pot," with the reply that higher-order awareness need not repeat endlessly.
- FACT: The three-row comparison table of mechanism and self-luminosity.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

"How do I know that I know?" is not three separate doctrines but one regress met three ways: the Prābhākara stops it by letting cognition light itself, the Bhāṭṭa stops it by reading cognition off the mark it leaves on its object, and the Naiyāyika stops it by permitting exactly one further act of awareness and no more.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
threefold awareness (tripuṭī-saṃvīt)	Prābhākara's mechanism
knower / known / knowing (jñātṛ / jñeya / jñāna)	The technical triad
self-luminosity (svaprakāśa)	The property in dispute
knownness (jñātātā)	Bhāṭṭa's mechanism
after-cognition (anuvyavasāya)	Nyāya's mechanism
regress (anavasthā)	The shared problem
lamp / painter analogies	Two ready-made illustrations

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The three classical answers to how a cognition is known are best understood as three engineered stopping-points for a single regress, and they differ in where they allow the process to halt. **Named evidence.** Prabhākara argues that if cognition were not self-manifest a second cognition would be needed and a third after that, and concludes that one act discloses knower, known and knowing together, comparing cognition to a lamp; Kumārila denies self-luminosity and infers the cognition from the object's acquired knownness (**jñātātā**), comparing cognition to a painter who does not paint himself; Nyāya posits a distinct after-cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) of the form "I know the pot." **Analysis.** The three positions can therefore be ranked by the size of the gap they tolerate between knowing and knowing-that-one-knows: none for the Prābhākara, an inferential gap for the Bhāṭṭa, a reflective gap for the Naiyāyika - and each gap-size carries a cost, respectively the risk of conflating the three disclosed items, the positing of an obscure relational property, and the reappearance of the very regress the higher-order act was meant to stop. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: Each school has an answer to its own cost, so the honest verdict is that the dispute is unresolved rather than won: what a candidate can assert confidently is only that Kumārila's combination of non-self-luminous cognition with intrinsic validity is philosophically stable, which is what Session 13 exploits.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2024, Q8(a), 20 marks** - "How do I know that I know? Answer with reference to the Naiyāyikas, the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Prābhākaras." Three named columns; this session supplies all three.
- **2018, Q8(a), 20 marks** - the self-luminosity half of that question is established here and applied in Session 13.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Swapping the mechanisms: threefold awareness is **Prābhākara**, knownness is **Bhāṭṭa**.
2. ANALYSIS: Describing Nyāya as accepting self-luminosity. It denies it and supplies a higher-order act.
3. ANALYSIS: Presenting the three views as a list without naming the regress they are all answering.
4. ANALYSIS: Reading Prābhākara's threefold awareness as idealism - as if the object were merely projected.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing knownness (**jñātātā**) with knownness-as-truth; it is a relational status of the object, not a validity-conferring property.

RAPID REVISION

- Problem: regress of cognitions-of-cognitions.
- Prābhākara: self-luminous; one act discloses knower, known, knowing; **lamp**; no gap.
- Bhāṭṭa: not self-luminous; object acquires **knownness**; cognition inferred; **painter**; inferential gap.
- Nyāya: **after-cognition** "I know the pot"; reflective gap.
- Three gaps: none / inferential / reflective.

SESSION 13 - DOES SELF-LUMINOSITY ENTAIL INTRINSIC VALIDITY?

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. Two different questions are constantly run together. The first is *how does a cognition show up?* The second is *is a cognition entitled to be believed?* Showing up and being true are not the same thing, and the whole 2018 twenty-marker turns on keeping them apart.

Technical definition. **Self-luminosity** (*svayaṃprakāśatva* / *svaprakāśatva*) concerns whether cognition or consciousness is manifest without another cognition. **Intrinsic validity** (*svataḥ-prāmāṇya*) concerns whether a cognition is entitled to *prima facie* truth without external certification. They answer different questions - manifestation and truth - and therefore neither thesis follows from the other merely by definition.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Think of a witness in a courtroom. Two questions can be asked about him.

Question one: is he visible? Does he need someone else to point him out, or does he step forward himself?

Question two: is he to be believed? Does the court trust him until he is impeached, or must corroboration be produced first?

These questions plainly come apart. A witness can be perfectly visible and thoroughly untrustworthy; another can be difficult to locate and, once located, entirely credible.

ANALYSIS: Now the philosophical payoff. If someone claims that self-manifestation *entails* trustworthiness, you defeat the claim by producing a single case of one without the other. Indian philosophy supplies that case from *inside* Mīmāṃsā - and that is why the 2018 question, which looks like a three-school survey, actually has a decisive answer.

VISUAL - THE FOUR-SCHOOL GRID AND THE DECISIVE COUNTEREXAMPLE

TWO INDEPENDENT QUESTIONS

- Q1 MANIFESTATION : is cognition/consciousness self-luminous?
Q2 TRUTH-ENTITLEMENT : is validity intrinsic?

SCHOOL	Q1 SELF-LUMINOUS?	Q2 VALIDITY INTRINSIC?	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE 2018 ANSWER
NYĀYA	NO - known through a subsequent after-cognition (anuvyavasāya)	NO - truth is ascertained extrinsically	accepts NEITHER thesis
PRĀBHĀKARA MĪMĀṂSĀ	YES - one cognition manifests knower, known and knowing	YES	CONNECTS both theses
BHĀṬṬA MĪMĀṂSĀ	NO - cognition is inferred from acquired knownness (jñātātā)	YES	DECISIVE COUNTEREXAMPLE TO ENTAILMENT
ADVAITA VEDĀNTA	YES - fundamentally, of consciousness ITSELF (not merely of episodes)	at the empirical level, <i>prima facie</i> until SUBLATED	CONNECTS them inside a wider NON-DUAL theory

THE ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE

Kumārila = NOT self-luminous + intrinsically valid => self-luminosity is NOT NECESSARY for intrinsic validity => and since the two theses answer different questions, neither entails the other
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ANALYSIS: THE TRAP THE 2018 PAPER IS SETTING

Nyāya is NOT "self-luminous but extrinsically valid."
Nyāya DENIES self-luminosity and supplies a higher-order cognition instead.
Writing Nyāya into the wrong cell destroys the entire comparative grid.

What the diagram shows: a two-question grid, four schools placed in it, and the one cell - Bhāṭṭa - that settles the question by exhibiting the combination the entailment-thesis says is impossible.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

- State the two theses separately, in one sentence each.** FACT: Self-luminosity concerns how cognition manifests itself and/or its object. FACT: Intrinsic validity concerns a cognition's *prima facie* truth and action-guiding authority before a defeater appears.
- Establish that they are different questions.** FACT: One is about manifestation, the other about truth. ANALYSIS: Because they are different questions, no entailment can be read off from the definitions alone; an entailment would have to be *argued* for, and no school supplies such an argument.
- The four placements, stated exactly.**
FACT: **Nyāya**: cognition is known through a subsequent cognition (*anuvyavasāya*) - *not* self-luminous - and truth is ascertained extrinsically (*parataḥ-prāmānya*). It accepts neither thesis. FACT: **Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā**: one cognition manifests knower, known and knowing - self-luminous - and validity is intrinsic. It connects both theses. FACT: **Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā**: cognition is *not* self-luminous and is inferred from the object's acquired knownness (*jñātātā*), yet validity *is* intrinsic. **This is the decisive counterexample.** FACT: **Advaita Vedānta**: self-luminosity holds fundamentally of consciousness itself; at the empirical level cognition carries *prima facie* authority until sublated. It connects the two within a wider non-dual theory.
- The decisive move, stated for the examiner.** FACT: Kumārila's combination - non-self-luminous cognition together with intrinsic validity - shows most clearly that **self-luminosity does not entail intrinsic validity, and intrinsic validity does not require self-luminosity.** ANALYSIS: A single internal counterexample defeats a necessity-claim; you do not need to survey every school to settle the question, though the survey is what the question asks you to display.

5. **Why Advaita is included in the question at all.** ANALYSIS: Advaita extends self-luminosity from cognitive *episodes* to consciousness *as such*, which is a stronger and differently grounded thesis; and its account of validity is embedded in a doctrine of levels of reality and sublation. Including it shows that the two theses can be connected for reasons quite unlike Prābhākara's.

6. **The distinction that must not be lost in the writing.** ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā debates cognition-episodes and validity within a theory of instruments; Advaita debates consciousness and levels of reality. Using the same English word "self-luminous" for both is legitimate only if the difference of scope is stated.

7. **The standing objection and its reply.** CAUTION: *Objection*: intrinsic validity seems unable to explain error. FACT: *Reply*: falsity is extrinsically discovered through sublation or causal defect; cognition presents itself as valid until defeated. ANALYSIS: This links Session 13 back to Sessions 4 and 11, and a good 20-mark answer makes that link explicitly.

8. **The answer to the question as printed.** FACT: **No** - the admission of self-luminosity does not *necessarily* lead to the admission of intrinsic validity. The two doctrines are logically independent; they happen to travel together in Prābhākara and in Advaita, and they come apart in Bhāṭṭa, while Nyāya rejects both. ANALYSIS: State the verdict early and then justify it; a survey that never returns a verdict loses the "discuss" mark.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The four-row grid of self-luminosity against intrinsic validity across Nyāya, Prābhākara, Bhāṭṭa and Advaita.
- FACT: Kumāṛila's combination as the counterexample that disproves necessary entailment.
- FACT: Nyāya's **anuvyavasāya** as the reason Nyāya is placed in the "neither" row.
- ANALYSIS: Advaita's extension of self-luminosity to consciousness as such, with validity holding at the empirical level until sublation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Kumāṛila is the standing refutation of the entailment: he holds that a cognition cannot show itself and yet insists that it may be believed on arrival - which proves that being manifest and being credible are two properties, not one property under two names.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
self-luminosity (svayamprakāśatva)	The first thesis
intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇya)	The second thesis
manifestation versus truth-entitlement	The distinction that decides the question
knownness (jñātātā)	Why Bhāṭṭa is the counterexample
after-cognition (anuvyavasāya)	Why Nyāya is in the "neither" row
sublation (bādha)	Advaita's qualification of empirical validity
counterexample to necessary entailment	The verdict, in technical form

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. The admission of self-luminosity does not necessarily lead to the admission of intrinsic validity, because the two doctrines answer different questions and can be held separately. **Named evidence.** Nyāya denies both, holding that cognition is known by a subsequent after-cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) and that validity is ascertained extrinsically; Prābhākara affirms both; Advaita affirms both but grounds self-luminosity in consciousness as such and treats empirical validity as holding until sublation; and Kumārila affirms intrinsic validity while expressly denying self-luminosity, inferring the cognition from the object's acquired knownness (**jñātātā**). **Analysis.** The Bhāṭṭa position is therefore not one opinion among four but the logically decisive datum: a single actual case of intrinsic validity without self-luminosity is sufficient to refute a claim of necessity, and the survey of the other three schools serves to show that the pairing found in Prābhākara and Advaita is a substantive philosophical commitment rather than a definitional consequence. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The independence claim should not be over-read: nothing here shows that the two theses are *unrelated*, since a self-luminous cognition plainly makes intrinsic validity easier to defend, and Advaita's version connects them within a non-dual framework that Mīmāṃsā would reject for entirely separate reasons.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2018, Q8(a), 20 marks** - "Does the admission of Svayaṃprakāśavāda necessarily lead to the admission of Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda? Discuss after the Naiyāyikas, the Mīmāṃsakas and the Advaita Vedāntins." The grid and the counterexample are the complete answer.

- Supports **2025, Q5(c)** and **2024, Q8(a)**, both of which reuse the same distinctions.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Placing Nyāya as "self-luminous but extrinsically valid." Nyāya denies self-luminosity.
2. ANALYSIS: Treating "the Mīmāṃsakas" as one column. The question is decided *inside* Mīmāṃsā.
3. ANALYSIS: Using "self-luminous" for Advaita and for Prābhākara without noting the difference of scope - consciousness as such versus cognitive episodes.
4. ANALYSIS: Surveying the schools and never answering the "necessarily" in the question.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing sublation (Advaita's **bādhā**) with Mīmāṃsā's defeater (**bādhaka**) as if the two frameworks were identical.

RAPID REVISION

- Two questions: manifestation (self-luminosity) versus truth-entitlement (intrinsic validity).
- Nyāya: neither. Prābhākara: both. Advaita: both, at a deeper level. Bhāṭṭa: intrinsic validity

without self-luminosity.

- Bhāṭṭa is the counterexample => no necessary entailment, in either direction.
- Verdict first, then the grid, then the qualification.

SESSION 14 - SENTENCE-UNITY AND THE TWO RIVAL SEMANTICS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A sentence is many words, each apparently carrying its own meaning, and yet it produces *one* understanding. How? Two Mīmāṃsā answers: either the words mean things first and the meanings are joined afterwards, or the words mean things only *as already joined*.

Technical definition. The problem is **sentence-unity (ekavākyatā)**. Bhāṭṭa holds **connection-of-the-already-denoted (abhihitānvayavāda)**: each word first denotes its isolated meaning (**padārtha**) through its primary denotative power (**abhidhā**), and sentence-meaning arises through a secondary connecting operation, often explained as indirect signification (**lakṣaṇā**) or purport-power (**tātparya-śakti**). Prābhākara holds **denotation-of-the-connected (anvitābhidhānavāda)**: words denote their meanings only as already connected with the other meanings in the sentence.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Take a set of loose bricks and a wall.

Bhāṭṭa's picture: you have bricks first - "bring," "the," "cow" - each with a fixed shape it carries into every wall it ever joins. Building the wall is a further operation performed on already-shaped bricks. This explains beautifully why the same brick can appear in a thousand different walls without changing shape.

Prābhākara's picture: there are no loose bricks. What you actually encounter, always, is a wall. A child does not learn "cow" from a dictionary and later assemble it into a command; the child hears "*bring the cow*," watches someone bring a cow, and learns the word as *the-thing-to-be-brought*. The "brick" is an abstraction we make afterwards by comparing many walls.

ANALYSIS: Both are explaining the same phenomenon and both accept the same three conditions of sentence formation. The disagreement is entirely about **which unit is semantically primary** - and therefore about whether meaning is compositional or contextual at bottom.

VISUAL - THE SHARED CONDITIONS AND THE TWO ROUTES

===== SHARED BY BOTH SUB-SCHOOLS: THE CONDITIONS OF SENTENCE-UNITY =====			
CONDITION	MEANING	FAILURE CASE	WHY IT MATTERS
+ ākāṅkṣā (mutual expectancy)	words mutually REQUIRE completion	"Bring..." leaves an open expectation of WHAT is to be brought	explains why words lean toward each other
+ yogyatā (semantic fitness)	meanings must be semantically COMPATIBLE	"sprinkle with fire" is unfit in ordinary usage	blocks absurd constructions
+ sannidhi/āsatti (proximity, contiguity)	words must occur in proper PROXIMITY	words separated by unrelated discourse fail to cohere	protects Vedic sentence-boundaries
+ tātparya PROBLEM FOR (purport)	ANALYSIS: purport / intended thrust - added by [Nyāya adds]	works for HUMAN speech	ANALYSIS: AN AUTHORLESS VEDA

ANALYSIS: MĪMĀṂSĀ CANNOT ground Vedic meaning in a speaker's intention, because the Veda is authorless (apauruṣeya). "Purport" must therefore be located in TEXTUAL FORCE, CONTEXTUAL UNITY and INJUNCTIONAL FUNCTION - not in an intending author.

===== THE TWO ROUTES TO ONE MEANING =====

TEST SENTENCE: "svargakāmo yajeta" - "one desiring heaven should sacrifice"

BHĀṬṬA - abhihitānvayavāda "connection of the already denoted"	PRĀBHĀKARA - anvitābhidhānavāda "denotation of the connected"
step 1 each word denotes its ISOLATED meaning via abhidhā	there is NO step 1 of this kind
step 2 meanings are CONNECTED via lakṣaṇā / tātparya-śakti	words denote meanings ONLY AS CONNECTED with agent, action, object, context
PRIMARY UNIT = THE WORD sentence-meaning is DERIVATIVE	PRIMARY UNIT = THE SENTENCE word-meaning is grasped IN RELATION
STRENGTH: explains STABLE LEXICAL MEANING across contexts	STRENGTH: explains LANGUAGE-LEARNING (vyutpatti) and ACTION-GUIDANCE

ANALYSIS: two stages are LOGICAL, not a slow repeatable;

temporal sequence in consciousness | denies that their PRIMARY life is isolated

VERDICT LINE: Bhāṭṭa secures stable lexical meaning; Prābhākara secures contextual action-guidance.

What the diagram shows: three shared conditions plus one contested fourth, then the two routes set side by side with their strengths and their standard clarifications - which is exactly the shape a 10-mark "how do they differ" answer should take.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The problem, stated as Mīmāṃsā states it.** FACT: The central semantic problem is how a sentence made of many words, each apparently carrying its own meaning, yields one unified cognition called **ekavākyatā**. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā *must* solve this, because Vedic obligation is grasped through sentence-meaning and not through isolated word-meanings.

2. **Why the problem is not artificial.** FACT: The Veda works through meaningful sentences - injunctions, prohibitions, mantras, names, explanatory passages. FACT: An injunction cannot guide action unless its words form one determinate action-guiding meaning. FACT: Mere succession does not produce unity, since unrelated words can be uttered side by side. FACT: Therefore the tradition must specify the conditions under which a sequence of words becomes a single sentence. WRONG: *Objection*: ordinary people understand sentences instantly; a technical theory seems unnecessary. FACT: *Reply*: Mīmāṃsā is explaining the *logical structure* of comprehension, especially for Vedic interpretation - not claiming that every hearer performs scholastic analysis.

3. **The three shared conditions.** FACT: **Mutual expectancy (ākāṅkṣā)**: without it, words do not demand one another and no single meaning arises. FACT: **Semantic fitness (yogyatā)**: without it, connected words may still generate an impossible meaning. FACT: **Proximity (sannidhi / āsatti)**: without it, even fit and expectant words may belong to different sentences.

4. **The fourth condition and the Mīmāṃsā difficulty.** ANALYSIS: Naiyāyikas often add ***purport* (tātparya) - **the speaker's intention or intended thrust**. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā cannot ground Vedic meaning in a speaker's intention because the Veda is authorless, so any "purport" must be located in textual force, contextual unity and injunctive function. WRONG: *Objection*: if purport is needed for human sentences, authorless Vedic sentences become unintelligible. FACT: *Reply*: Vedic purport is not psychological intention but sentence-function disclosed by textual relations, especially subordination to injunction (vidhī**). ANALYSIS: This creates a real internal pressure, and a strong answer says so: *the refusal of speaker-intention forces Mīmāṃsā to make purport impersonal, textual and rule-governed*.

5. Bhāṭṭa's connection-of-the-denoted, in six steps.

(i) Words such as "cow," "bring" and "heaven-desirer" have repeatable lexical meanings. (ii) These meanings are grasped when the corresponding words are heard. (iii) The isolated meanings are not yet a full sentence-meaning. (iv) They become one meaning only when related through expectancy, fitness and proximity. (v) Comprehension therefore has two logical stages: denotation of word-meanings, then connection of those meanings. (vi) This preserves the independent force of words and explains stable lexical meaning across contexts. FACT: Presupposition: word-meanings can be grasped independently enough to be available for later syntactic connection; sentence meaning is **compositional**. ANALYSIS: Distinction: the two stages are primarily *logical*, not a slow temporal sequence - Bhāṭṭa need not claim the hearer pauses after each word. WRONG: *Objection*: the theory multiplies operations, seeming to require indirect signification or a special connecting power in every sentence. FACT: *Reply*: that is the cost of explaining how stable word-meanings combine into determinate sentence-meaning; the operation is structural, not an arbitrary extra act.

6. Prabhākara's denotation-of-the-connected, in six steps.

(i) In actual learning and use, words are encountered within meaningful action-guiding sentences. (ii) The child does not first master isolated dictionary meanings and then build sentences. (iii) The standard **learning argument (vyutpatti)** says a child observes an elder command "bring the cow" and a younger person comply. (iv) From this whole event the child learns the connected sense of the words inside a practical sentence. (v) Therefore words signify meanings already connected with action, agent, object and context. (vi) Sentence-comprehension is not a later synthesis of atomised meanings but the original mode of linguistic understanding. FACT: Presupposition: no meaning is grasped outside some context of use; language is primarily action-guiding, which fits Mīmāṃsā's injunction-centred hermeneutics. ANALYSIS: Distinction: Prabhākara does not deny that words are repeatable; he denies that their primary semantic life is an isolated lexical object detached from sentential connection. WRONG: *Objection*: if a word never means anything in isolation, dictionaries, grammar lessons and single-word utterances become inexplicable. FACT: *Reply*: these are secondary abstractions from repeated connected uses; primary meaning remains relational.

7. The four cross-objections, which convert a description into a debate.

WRONG: *Against Bhāṭṭa*: the isolated-word stage is not phenomenologically observed and makes every sentence depend on an extra indirect-signification or purport-operation. FACT: *Reply*: the distinction is explanatory, not introspective; stable lexical meaning requires word-priority. WRONG: *Against Prābhākara*: if words signify only connected meanings, the same word would seem to mean differently in every sentence. FACT: *Reply*: recurrent connected uses yield stable practical competence without positing context-free meanings. WRONG: *Against Bhāṭṭa*: language-learning begins in sentences, not in isolated word-lists. FACT: *Reply*: learning-history does not settle semantic structure; what is learned in context can still be the word's repeatable meaning. WRONG: *Against Prābhākara*: single-word commands such as "Cow!" or "Fire!" seem meaningful. FACT: *Reply*: such utterances are elliptical sentences supplied by context, not proof of isolated word-meaning.

8. **The verdict line.** ANALYSIS: **Bhāṭṭa secures stable lexical meaning; Prābhākara secures contextual action-guidance.** Neither claim is refuted by the other, and the honest close is that the two theories capture different halves of a genuine phenomenon.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The test sentence "**svargakāmo yajeta**" - "one desiring heaven should sacrifice" - which the hearer must grasp as a unified injunction upon a qualified agent, not as "heaven-desirer" plus "sacrifice."
- FACT: The three shared conditions with their failure cases: "Bring..." for expectancy, "sprinkle with fire" for fitness, separated discourse for proximity.
- FACT: Bhāṭṭa's denotative power (**abhidhā**) plus indirect signification (**lakṣaṇā**) or purport-power (**tātparya-śakti**).
- FACT: Prābhākara's learning argument (**vyutpatti**): elder commands, younger complies, child learns.
- FACT: The four-row cross-objection table.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The Bhāṭṭa hears a sentence as words that have been joined; the Prābhākara hears words as a sentence that has been analysed - and the whole dispute is about which of those two descriptions reports the original event and which reports the later reconstruction.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
sentence-unity (ekavākyatā)	The problem, correctly named
connection-of-the-denoted (abhihitānvayavāda)	Bhāṭṭa's thesis
denotation-of-the-connected (anvitābhidhānavāda)	Prābhākara's thesis
expectancy (ākāṅkṣā) · fitness (yogyatā) · proximity (sannidhi)	The three shared conditions
purport (tātparya)	The contested fourth, and the authorless-Veda problem
denotative power (abhidhā) / indirect signification (lakṣaṇā)	Bhāṭṭa's machinery
learning argument (vyutpatti)	Prābhākara's strongest evidence
svargakāmo yajeta	The standard test sentence

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara agree entirely about the conditions of sentence-unity and disagree only about which linguistic unit is semantically primary. **Named evidence.** Both require mutual expectancy (**ākāṅkṣā**), semantic fitness (**yogyatā**) and proximity (**sannidhi**) before a word-sequence becomes one sentence; Bhāṭṭa then holds that each word denotes its own meaning through **abhidhā** and that these meanings are connected by a further operation, while Prābhākara appeals to the learning situation (**vyutpatti**) - an elder commanding "bring the cow" and a younger complying - to argue that words are learned, and therefore denote, only as already connected. **Analysis.** The two theories are strong at opposite points: word-priority explains why "cow" carries the same meaning into a thousand sentences, whereas sentence-priority explains how the word was acquired in the first place and why the Veda's injunctions are grasped as demands rather than as assembled descriptions - which is why the Prābhākara account sits more naturally with the school's injunction-centred hermeneutics. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: Neither side refutes the other, and both inherit a common difficulty: because the Veda has no author, the purport (**tātparya**) that Naiyāyikas locate in a speaker's intention must here be relocated into textual function and subordination to injunction, which is an intellectually demanding move rather than an obvious one.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2024, Q5(d), 10 marks** - "How does Bhāṭṭa's view of nature of word-meaning and sentential-meaning differ from Prābhākara's view? Critically discuss." Three shared conditions, two theses, two cross-objections and the verdict line fill the word limit exactly.
- **2023, Q8(c), 15 marks** - universals or particulars; that answer stands on this session's semantic frame (Session 15).

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Reversing the two labels. **Abhihitānvaya = Bhāṭṭa** (denoted-then-connected); ****anvitābhidhāna = Prābhākara (connected-then-denoted).** **Memorise by the first syllable pairing:** A-BHI-hita with BHĀ-ṭṭa**.
2. ANALYSIS: Presenting Bhāṭṭa's two stages as a temporal sequence in the hearer's consciousness.
3. ANALYSIS: Omitting the three shared conditions and writing only the disagreement.
4. ANALYSIS: Adding **tātparya** to the Mīmāṃsā list without flagging the authorless-Veda problem.
5. ANALYSIS: Claiming Prābhākara denies that words are repeatable.

RAPID REVISION

- Problem: **ekavākyatā** - how many words yield one cognition.
- Shared: expectancy · fitness · proximity. Contested fourth: purport (Nyāya adds it; Mīmāṃsā must impersonalise it).
- Bhāṭṭa: word first (**abhidhā**), then connection (**lakṣaṇā / tātparya-śakti**) => compositional.
- Prābhākara: connected denotation, supported by the learning argument (**vyutpatti**) => contextual.
- Verdict: stable lexicon versus action-guidance; test sentence **svargakāmo yajeta**.

SESSION 15 - UNIVERSALS OR PARTICULARS, EXCLUSION, AND THE REJECTED SOUND-BURST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. When you say "cow," what does the word actually pick out - the general character shared by all cows, or the individual animal in front of you? Mīmāṃsā answers "the general character, primarily"; Nyāya answers "the individual, as qualified"; and a Buddhist answers "neither - the word merely excludes non-cows."

Technical definition. Mīmāṃsā generally holds that words primarily denote the **universal (jāti)**, while Nyāya gives primacy to the **individual (vyakti)** qualified by universal and form. The Buddhist alternative is **exclusion (apoha)**. The Grammarians add a third position, **sound-burst theory (sphoṭa-vāda)**, on which sentence-meaning is grasped in a single indivisible flash of **vākya-sphoṭa**; both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject it.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Point at a cow and say the word. Something has to explain two facts at once.

Fact one: the same word works for a cow you have never seen, in a country you have never visited. So the word cannot be tied to *this* animal.

Fact two: when the Veda says "bring the cow," an actual animal must be brought. So the word cannot float free of individuals either.

Mīmāṃsā's solution: the word's *primary* grip is on cow-ness, and the individual is reached *through* the universal as instantiated in a concrete context. Nyāya reverses the priority. ANALYSIS: Note that both sides reach both - the dispute is about **semantic priority**, not about coverage, and caricaturing either side as knowing only universals or only particulars is the standard way to lose this question.

VISUAL - THREE POSITIONS ON REFERENCE, AND THE FOURTH ON SENTENCE-MEANING

THE QUESTION: do words refer to universals, particulars, or both?

SCHOOL	PRIMARY DENOTATION	HOW THE OTHER IS REACHED
MĪMĀṂSĀ	the UNIVERSAL (jāti) - cow-ness	the individual is reached THROUGH the universal as instantiated in a concrete context
NYĀYA	the INDIVIDUAL (vyakti), as qualified by universal and form	the universal is present AS THE QUALIFIER of the individual
BUDDHIST (apoha)	NEITHER - the word functions by EXCLUDING non-cows	apparent generality is a constructed negative shadow

ANALYSIS: BOTH Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya reach BOTH universal and individual.

THE DIFFERENCE IS PRIORITY, NOT COVERAGE. Do not caricature either side.

===== THE MĪMĀṂSĀ ARGUMENT (five steps) =====

1. the same word "cow" applies to MANY individual cows
 2. this REPEATABILITY is best explained by the word's relation to cow-ness
 3. the individual is then reached through the universal as instantiated
 4. Nyāya REVERSES the priority, taking the qualified individual as primary
 5. answers must not caricature either side
- PRESUPPOSITION: linguistic repeatability requires a STABLE SEMANTIC GROUND across changing individuals.

===== TWO OBJECTIONS AND TWO REPLIES =====

WRONG: "A universal alone cannot be milked, brought or sacrificed."

FACT: the universal is primary FOR MEANING, while ACTION reaches the qualified individual through contextual application.

WRONG: BUDDHIST EXCLUSION: no real universal is needed; "cow" works by excluding non-cows.

FACT: pure exclusion cannot explain STABLE POSITIVE RECOGNITION and REPEATABLE APPLICATION unless a shared class-character is already available => word-use is grounded in a REAL universal, not only in negation.

===== THE GRAMMARIAN THIRD POSITION - AND ITS REJECTION =====

ANALYSIS: BHARTRĦARI / GRAMMARIANS - sphoṭa-vāda

individual sounds PERISH and cannot by themselves yield the whole meaning
=> posit a unitary SOUND-BURST (vākya-sphoṭa) as the real bearer of meaning

FACT: MĪMĀṂSĀ REPLY (both sub-schools reject the extra entity)

the eternal PHONEMES (varṇa) and their ordered manifestation are SUFFICIENT word-meaning + the sentence-conditions already explain comprehension
=> NO ADDITIONAL SPHOṬA IS REQUIRED

WRONG: "if letters are heard successively, how can they produce one meaning?"

FACT: MEMORY of the ordered series + ākāṅkṣā + yogyatā + sannidhi is enough

=> preserves economy AND the theory of eternal word-units WITHOUT Grammarian holism

What the diagram shows: the three-way reference dispute with its priority-not-coverage caution, the five-step Mīmāṃsā argument, both objections with their replies, and the Grammarian position that a 15-mark answer can add for depth.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The thesis, with its exact hedge.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā generally holds that words primarily denote the

universal; Nyāya gives primacy to the individual qualified by universal and form. ANALYSIS: **Both positions can reach both**; the difference concerns semantic priority.

2. **The five-step argument.** (i) The same word "cow" applies to many individual cows. (ii) This repeatability is best explained, for Mīmāṃsā, by the word's relation to cow-ness. (iii) The individual is then reached through the universal as instantiated in a concrete context. (iv) Nyāya reverses the priority. (v) Therefore exam answers must not caricature either side.

3. **The presupposition.** FACT: Linguistic repeatability requires a *stable semantic ground* across changing individuals. ANALYSIS: This is why the dispute is not merely terminological: it is a dispute about what makes language possible at all.

4. **The worked example.** FACT: "Cow" can refer to this cow in front of me because the universal cow-ness is recognisable in that individual.

5. **The action objection and its reply.** WRONG: A universal alone cannot be milked, brought or sacrificed. FACT: The universal is primary *for meaning*, while action reaches the qualified individual through contextual application. ANALYSIS: Notice how neatly this preserves the school's ritual commitments: an injunction must reach a real animal, and the theory of meaning does not prevent that.

6. **The Buddhist exclusion objection and its reply.** WRONG: No real universal is needed; "cow" functions by excluding non-cows (**apoha**). FACT: Mīmāṃsā replies that pure exclusion cannot explain stable positive recognition and repeatable application unless a shared class-character is already available; word-use is therefore grounded in a real universal, not only in negation. ANALYSIS: This reply is also the semantic face of the realism defended in Session 7's two-stage perception, and saying so links two answers together.

7. **The Grammarian third position.** ANALYSIS: Bhartṛhari and the Grammarian tradition defend **sphoṭa-vāda**: sentence-meaning is grasped in a single indivisible flash of **vākya-sphoṭa**. The argument is that individual sounds perish and cannot by themselves yield the whole meaning, so a unitary sound-burst must be posited as the real bearer of meaning. FACT: Both Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara reject the need for such an additional entity.

8. **The Mīmāṃsā reply to the Grammarian, in three steps.** FACT: The eternal phonemes (**varṇa**) and their ordered manifestation are sufficient. FACT: Since word-meaning and the sentence-conditions already explain comprehension, no additional sound-burst is required. FACT: This preserves Mīmāṃsā's economy and its theory of eternal word-units without accepting Grammarian holism. WRONG: *Objection*: if letters are heard successively, how can they produce one meaning without a sound-burst? FACT: *Reply*: memory of the ordered series, together with expectancy, fitness and proximity, is enough to yield unity. FACT: Presupposition: the phonemes are real and stable enough to carry meaning without a separate indivisible language-entity.

9. **How a 15-marker on this question should be built.** ANALYSIS: Begin from sentence-unity and the shared conditions (Session 14); state the Mīmāṃsā universal-priority thesis with the repeatability argument; state the Nyāya reversal fairly with its qualified-individual formula; supply the cow / cow-ness example on both sides; answer the action objection; add the Buddhist exclusion challenge and the reply; and, if space permits, add the Grammarian position and its rejection for depth. Close on priority-not-coverage.

10. **The connection back to eternal words.** ANALYSIS: The rejection of the sound-burst is not an isolated polemic: it protects the doctrine that word-units are eternal and merely *manifested* by utterance, which Session 16 needs in order to defend authorlessness. The semantics and the scriptural defence are one structure.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The Mīmāṃsā universal-priority thesis and the Nyāya qualified-individual thesis, with the explicit "both reach both" caution.
- FACT: The repeatability argument and the cow / cow-ness example.
- FACT: The Buddhist **apoha** objection and the stable-positive-recognition reply.
- ANALYSIS: Bhartṛhari's **sphoṭa-vāda** and its rejection by both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools, with the eternal phonemes (**varṇa**) and ordered manifestation as the sufficient alternative.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Neither Mīmāṃsā nor Nyāya is confined to one side of the universal-particular divide; what is genuinely at stake is which of the two the word *reaches first*, and Mīmāṃsā answers "the universal" because nothing else explains how a word learned on one animal can be spent on a thousand.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
universal (jāti)	Mīmāṃsā's primary denotatum
individual (vyakti), qualified	Nyāya's primary denotatum
semantic priority, not coverage	The anti-caricature sentence
repeatability	The argument's engine
exclusion (apoha)	The Buddhist alternative
sound-burst (sphoṭa) / sentence-sound-burst (vākya-sphoṭa)	The Grammarian position, for depth
phonemes (varṇa) and ordered manifestation	Mīmāṃsā's economical alternative

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā holds that words denote the universal primarily and the individual derivatively, while Nyāya reverses that order - so the dispute concerns semantic priority rather than the range of what language can reach. **Named evidence.** Mīmāṃsā argues from repeatability: the same word "cow" applies to indefinitely many individuals, which is explained by its relation to cow-ness, the individual being reached through the universal as instantiated; Nyāya takes the individual qualified by universal and form as primary; and the Buddhist **apoha** theory denies real universals altogether, treating "cow" as the exclusion of non-cows. **Analysis.** The Mīmāṃsā reply to exclusion is the decisive move for a realist semantics: pure negation cannot account for the stable positive recognition and repeatable application that language actually exhibits, since to exclude non-cows one must already be able to identify what counts as a cow - and the same realism reappears in the school's insistence that determinate perception interprets rather than falsifies the given. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The Mīmāṃsā position must still explain how a universal is milked or sacrificed, and its answer - that action reaches the qualified individual through contextual application - concedes that the individual is indispensable in practice even if secondary in meaning; the Grammarian sound-burst theory, though rejected here, shows that even within the orthodox camp the sufficiency of phonemes plus sentence-conditions is contested.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2023, Q8(c), 15 marks** - "Do words refer to universals or particulars or both? Present an exposition of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā position ... along with suitable examples." The "or both" in the stem is precisely the priority-not-coverage point, and examples are explicitly demanded.
- Supports **2024, Q5(d)**, since the semantics of Session 14 and this session are one continuous argument.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing that Mīmāṃsā knows *only* universals and Nyāya *only* particulars. The stem's "or both" is a warning, not a decoration.
2. ANALYSIS: Omitting examples in a question that asks for them by name.
3. ANALYSIS: Attributing **sphoṭa-vāda** to Mīmāṃsā. Both sub-schools **reject** it.
4. ANALYSIS: Treating **apoha** as a minor curiosity; it is the strongest challenge to the Mīmāṃsā position and its refutation is worth marks.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing the Grammarian eternal *sound-burst* with the Mīmāṃsā eternal *phoneme*; Mīmāṃsā's

eternity claim is about word-units, not about an indivisible meaning-bearer.

RAPID REVISION

- Mīmāṃsā: universal (**jāti**) primary; individual reached through it.
- Nyāya: individual (**vyakti**) qualified by universal and form, primary.
- Both reach both - priority, not coverage.
- Engine: repeatability requires a stable semantic ground.
- Buddhist **apoha** answered by stable positive recognition.
- Grammarian **sphoṭa** rejected: phonemes + ordered manifestation + the three conditions suffice.

SESSION 16 - THE AUTHORLESS VEDA AND THE CIRCULARITY CHARGE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The Veda is authoritative, says Mīmāṃsā, precisely because nobody wrote it. A text with an author has somewhere for error, deceit, partiality and forgetfulness to enter. A text with no author has no such place.

Technical definition. Authorlessness (apauruṣeyatva) means that the Veda is not the composition of any human or divine person. It is supported by the **eternality of the word (śabda-nityatva)** and by the doctrine that the relation between word (**śabda**) and meaning (**artha**) is **natural or inherent (autpattika)** rather than a convention (**saṅketa**) instituted by a person. Utterance therefore *manifests* rather than *produces* the word.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Every other route to scriptural authority runs through a person: this prophet was inspired, this teacher was omniscient, this God does not lie. And every such route has the same weak joint - you must first establish the person's credentials, and you must establish them without using the scripture whose authority is in question.

Mīmāṃsā takes the opposite road. It removes the person entirely.

Ask the Mīmāṃsaka *why* the Veda is reliable and he will not praise anyone. He will say: reliability fails when a speaker is ignorant, deceitful, partial or forgetful; there is no speaker here; so that entire class of failure does not arise.

ANALYSIS: It is a defence by *subtraction*, and it is why Session 18's atheism is not an embarrassment to this school but a requirement of it. Add God as author and you have re-installed exactly the weak joint you removed.

VISUAL - THE ARGUMENT, THE CIRCULARITY CHARGE, AND SIX REPLIES

===== THE EIGHT-STEP ARGUMENT FOR AUTHORLESSNESS =====

1. no author of the Veda is REMEMBERED in the tradition
2. an author of so momentous a text would NORMALLY have been remembered
3. the word-meaning relation is NATURAL (autpattika), not newly instituted by a person
4. word-units (varṇa) have ETERNITY (śabda-nityatva) => utterance MANIFESTS, not produces
5. transmission has been maintained by disciplined recitation; no event of composition is located
6. the Veda need not be treated as a composed book with a fallible author
7. authorial defects explain unreliability in human testimony
8. an authorless Veda is free of that class of defect => SELF-VALID FOR DHARMA

WHY AUTHORLESSNESS MATTERS - the four-defect argument

a personal author MAY ERR · MAY DECEIVE · MAY LACK COMPLETE KNOWLEDGE
=> authority would depend on PROVING competence and sincerity
=> authorlessness removes the dependence => validity is intrinsic

AGAINST NYĀYA'S GOD-GUARANTEE - the three-stage burden

first prove God exists -> then prove God is omniscient -> then prove God intends truth
each stage needs INDEPENDENT support => cumbersome => authorlessness avoids it

===== THE CIRCULARITY CHARGE, IN TWO FORMS =====

WRONG: FORM 1: the Veda is authoritative because authorless - but authorlessness and the claim that dharma is unknowable otherwise seem accepted BECAUSE THE TRADITION SAYS SO.
WRONG: FORM 2 (sharper): intrinsic validity PROVES TOO MUCH - if every cognition is intrinsically valid, RIVAL SCRIPTURES become self-valid too.

===== SIX REPLIES =====

- ↓
- FACT: R1 authorlessness rests on ORDINARY REASONING + the absence of any remembered author, not on a Vedic quotation
- FACT: R2 the reasoning has a POSTULATION (arthāpatti) FORM: extraordinary authority + no remembered authorial event => authorless transmission is the required postulate
- FACT: R3 intrinsic validity ≠ indefeasibility; invalidity is known through defect (doṣa) or a subverting cognition (bādhaka)
- FACT: R4 rival scriptures WITH known or claimed human authors possess a POSSIBLE LOCUS OF DEFECT; an authorless Veda lacks that locus
- FACT: R5 the Veda is authoritative ONLY FOR DHARMA, where no rival instrument operates; it does not compete with perception about colour or inference about fire
- FACT: R6 the DIVINE-AUTHOR alternative is WORSE: a person, even a divine person, becomes a further object needing proof, and his omniscience and disinterest would themselves require support

===== RESIDUAL FORCE - state this in a critical answer =====

ANALYSIS: the reply loads great weight on "no remembered author" and on the NATURALNESS of the word-meaning relation

ANALYSIS: Nyāya (Jayanta, Udayana) deny naturalness: the relation is CONVENTION (saṅketa), ultimately instituted by Īśvara, and the Veda is the testimony of a trustworthy authority (āpta)

ANALYSIS: Buddhists in the Dharmakīrti line reject eternal words and ask how an eternal, changeless word could produce a cognition AT A PARTICULAR TIME

FACT: Mīmāṃsā answer: the eternal word is not newly produced; it is MANIFESTED by utterance under auditory conditions, so the timed cognition depends on manifestation and hearer-conditions, not on creation of the word

What the diagram shows: the positive argument, the two supporting arguments, the charge in both its forms, six numbered replies, and the residual pressure - which together constitute a complete answer to the 2019 question at any length.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The thesis.** FACT: The Veda is authoritative because it is authorless, eternal and self-valid.
2. **Why authorlessness is the right ground.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in authorlessness because a text without an author has no locus for ignorance, deceit, partiality or forgetfulness. FACT: The doctrine is central because the Veda reveals duty, a supersensible object unavailable to perception, inference or ordinary testimony. ANALYSIS: The Veda is therefore authoritative **not because a perfect speaker guarantees it, but because it is impersonal, eternal and free from authorial defect.**
3. **The eight-step argument.** (i) No author is remembered in the tradition. (ii) A human author of so momentous a text would normally have been remembered. (iii) The word-meaning relation is natural (**autpattika**), not a convention newly instituted by a person. (iv) For Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, words as sound-burst-independent phonemes and the relevant universals of wordhood have eternity (**śabda-nityatva**), so utterance manifests rather

than produces the word. (v) Vedic transmission has been maintained through disciplined recitation, and no original event of composition is located. (vi) Therefore the Veda need not be treated as a composed book with a fallible author. (vii) Since authorial defects explain unreliability in human testimony, (viii) an authorless Veda is free from that class of defects - hence Vedic testimony is self-valid in its proper domain, namely duty.

4. **The presuppositions.** FACT: A text can be meaningful without a historical author if word-meaning relations are eternal and impersonal. FACT: The absence of a remembered author is philosophically relevant, because an author of the Veda would not be a trivial forgotten artisan. FACT: Duty is supersensible, so the Veda's authority is restricted to a domain not otherwise known.

5. **The distinction that prevents an obvious misreading.** ANALYSIS: Authorlessness is **not** the claim that no one ever recited, taught or arranged Vedic branches. It is the claim that transmission and recension are not original authorship. FACT: Names such as **Kaṭha** and **Kauṣītaki** can mark schools, transmitters or branches without proving personal composition of Vedic content. FACT: Example: a teacher who recites a mantra is a transmitter; Mīmāṃsā denies that such transmission makes the teacher the author of the mantra's Vedic authority.

6. **The four-defect argument for why authorlessness matters.** FACT: A personal author may err; may deceive; may lack complete knowledge. FACT: If the Veda had an author, its authority would depend on proving that author's competence and sincerity. FACT: By being authorless it is free from these defects, and hence its validity is intrinsic.

7. **Against Nyāya's God-guarantee.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā objects that Nyāya's route is cumbersome: first prove God exists, then prove God is omniscient, then prove God intends truth - each stage needing independent support. FACT: Authorlessness avoids the dependence entirely.

8. **The circularity charge, in both forms, and the six replies.** WRONG: *Form 1*: the defence looks circular, since authorlessness and the unknowability of duty by other means seem accepted because the tradition says so. WRONG: *Form 2, sharper*: intrinsic validity proves too much - if every cognition is intrinsically valid, rival scriptures also become self-valid unless an external criterion is smuggled in. FACT: *Reply 1*: authorlessness is presented as supported by ordinary reasoning plus the absence of any remembered author, not as a conclusion quoted from the Veda. FACT: *Reply 2*: the reasoning has a **postulation (arthāpatti)** form - given a tradition of extraordinary authority and no remembered authorial event, authorless transmission is posited as the required explanation. FACT: *Reply 3*: intrinsic validity does not mean every cognition is finally indefeasible; it means validity needs no positive external certificate, while invalidity is known through defect (**doṣa**) or a subverting cognition (**bādhaka**). FACT: *Reply 4*: rival scriptures with known or claimed human authors possess a possible locus of defect, whereas an authorless Veda lacks that locus. FACT: *Reply 5*: the Veda is authoritative only for **duty**, where no rival instrument operates; it does not compete with perception on colour or with inference on smoke and fire. FACT: *Reply 6*: the divine-author alternative is worse for Mīmāṃsā, because a person - even a divine person - becomes a further object needing proof, and the alleged omniscience and freedom from self-interest of that person would themselves require support from some instrument.

9. **The residual force, which a critical answer must state.** ANALYSIS: The reply pushes significant weight onto "no remembered author" and onto the naturalness of the word-meaning relation. ANALYSIS: Nyāya thinkers such as **Jayanta** and **Udayana** deny naturalness, treating the relation as convention (**saṅketa**) ultimately grounded in Īśvara's institution, and reading the Veda as the testimony of a trustworthy authority (**āpta**). ANALYSIS: Buddhist critics in the **Dharmakīrti** line reject eternal words and ask how an eternal, changeless word could produce a cognition at a particular time.

10. **The four rejoinders to those attacks.**

WRONG: *Nyāya*: word-meaning is conventional; God institutes the convention and guarantees the Veda as its trustworthy author. FACT: *Reply*: conventionalism makes meaning depend on an institutor whose existence and reliability must first be proved; the natural relation explains linguistic stability without that extra theological burden. WRONG: *Nyāya*: branch-names such as **Kaṭha** and **Kauṣītaki** show human authorship. FACT: *Reply*: such names can indicate reciters, teachers or schools of transmission, not composers of Vedic sentences. WRONG: *Buddhist*: an eternal word cannot cause a timed cognition, because what is changeless cannot suddenly produce an effect. FACT: *Reply*: the eternal word is not newly produced but **manifested** by utterance under appropriate auditory conditions, so the timed cognition depends on manifestation and hearer-conditions, not on the creation of the word. WRONG:

Buddhist: if all authority is defended through intrinsic validity, sectarian texts can make the same claim. FACT: *Reply*: intrinsic validity is defeasible; a text with an author, a contradiction or a detectable defect can be defeated, whereas the Veda's domain is precisely the supersensible domain in which perception and inference supply no defeater.

11. **The eternity of the word, stated compactly.** FACT: Words are eternal in the relevant Mīmāṃsā sense; utterance manifests them rather than creates them; Vedic revelation is therefore not dependent on temporal composition.

12. **The final formula.** FACT: Presupposition: duty is supersensible. FACT: Distinction: Vedic authority rests on authorlessness, not on speaker intention. FACT: Example: ritual obligations and unseen fruits lie beyond perception. WRONG: *Objection*: communication requires a speaker's intention. FACT: *Reply*: Mīmāṃsā grounds meaning in the eternal relation of word and meaning, not in a historical author's psychology. FACT: **Conclusion: the Veda is self-valid because it is eternal, authorless and uniquely revelatory of duty.**

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The eight-step argument for authorlessness and the four-defect argument for why it matters.
- FACT: The **Kaṭha** and **Kauṣītaki** branch-names, used as the standard reply to the human-authorship inference.
- FACT: The three-stage burden Mīmāṃsā attributes to the Nyāya God-guarantee.
- FACT: The six numbered replies to the circularity charge, including the postulation-form of Reply 2.
- ANALYSIS: **Jayanta** and **Udayana** on convention (**saṅketa**) and on the Veda as an **āpta**-testimony; the **Dharmakīrti** line on timed cognition from an eternal word.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Every rival grounds a scripture by praising somebody; Mīmāṃsā grounds it by finding nobody - and its wager is that an absent author is a safer foundation than a perfect one, because perfection has to be proved and absence only has to be undisturbed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
authorlessness (apauruṣeyatva)	The thesis
eternity of the word (śabda-nityatva)	The supporting doctrine
natural relation (autpattika)	Why meaning needs no institutor
convention (saṅketa)	The Nyāya alternative, correctly named
trustworthy authority (āpta)	Nyāya's route to Vedic reliability
defect (doṣa) / defeater (bādhaka)	How invalidity is detected
manifested, not produced	The reply to the Buddhist timing objection
domain restriction to dharma	Reply 5, the strongest anti-proliferation move

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā establishes Vedic authority by removing its author, on the ground that unreliability in testimony is traceable to defects that can exist only in a person. **Named evidence.** The school argues that no author of the Veda is remembered although such an author would have been; that the word-meaning relation is natural (**autpattika**) rather than an instituted convention; that word-units possess eternality (**śabda-nityatva**) so that utterance merely manifests them; and that a personal author may err, deceive or lack complete knowledge, so that Nyāya's route must first prove God's existence, then his omniscience, then his truthfulness. **Analysis.** The defence is stronger than it first appears because it is restricted: the Veda is claimed to be self-valid only for duty, where no other instrument operates and therefore no defeater can arise, which simultaneously blocks the charge that intrinsic validity would license every rival scripture - those rivals have authors, and an author is precisely a locus of defect and a target for defeat. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The argument nevertheless rests heavily on two contested props - the absence of a remembered author and the naturalness of the word-meaning relation - and both are denied by Nyāya, which treats the relation as divinely instituted convention, and by the Dharmakīrti line, which rejects eternal words altogether; the honest verdict is that Mīmāṃsā's position is coherent within its own presuppositions rather than compelling against those who reject them.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - "How does Mīmāṃsā establish the authority of Vedic knowledge?" A ten-mark answer needs the eight-step argument compressed to four, the four-defect argument, and one line of residual pressure.
- Supports **2018, Q8(a)** and the whole of Session 18, since the atheism follows from this defence rather than sitting beside it.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing that the Veda is "God-given" or "revealed by God." For Mīmāṃsā it is authorless - this is the single most damaging error available on this topic.
2. ANALYSIS: Treating authorlessness as denying that anyone recited or transmitted the Veda.
3. ANALYSIS: Omitting the domain restriction, which is what stops the doctrine from validating every scripture.
4. ANALYSIS: Attributing the convention theory (**saṅketa**) to Mīmāṃsā; it is the Nyāya position.
5. ANALYSIS: Forgetting that Reply 2 is itself an application of postulation - a link worth a mark.
6. ANALYSIS: Presenting the Buddhist timing objection without the "manifested, not produced" reply.

RAPID REVISION

- Thesis: authorless (**apauruṣeyatva**) => no locus of defect => self-valid for duty.
- Supports: eternal word (**śabda-nityatva**), natural relation (**autpattika**), no remembered author, unlocated composition.
- Against Nyāya: three-stage burden - exists, omniscient, truthful.
- Circularity: two forms; six replies; strongest are the postulation-form (R2) and the domain restriction (R5).
- Residual: Jayanta/Udayana on convention; Dharmakīrti on timed cognition - answered by "manifested, not produced."

SESSION 17 - INJUNCTION, IMPELLING FORCE, OBLIGATION, UNSEEN POTENCY AND DUTY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The Veda's characteristic sentence is not "this is the case" but "do this." Mīmāṃsā therefore needs an account of what makes a sentence a *command* rather than a report, what makes a command *bind* someone who has no commander in front of him, and how an act performed today can pay out a fruit long after the act has ended.

Technical definition. The Veda's primary import is **injunction (vidhi / codanā)**. Its meaning-content, on the Bhāṭṭa analysis, is **impelling force (bhāvanā)** - the efficient force of bringing something into being, expressed by the verbal ending - which divides into **verbal impelling force (śābdī bhāvanā)** and **objective productive force (ārthī bhāvanā)**, each requiring the three factors (**aṃśa-traya**). Prabhākara replaces this doubling with a directly apprehended **to-be-done (kārya) / obligation (niyoga)**. The bridge from a perishing act to a distant fruit is the **unseen potency (apūrva)**.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Read the school's standard test sentence aloud: "**svargakāmo yajeta**" - "*one desiring heaven should sacrifice.*"

Three puzzles are packed into those two words.

First: what turns this into a command? No one is commanding. There is no speaker to be obeyed. Bhāṭṭa's answer: the imperative force sits in the verbal form itself, whose relation to its meaning is natural rather than instituted. The sentence impels because of what it *is*, not because of who said it.

Second: why would anyone obey? Bhāṭṭa answers: because you want heaven, and the sentence tells you that sacrifice produces it. Prabhākara answers: because it is enjoined, full stop - the desire is not the ground of the obligation.

Third: how can a rite performed on a Tuesday produce heaven decades later? The flames do not travel. Mīmāṃsā answers with **unseen potency (apūrva)**: the act generates a persisting potency that matures into the fruit.

ANALYSIS: And notice the method - that potency is not asserted, it is *postulated*, by the very instrument defended in Session 9.

VISUAL - FROM SENTENCE TO FRUIT, WITH THE TWO RIVAL ACCOUNTS

THE VEDIC SENTENCE TAXONOMY (five functions)

injunction (vidhi)	enjoins a duty or rite not otherwise known	PRIMARY REVEALER OF DHARMA
prohibition (niṣedha)	forbids an act, grounds avoidance	negative duty
mantra (mantra)	recalls deity, material, detail during performance	assists a rite
name (nāmadheya)	names a rite, substance, component	fixes ritual identification
praise/explanation (arthavāda)	praises, condemns, narrates or explains in support of a vidhi	force through relation to vidhi

FACT: Do NOT dismiss mantra, name and arthavāda as meaningless: their Vedic function is secured by SENTENCE-UNITY (ekavākyatā) with an operative injunction.

SECOND CLASSIFICATION - three logical kinds of injunction

apūrva-vidhi (novel) reveals an otherwise UNKNOWN duty
 niyama-vidhi (restrictive) SELECTS one eligible means where alternatives appear
 parisamkhyā-vidhi (exclusionary) EXCLUDES alternatives

ANALYSIS: THIRD, SEPARATE GRID - ritual coordination of a complex rite; do NOT conflate with the above

utpatti (the act) · viniyoga (subsidiary application) · prayoga (performance-order)
 · adhikāra (qualified agent)

BHĀṬṬA: THE DOUBLE FORCE

"svargakāmo yajeta"

--- ŚĀBDĪ BHĀVANĀ (locus: the Vedic sentence / injunction)
 word-force IMPELS the hearer => immediate result: PRAVRṬTI (impulse to act)
 aṃśa-traya: kim? -> the agent's pravṛtti (what is to be brought about)
 kena? -> the injunctive suffix + knowledge of the injunction
 katham? -> arthavāda and eulogistic supports strengthen it
 --- ĀRTHĪ BHĀVANĀ (locus: the agent's own effort and ritual performance)
 action BRINGS ABOUT the result through the proper means
 => immediate result: PHALA (e.g. svarga), mediated by apūrva where needed
 aṃśa-traya: kim? -> SVARGA (what is to be brought about)
 kena? -> YĀGA, sacrifice (the means)
 katham? -> procedure, materials, sequence, subsidiary acts

=> WORD-FORCE PRODUCES UNDERTAKING; ACTION-FORCE PRODUCES FRUIT.

PRĀBHĀKARA: THE SINGLE BINDING

the sentence directly presents an act as TO-BE-DONE (kārya) => OBLIGATION (niyoga)
 bindingness does NOT wait upon attraction toward svarga

=> PRĀBHĀKARA = NIYOGA-VĀDA (duty for duty's sake)

BHĀṬṬA = BHĀVANĀ-VĀDA (injunction operates through desire for a result)

ANALYSIS: Western comparison flag: niyoga may be compared CAUTIOUSLY with Kant's categorical imperative - both separate duty from desired consequences - but niyoga is grounded in an impersonal eternal Veda and applies only to the ritually qualified agent (adhikārin).

THE BRIDGE: UNSEEN POTENCY (apūrva)

ritual act is TEMPORALLY LIMITED -> promised fruit is TEMPORALLY REMOTE
 if the act simply perished without remainder, the Vedic connection would be unintelligible
 => POSTULATE apūrva as the unseen link => established by ARTHĀPATTI (Session 9)
 => THE FLAMES DO NOT TRAVEL TO HEAVEN; THE POTENCY PERSISTS UNTIL THE FRUIT MATURES.

HERMENEUTIC CANONS (comparative note)

ANALYSIS: The tradition's rule-governed interpretation is standardly presented through the strength-ordering śruti-liṅga-vākya-prakarāṇa-sthāna-samākhyā and the general/exception pair utsarga-apavāda. In this repository these canons are held as a CONTROLLED COMPARISON with rule-governed legal interpretation, with the express disanalogy that Mīmāṃsā presupposes an INFALLIBLE AUTHORLESS text and admits NO amendment by legislative intention. Use them as a named comparison, not as a doctrinal list to be expanded.

What the diagram shows: three separate classifications kept apart, the two rival theories of injunctive force with their three-factor analyses, the postulated bridge to the fruit, and the hermeneutic canons flagged at exactly the level of support the sources give them.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Why injunction is the semantic heart.** FACT: For Mīmāṃsā the primary import of the Veda is not description but injunction. FACT: Because the Veda's whole purpose is **codanā** and its subject is **dharma**, impelling force is the semantic heart of the system. ANALYSIS: An injunction is therefore not merely a sentence *about* an

action; it is a sentence that makes an action *obligatory for a qualified agent*.

2. **The six-step argument.** (i) Duty is supersensible and cannot be known by perception or ordinary inference. (ii) The Veda reveals duty through action-guiding sentences. (iii) A merely descriptive sentence would tell what is already the case, not what ought to be done. (iv) Therefore the decisive Vedic sentence-type is the injunction. (v) The force that converts a sentence into an action-guiding demand is **bhāvanā**. (vi) Hence Mīmāṃsā semantics, ritual theory and epistemology converge in the analysis of injunction.

3. **The presupposition that makes an authorless command possible.** FACT: Vedic meaning is primarily prescriptive, and an authorless text can bind because obligation flows from the *injunctive structure*, not from a personal commander. WRONG: *Objection*: a sentence without a personal speaker cannot command anyone. FACT: *Reply*: imperative force is carried by the optative/injunctive verbal form (**liḥ / vidhi**) itself, whose relation to its meaning is natural (**autpattika**); the obligation is impersonal and structural, not the will of a person.

4. **Bhāṭṭa's two-fold analysis.** FACT: **Verbal impelling force (śābdī bhāvanā)** has the Vedic sentence as its locus; the word-force impels the hearer to act, and its immediate result is **pravṛtti**, the volitional impulse to act in the qualified agent. FACT: **Objective productive force (ārthī bhāvanā)** has the agent's own effort and ritual performance as its locus; the action brings about the desired result through the proper means, and its immediate result is **phala** such as heaven, mediated by unseen potency where needed.

5. **The seven-step justification for doubling the force.** (i) An injunction has a linguistic side: the sentence must be understood as *requiring* action. (ii) This side belongs to the word or verbal ending and is therefore called verbal impelling force. (iii) Understanding the injunction produces the impulse in the qualified agent. (iv) But mere linguistic impulse does not itself produce heaven or any ritual result. (v) The agent must perform the act with the prescribed materials, sequence and subsidiaries. (vi) This real activity is objective productive force. (vii) Therefore the analysis doubles the productive force: word-force produces undertaking; action-force produces the fruit. WRONG: *Objection*: the two-fold structure is artificial, since one injunction seems to convey one act. FACT: *Reply*: the distinction is needed because linguistic impelling and real production are not the same function.

6. **The three factors (amśa-traya).** FACT: Every impelling force requires **what is to be brought about (sādhya / bhāvya), **the** means (karaṇa / sādhana), **and** how it is to be done (itikartavyatā)** - answering *kim?*, *kena?* and *katham?* FACT: For objective force in "svargakāmo yajeta": heaven is the result, sacrifice is the means, and ritual procedure, materials, sequence and subsidiary acts supply the "how." FACT: For verbal force in the same injunction: the agent's impulse is to be brought about, the injunctive suffix and the knowledge of the injunction are the means, and explanatory/eulogistic support strengthens and specifies the undertaking.

7. **Why the three factors matter beyond grammar.** FACT: No action-guiding sentence is complete unless it indicates what is to be achieved, by what means, and by what procedure. FACT: The frame lets Mīmāṃsā connect grammar, ritual detail and obligation in a single hermeneutic scheme. WRONG: *Objection*: praise passages seem meaningful on their own as praise, story or explanation. FACT: *Reply*: their Vedic relevance is secured through sentence-unity with an injunction; they are meaningful *as subordinate to* injunction. FACT: Example: a passage glorifying a rite does not independently create duty; it supports the relevant injunction by generating confidence, attention or motivation.

8. **Prabhākara's alternative, in five steps.** FACT: He rejects the Bhāṭṭa doubling and holds that the injunctive content is **to-be-done / obligation (kārya / niyoga)**, directly apprehended from the injunction and binding on the qualified agent. (i) The qualified agent hears the injunction. (ii) The sentence directly presents an act as to-be-done. (iii) The bindingness does not wait upon attraction toward heaven or any other fruit. (iv) Therefore obligation arises from **niyoga** itself. (v) This gives Prabhākara a rigorously deontological structure within ritual hermeneutics. WRONG: *Objection*: if the fruit does not motivate, why would the agent act at all? FACT: *Reply*: the cognition of the act as enjoined is itself action-guiding for the qualified agent.

9. **The doctrinal contrast to write out.** ANALYSIS: **Prābhākara = niyoga-vāda**, duty for duty's sake; **Bhāṭṭa = bhāvanā-vāda**, in which the injunction operates through desire for a result. ANALYSIS: This is a genuine Indian anticipation of the deontology/consequentialism contrast, and the Kantian comparison is legitimate *only* with its disanalogy attached: **niyoga** is grounded in an impersonal eternal Veda and applies to ritually qualified agents, whereas Kant grounds obligation in rational autonomy and universalisability.

10. **The subordination of non-injunctive material.** FACT: Praise (**arthavāda**), mantra and name (**nāmadheya**) are subordinate to injunctions, gaining Vedic function through sentence-unity with a **vidhi**. FACT: The argument: the Veda's central purpose is to reveal duty; duty is action-guiding; therefore sentences that do not directly enjoin must be related to sentences that do. WRONG: *Objection*: this reduces rich Vedic discourse to ritual command. FACT: *Reply*: Mīmāṃsā accepts the cost, because its project is not literary appreciation but the discovery of duty.

11. **The Vedānta seam - where the subordination is challenged.** FACT: The sharp doctrinal seam appears over Upaniṣadic sentences such as "**tat tvam asi**." FACT: *Mīmāṃsā's prior position*: the Veda's purpose is duty; duty is known through injunction; a sentence that does not guide action seems purposeless in the Vedic economy; therefore Upaniṣadic statements must either enjoin meditation/knowledge-related discipline or serve an injunctive purpose. FACT: *Advaita's counter-position*: knowledge is not an action and cannot be produced by command as sacrifice can; Brahman is not a future product but an accomplished reality; therefore sentences revealing Brahman can be independently valid as disclosure of an **accomplished fact (siddha-vastu)**, and the Upaniṣads need not be subordinated to ritual injunction. FACT: *Mīmāṃsā's reply back*: Vedic purposiveness is unintelligible unless scriptural sentences are action-guiding. ANALYSIS: *Advaita's rejoinder*: revelation of an accomplished reality is itself a valid scriptural purpose. ANALYSIS: The disagreement turns on whether Vedic meaningfulness requires action-production or can include direct metaphysical disclosure - and this is the doctrinal seam between the two Mīmāṃsās.

12. **Ethics in the narrow sense.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā epistemology culminates in duty: the point of knowing is to know what ought to be done. FACT: **Injunction (vidhi)** gives positive command and **prohibition (niṣedha)** gives negative command; together they define the normative shape of duty. FACT: On motivation, Bhāṭṭa foregrounds the desired fruit while Prābhākara stresses obligation. WRONG: *Objection*: without God there is no moral authority. FACT: *Reply*: for Mīmāṃsā, Vedic injunction and unseen potency are enough to secure binding duty and future fruit.

13. **Unseen potency, argued rather than asserted.** FACT: **Apūrva** is the unseen potency generated by ritual action that links a perishing act to a distant fruit; it makes objective productive force intelligible across time, because the act ends but its potency persists until the fruit matures. FACT: The five-step argument: (i) a ritual act is temporally limited; (ii) its promised fruit may be temporally remote and not visibly produced at the moment of action; (iii) if the act simply perished without remainder, the Vedic connection between rite and fruit would be unintelligible; (iv) therefore Mīmāṃsā posits apūrva as the unseen link; (v) and this postulation is defended through **arthāpatti**, because otherwise the scripturally guaranteed connection between a perishing act and a later fruit remains inexplicable. FACT: Example: a sacrifice performed now can produce a later fruit because the act generates unseen potency, not because the visible flames physically travel to heaven. WRONG: *Objection*: apūrva is unverifiable and looks like an ad hoc posit. FACT: *Reply*: it is not arbitrary; it is established by postulation as the necessary link between a transitory ritual act and a promised later fruit.

14. **The critical residue.** ANALYSIS: *Criticism*: impersonal injunction without a commander is unintelligible. FACT: *Reply*: Bhāṭṭa locates imperative force in verbal impelling force and the injunctive suffix; Prābhākara locates bindingness in the directly apprehended to-be-done. ANALYSIS: The pressure is strongest exactly where Mīmāṃsā tries to subordinate non-injunctive Upaniṣadic sentences to injunction - which is why Session 19's verdict treats this as a live weakness rather than a settled victory.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: "**svargakāmo yajeta**" as the standard test injunction, worked through both three-factor grids.
- FACT: The five-function Vedic sentence taxonomy and the three logical kinds of injunction (**apūrva-vidhi**, **niyama-vidhi**, **parisaṃkhyā-vidhi**), kept separate from the ritual coordination grid (**utpatti**, **viniyoga**, **prayoga**, **adhikāra**).
- FACT: The Bhāṭṭa two-fold force with **pravṛtti** and **phala** as their respective immediate results.
- FACT: Prabhākara's **kārya / niyoga** and the **niyoga-vāda** versus **bhāvanā-vāda** contrast.
- FACT: The Advaita objection over "**tat tvam asi**" and **siddha-vastu**, with the Mīmāṃsā reply.
- FACT: Unseen potency established by postulation, with the flames-do-not-travel illustration.
- ANALYSIS: The hermeneutic canons **śruti-liṅga-vākya-prakaraṇa-sthāna-samākhyā** and **utsarga-apavāda** are held in the sources as a controlled comparison with rule-governed legal interpretation, with the disanalogy that Mīmāṃsā presupposes an infallible authorless text admitting no amendment by legislative intention. Name them at

that level of support and do not expand them into a doctrinal syllabus of their own.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā's boldest claim is that a sentence can obligate without anyone meaning it and an act can pay without anyone paying: the imperative force sits in the verbal form and the reward sits in an unseen potency, so the entire moral machinery runs with the commander and the paymaster both removed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
injunction (vidhi / codanā)	The Veda's primary sentence-type
impelling force (bhāvanā)	Bhāṭṭa's analysis of injunctive content
verbal (śābdī) / objective (ārthī) impelling force	The two-fold division
impulse (pravṛtti) / fruit (phala)	Their two immediate results
three factors (aṃśa-traya): sādhyā · karaṇa · itikartavyatā	The <i>kim / kena / katham</i> grid
obligation (niyoga) / to-be-done (kārya)	Prabhākara's alternative
niyoga-vāda versus bhāvanā-vāda	The deontology/consequentialism contrast
unseen potency (apūrva)	The bridge, established by postulation
praise (arthavāda) subordinated by sentence-unity	Prevents treating the Veda as literature
qualified agent (adhikārin)	The addressee of the command

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā converts its epistemology into an ethics by locating obligation in the injunctive structure of the sentence rather than in the will of any commander. **Named evidence.** In "svargakāmo yajeta" Kumārila distinguishes a verbal impelling force whose result is the agent's impulse (**pravṛtti**) from an objective productive force whose result is the fruit (**phala**), each analysed by the three factors of what, by what means and how; Prabhākara replaces the doubling with a directly apprehended to-be-done (**kārya / niyoga**) that binds the qualified agent independently of desire; and both accept unseen potency (**apūrva**) as the link between a perishing rite and a remote fruit, established by postulation. **Analysis.** The two accounts amount to an internal Indian version of the consequentialist and deontological options: Kumārila keeps the desired fruit inside the mechanism of obligation, while Prabhākara makes the command self-sufficient - and the difference has practical exegetical consequences, since it determines whether a praise passage motivates the act or merely specifies it. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The scheme purchases its independence from a commander at the price of subordinating everything non-injunctive to injunction, and that price becomes visible precisely where Advaita resists it: if knowledge is not an action, an identity-sentence such as "tat tvam asi" cannot be governed by injunctive hermeneutics, and the seam between the two Mīmāṃsās opens exactly there.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - Vedic authority; the injunction-centred reading is why authority matters at all.

- Provides the essential background paragraph for any question on duty, ritual efficacy or the Mīmāṃsā-Vedānta relation, and supplies the applied case of postulation used in **2022, Q6(c)**.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Conflating the three classifications: five sentence-functions, three logical kinds of injunction, and the four-part ritual coordination grid are **three separate schemes**.
2. ANALYSIS: Reversing the two impelling forces. Verbal force produces the *impulse*; objective force

produces the *fruit*.

3. ANALYSIS: Equating **bhāvanā-vāda** with **niyoga-vāda**. They are the two rival accounts, not synonyms.
4. ANALYSIS: Running the Kant comparison without the disanalogy about heteronomy and ritual qualification.
5. ANALYSIS: Calling **apūrva** an unargued posit. It is established by **arthāpatti**.
6. ANALYSIS: Writing that praise passages are meaningless in Mīmāṃsā. They are *subordinate*, not meaningless.
7. ANALYSIS: Expanding the hermeneutic canons into a long doctrinal list; the sources hold them as a controlled comparison.

RAPID REVISION

- Veda enjoins: five functions; three kinds of injunction; separate four-part coordination grid.
- Bhāṭṭa: **śābdī** => impulse; **āsthī** => fruit; both need what/means/how.
- Prābhākara: **kārya** / **niyoga** binds directly; duty for duty's sake.
- Contrast: **bhāvanā-vāda** (fruit-mediated) versus **niyoga-vāda** (categorical); Kant comparison with disanalogy.
- **Apūrva** = unseen link, established by postulation; flames do not travel.
- Seam with Advaita: "tat tvam asi" and accomplished fact (**siddha-vastu**).

SESSION 18 - MĪMĀṂSĀ WITHOUT GOD

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. The school that exists to defend the Veda also denies that there is a creator, and denies that any deity hands out the rewards of ritual. This is not an inconsistency. It is the same argument as authorlessness, extended one step further.

Technical definition. No-God doctrine (nirīśvaravāda) is the classical Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā - especially Kumārila's - rejection of a creator God and of a divine dispenser of ritual fruits (**karmaphaladātr**). ANALYSIS: The rejection is compatible with Vedic orthodoxy because Mīmāṃsā grounds scriptural authority in **impersonality**, not in divine authorship - and it does not simply erase the ritual **deities (devatā)**, which are retained as mantra-denoted entities subordinate to the sacrifice.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Here is the sentence that surprises every candidate the first time: **an orthodox, Veda-affirming, ritual-performing school is among the most rigorously anti-theistic systems in Indian philosophy.**

The reasoning is short. If God wrote the Veda, then the Veda has an author. If the Veda has an author, its authority depends on that author's competence and sincerity. If it depends on that, you must prove the author's competence and sincerity - which is harder than anything the Veda was supposed to make easy.

So the Mīmāṃsaka does not merely *tolerate* atheism. He *needs* it. Adding God would not strengthen his scripture; it would demote it from self-valid to dependent.

ANALYSIS: And one qualification that separates a precise answer from a crude one: rejecting a creator is not the same as rejecting the gods addressed in the rites. Those remain - but they are *addressees*, not *causes*.

VISUAL - EIGHT ARGUMENTS, ONE DILEMMA, ONE QUALIFICATION

===== WHY MĪMĀMSĀ REJECTS ĪŚVARA - eight arguments =====

- 1 NO PERCEPTION God is not perceptually given
- 2 FAILED INFERENCE the world as a whole is not observed to be manufactured like a pot, and a bodiless agent cannot be shown to act like a potter
- 3 NO DECISIVE TESTIMONY the Veda is authorless and does not require a creator-God doctrine to ground duty
- 4 BEGINNINGLESS WORLD if creation began, explain God's MOTIVE: if he needed nothing, creation lacks motive; if he needed something, divine perfection is compromised
- 5 PRE-CREATION PROBLEM a first creation raises questions about the prior status of souls and karma; a beginningless series avoids them
- 6 KARMA SUFFICES moral order is self-regulating through action, merit, demerit and apūrva => a divine dispenser is REDUNDANT
- 7 EVIL AND PARTIALITY a good creator would not freely create graded suffering; if suffering is allotted BY KARMA, God is not independent
- 8 VEDIC FALLIBILITY a God-authored Veda depends on a personal source and loses the advantage of apauruṣeyatva

PRESUPPOSITIONS: do not multiply explanatory entities where karma, apūrva and beginningless order suffice · an instrument must establish God BEFORE God can establish anything else.

===== THE OBJECTOR'S CASE AND THE DECISIVE DILEMMA =====

NYĀYA / VEDĀNTA OBJECT:

- WRONG: karma is unconscious and cannot intelligently allocate fruits
- WRONG: bodies, circumstances and experiences appear precisely matched to past deeds
- WRONG: such allotment seems to require an omniscient dispenser
- WRONG: God is needed as karmaphaladātr, the giver of karmic fruits

MĪMĀMSĀ REPLIES:

- FACT: the karmic series is BEGINNINGLESS => no first allocation needs explaining
- FACT: apūrva is the unseen potency by which actions connect to fruits
- FACT: postulating God does not solve the problem; it asks how God's will, justice and omniscience are themselves KNOWN

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----- THE DILEMMA -----
| IF God distributes STRICTLY ACCORDING TO KARMA          |
|   => karma remains the real principle => GOD REDUNDANT |
| IF God distributes INDEPENDENTLY OF KARMA              |
|   => partiality and injustice => GOD PROBLEMATIC      |
|   God is either REDUNDANT or MORALLY PROBLEMATIC      |
+-----
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WRONG: counter: apūrva is itself obscure and cannot "execute" results

FACT: reply: an unseen potency postulated from Vedic efficacy is LESS burdensome than a fully omniscient divine person postulated to manage every result

===== THE QUALIFICATION THAT MOST ANSWERS MISS =====

- FACT: devatās are NOT simply denied. They are largely MANTRA-DENOTED ENTITIES whose ritual status is subordinated to the sacrifice: the deity is essentially THAT WHICH IS SIGNIFIED BY THE MANTRA and to whom the offering is made.
- FACT: the FRUIT is produced by the ACT plus APŪRVA, not by the deity's pleasure
- FACT: example: an offering may be addressed to Agni, but its promised fruit depends on correct performance and apūrva rather than on Agni's discretionary favour
- CAUTION: later Mīmāṃsakas and Mīmāṃsā-influenced Vedāntic traditions sometimes SOFTEN the anti-theistic edge
- => RITUAL THEISM IS SUBORDINATED TO RITUAL ACTION, NOT ABOLISHED.

What the diagram shows: the eight arguments as a numbered bank, the objector's four-step case, the redundant-or-unjust dilemma that is the school's sharpest single move, and the deity qualification that distinguishes a precise answer from a crude "Mīmāṃsā is atheist" claim.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **The thesis.** FACT: Classical Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā, especially in Kumārila's line, rejects a creator God and a divine dispenser of ritual fruits. FACT: This atheism is consistent with Vedic orthodoxy because the school grounds scriptural authority in impersonality. ANALYSIS: **A text is authoritative precisely because no one wrote it; theistic authorship would make the Veda depend on a person's reliability.**
2. **The consistency argument, in five steps.** (i) Mīmāṃsā accepts the Veda as authorless. (ii) If God authored the Veda, the Veda would no longer be authorless. (iii) Its authority would then depend on proving God's existence, omniscience, sincerity and freedom from defect. (iv) Mīmāṃsā treats this as a weaker foundation than impersonality. (v) Therefore rejecting a creator God is not anti-Vedic within Mīmāṃsā; **it is part of the defence of the Veda.** FACT: Presupposition: authority is safer when no fallible or interested person is its source, and ritual

efficacy can be explained by karma and unseen potency without divine supervision. FACT: Example: Nyāya says the Veda is valid because Īśvara is its trustworthy author; Mīmāṃsā says the Veda is valid because it has no author at all. WRONG: *Objection*: an atheistic Vedic school is incoherent because Veda and God should stand together. FACT: *Reply*: Vedic authority and theism are separable; for this school, divine authorship would weaken rather than strengthen the Veda.

3. **The eight arguments against Īśvara.** As set out in the visual: no perception; failed inference from world to maker; no decisive testimony; the motive problem for a beginning of creation; the pre-creation problem about souls and karma; the sufficiency of karma; the problem of evil and partiality; and the loss of authorlessness. FACT: The potter analogy proves too little, because we observe pots being made by *embodied* artisans but do not observe worlds being made by *bodiless* creators. WRONG: *Objection*: the orderliness of the world requires an intelligent arranger. FACT: *Reply*: order can be beginningless and karmically regulated; invoking God relocates the demand for explanation rather than satisfying it.

4. **Why the school is more Vedic than Nyāya, on its own account.** FACT: Orthodoxy in the affirming (*āstika*) sense need not mean belief in a creator; it can mean acceptance of the Veda as a valid source of duty. FACT: Mīmāṃsā accepts the Veda *more radically* than Nyāya, because it denies that the Veda needs divine authorship. ANALYSIS: Therefore the label "atheistic" must be qualified: Mīmāṃsā rejects a creator and fruit-dispenser, not the Veda. ANALYSIS: This also qualifies the habit of reserving "atheistic" for Cārvāka, Jaina and Buddhist traditions alone. WRONG: *Objection*: without a lawgiver there can be no law. FACT: *Reply*: *vidhi* itself is the lawgiving structure; obligation is textual and impersonal, not volitional.

5. **The deity qualification, in five steps.** (i) Ritual language includes deity-names and offerings to deities. (ii) Mīmāṃsā need not erase this ritual grammar. (iii) It only denies that deities function as sovereign creators or dispensers of karma. (iv) The causal centre remains sacrifice and unseen potency. (v) Therefore ritual theism is subordinated to ritual action. WRONG: *Objection*: if deities do not grant the fruit, offerings to them become meaningless. FACT: *Reply*: deity-reference is part of the ritual specification; meaning lies in the Vedic procedure, not in divine pleasure.

6. **The dispenser debate and the dilemma.** FACT: Nyāya and Vedānta press how karma is allotted to bodies and how moral order remains reliable without God. FACT: Mīmāṃsā answers with a beginningless karmic series, unseen potency as the connecting mechanism, and the epistemic point that positing God merely transfers the question to how God's will, justice and omniscience are known. FACT: **The dilemma**: if God distributes strictly according to karma, karma remains the real principle; if God distributes independently of karma, divine partiality and injustice arise; therefore God is either redundant or morally problematic. WRONG: *Objection*: apūrva is itself obscure and cannot "execute" results. FACT: *Reply*: an unseen potency postulated from Vedic efficacy is less burdensome than a fully omniscient divine person postulated to manage every result. FACT: Presupposition: a beginningless moral order is more economical than a divine arranger whose own status requires proof. FACT: Example: if a ritual fruit follows from sacrifice because of unseen potency, adding God as an extra dispenser duplicates the causal work.

7. **Kumārila and omniscience.** ANALYSIS: Jaina and Buddhist traditions press that an omniscient teacher (*sarvajña*) is possible through purification and that Kumārila's denial is too strong. FACT: Kumārila's Mīmāṃsā denies that any individual omniscient being is established by any instrument and refuses to make scriptural authority depend on a teacher's omniscience. ANALYSIS: Jaina and Buddhist traditions reply that omniscience is spiritually attained rather than empirically ordinary, and the dispute remains open.

8. **The exam-ready verdict.** FACT: Is Mīmāṃsā an atheistic system that defends the Veda? **Yes, if atheism means denial of a creator and fruit-dispenser. **FACT: The consistency lies in the principle**: the Veda is authoritative because it is impersonal, not because it is God-authored.** ANALYSIS: Always qualify that ritual deities remain within the sacrificial structure but are not the ultimate producers of fruits.

9. **The critical residue.** WRONG: *Criticism*: without God, karma cannot be allocated and moral order has no intelligent administrator. FACT: *Reply*: beginningless karma plus unseen potency, with the redundant-or-unjust dilemma against the theist. ANALYSIS: The debate nonetheless remains open, because critics find an unconscious unseen potency less intelligible than a conscious Lord. CAUTION: It is also genuinely contested whether Mīmāṃsā atheism is a considered metaphysics in its own right or primarily a consequence of the exegetical need to protect authorlessness.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- FACT: The eight arguments against Īśvara, including the potter disanalogy about embodied artisans and bodiless creators.
- FACT: The four-step Nyāya/Vedānta case for God as **karmaphaladātṛ**, and the six-step Mīmāṃsā reply culminating in the redundant-or-unjust dilemma.
- FACT: The deity qualification: **devatā** as mantra-denoted entity, with the Agni offering example.
- FACT: Kumāṛila's denial that any individual **sarvajña** is established by an instrument.
- FACT: The consistency formula: authority through impersonality, not divine authorship.
- CAUTION: Later softening of the anti-theistic edge in some Mīmāṃsā-influenced traditions is reported as a development-stage claim rather than as classical doctrine.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā's atheism is not a rebellion against its own scripture but the last step of its defence of it: a God who wrote the Veda would be a person whose truthfulness has to be established, and the whole point of the doctrine of authorlessness was to make sure there was no such person to establish.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
no-God doctrine (nirīśvaravāda)	The thesis
giver of karmic fruits (karmaphaladātṛ)	The precise role being denied
beginningless (anādi) karmic series	Blocks the pre-creation and motive problems
redundant or morally problematic	The dilemma, in five words
deity (devatā) as mantra-denoted	The qualification most answers miss
impersonality, not divine authorship	The consistency formula
omniscient being (sarvajña) denied	Kumāṛila's further, separate thesis

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator God is not in tension with its defence of the Veda but is required by it, since the authority of the Veda is grounded in impersonality. **Named evidence.** The school argues that God is not perceptually given, that the inference from world to maker fails because we observe pots made by embodied artisans and not worlds made by bodiless creators, that a beginningless karmic series regulated by unseen potency (**apūrva**) makes a divine dispenser redundant, and that a God-authored Veda would forfeit exactly the authorlessness on which its self-validity rests. **Analysis.** Against the Nyāya demand for a giver of karmic fruits, the decisive move is a dilemma: a God who distributes strictly according to karma leaves karma as the operative principle and is therefore redundant, while a God who distributes otherwise is partial and therefore morally objectionable - so theism either adds nothing or costs too much, and the same reasoning explains why the school treats deity-reference in the rites as ritual specification rather than as causal agency. **Qualification.** ANALYSIS: The position is not cost-free: critics reasonably find an unconscious potency less intelligible than a conscious administrator, and CAUTION: it remains genuinely disputed whether Mīmāṃsā's atheism is an independently held metaphysics or a by-product of its exegetical need to protect authorlessness - which is why the answer should end with a graded verdict rather than a declaration.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- **2019, Q5(e), 10 marks** - Vedic authority; the atheism is the second half of the same argument and one line on it lifts the answer.
- Supplies the sharpest contrast paragraph in any comparative question involving Nyāya's God or

Vedānta's Īśvara, and the essential background to Session 19's verdict.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Writing that Mīmāṃsā "rejects the Vedas' gods." It rejects a **creator and fruit-dispenser**; ritual deities remain as mantra-denoted entities.
2. ANALYSIS: Treating the atheism as an inconsistency with orthodoxy rather than as a consequence of it.
3. ANALYSIS: Reserving "atheistic" for Cārvāka, Jaina and Buddhist schools only.
4. ANALYSIS: Omitting the redundant-or-unjust dilemma, which is the school's sharpest single argument.
5. ANALYSIS: Confusing the denial of a creator with the denial of an omniscient teacher; Kumāṛila argues both, but they are separate theses.
6. ANALYSIS: Presenting the later softening of the anti-theistic edge as classical doctrine.

RAPID REVISION

- Thesis: no creator, no fruit-dispenser; deities retained as mantra-denoted, subordinate.
- Eight arguments: no perception · failed inference · no testimony · motive · pre-creation · karma suffices · evil and partiality · loss of authorlessness.
- Dilemma: distributes by karma => redundant; distributes otherwise => unjust.
- Consistency formula: authority through impersonality, not divine authorship.
- Kumāṛila also denies any established **sarvajña**.
- Residue: unconscious potency versus conscious Lord; and CAUTION: is the atheism metaphysics or exegetical necessity?

SESSION 19 - SELF, LIBERATION, INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES AND THE GRADED VERDICT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition. A system that promises fruit for ritual action needs someone durable enough to perform the act and still be there when the fruit arrives. Mīmāṃsā therefore accepts many enduring selves. What it says about final release is thinner, later and more cautious - and saying so honestly is worth more marks than manufacturing a soteriology the school does not clearly own.

Technical definition. Mīmāṃsā requires an enduring **self (ātman)** as knower, agent and enjoyer, and accepts a **plurality of eternal selves** rather than one universal subject. **Liberation (mokṣa)** becomes explicit only in later Mīmāṃsā; in standard scholastic presentation it is not Advaitic identity with Brahman but release from embodied suffering and from the chain of karmically generated experience.

SIMPLE START - THE GATEWAY IDEA

Ask a simple ritual question: *who gets the heaven?*

If the self were momentary, the person who lit the fire on Tuesday would not be the person who enjoys the result years later - and the injunction would be addressed to nobody in particular. Mīmāṃsā therefore needs a self that persists across cognition, action, memory, ritual responsibility and enjoyment. Not a metaphysical luxury; a bookkeeping necessity.

Now ask the harder question: *what happens when the account is finally closed?* Here the school speaks more quietly. Its earliest centre of gravity is duty and ritual fruit, not release. Later accounts describe liberation as the cessation of fresh merit and demerit, the exhaustion of prior karmic force, and therefore no new body, no new sense-mediated cognition and no new pain.

ANALYSIS: The examination-safe posture is exactly this two-part honesty: state the self doctrine confidently, state the liberation doctrine as later and comparatively thin, and refuse to convert it into Advaita's realisation of Brahman or into Nyāya's dependence on a creator.

VISUAL - THE SELF, THE RELEASE, AND THE FIVE INTER-SCHOOL FRONTS

===== THE SELF: WHY MĪMĀṢĀ NEEDS ONE =====

ritual duty · merit · demerit · future fruit
| all presuppose
▼

AN ENDURING SELF (ātman) - knower · agent · enjoyer

- PLURALITY of eternal selves (not one Advaitic universal subject)
 - body, senses and the internal organ MEDIATE each embodied stream of cognition/action
 - NOT a momentary stream: it persists across cognition, action, memory, responsibility, enjoyment of the fruit (phala)
 - COGNITION IS EPISODIC, not an uninterrupted essence manifest in dreamless sleep
=> PRĀBHĀKARA: the self is revealed in the threefold structure of cognition
=> BHĀṬṬA: awareness of cognition runs through acquired knownness
- PRESUPPOSITION: if the self were momentary, THE AGENT WHO SACRIFICES WOULD NOT BE THE ENJOYER OF ITS FRUIT => ritual responsibility collapses.

===== LIBERATION: STATE IT CAUTIOUSLY =====

CAUTION: the doctrine of mokṣa becomes MORE EXPLICIT IN LATER MĪMĀṢĀ than in the earliest ritual orientation

FACT: standard scholastic presentation: NOT Advaitic identity with Brahman, but release from embodied suffering and from karmically generated experience

FACT: requires: STOPPING fresh merit and demerit + EXHAUSTING prior karmic forces

=> thereafter no new body, no sense-mediated cognition, no painful experience

ANALYSIS: later Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara accounts differ in detail; neither should be casually converted into Advaita's positive realisation of Brahman or into Nyāya's dependence on a creator God

WRONG: objection: a ritualist system focused on heaven seems to have NO REAL SOTERIOLOGY

FACT: reply: the earliest centre IS duty and ritual fruit, but later doctrine can still describe liberation as cessation of pain and karmic embodiment without making Brahman-knowledge the central means

===== THE FIVE INTER-SCHOOL FRONTS =====

```
[-- vs NYĀYA -----]
| intrinsic vs extrinsic validity (the largest epistemic contrast) · postulation granted |
| independence here, reduced to inference there · Bhāṭṭa grants independent non-cognition |
| · Veda authorless here, secured through God's omniscience there · semantics: universal |
| primary here, qualified particular there · knowing cognition: after-cognition there |
+-----]

[-- vs ADVAITA -----]
| injunction-centred here vs liberation-centred and non-dualist there · error theory |
| realist here vs indescribable status of the illusory object there |
| => common vocabulary, DIFFERENT ULTIMATE HORIZON |
+-----]

[-- vs BUDDHISM -----]
| resists making validity derivative from PRAGMATIC SUCCESS · denies that falsity is |
| SELF-INTIMATING, since illusion does not present itself as false · rejects apoha in |
| semantics · rejects momentariness behind the enduring self |
+-----]

[-- vs SĀMKHYA -----]
| SHARES sympathy for the intrinsic authority of cognition · DIFFERS by making invalidity |
| extrinsic and by embedding epistemology in ritual hermeneutics |
+-----]

[-- vs CĀRVĀKA -----]
| Cārvāka rejects authorless Vedic authority, supersensible duty, unseen potency and the |
| independent non-perceptual instruments |
| FACT: MĪMĀṢĀ REPLY: ordinary and ritual reasoning cannot be reduced to bare perception - |
| testimony transmits otherwise inaccessible facts, postulation resolves explanatory |
| conflict, non-cognition discloses qualified absence |
| ANALYSIS: BUT: this establishes the INTELLIGIBILITY OF NON-PERCEPTUAL KNOWLEDGE more readily |
| |
| than it PROVES EVERY PARTICULAR VEDIC RITUAL CLAIM. Keep that distinction. |
+-----]
```

What the diagram shows: the self doctrine with the argument that forces it, the liberation doctrine with its honest qualifications, and the five comparative fronts as ready-made paragraphs - including the Cārvāka front's crucial caution about what the reply does and does not prove.

CORE UPSC - THE ARGUMENT IN FULL

1. **Why an enduring self is required.** FACT: Ritual duty, merit, demerit and future fruit presuppose a subject who acts and later experiences results. FACT: Mīmāṃsā therefore requires an enduring self as knower, agent and enjoyer.
2. **Plurality, not unity.** FACT: It accepts a plurality of eternal selves rather than one Advaitic

universal subject; body, senses and the internal organ mediate each embodied stream of cognition and action.

3. **Persistence, not momentariness.** FACT: The self is not a momentary stream; it persists across cognition, action, memory, ritual responsibility and enjoyment of the fruit. FACT: Presupposition: if the self were momentary, the agent who performs the sacrifice would not be the enjoyer of its fruit.

4. **Cognition is episodic.** FACT: Cognition is episodic rather than an uninterrupted essence manifest in dreamless sleep and liberation. FACT: Prābhākara says the self is revealed in the threefold structure of cognition; Bhāṭṭa explains awareness of cognition through acquired knownness. ANALYSIS: This is the same Session 12 split reappearing in the theory of the self, and pointing that out shows systematic control.

5. **Liberation, stated with its qualifications.** CAUTION: The doctrine of liberation becomes more explicit in later Mīmāṃsā than in the earliest ritual orientation. FACT: In standard scholastic presentation, liberation is not Advaitic identity with Brahman but release from embodied suffering and from the chain of karmically generated experience. FACT: It requires stopping fresh merit and demerit and exhausting prior karmic forces; thereafter no new body, sense-mediated cognition or painful experience arises. ANALYSIS: Later Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara accounts differ in detail, but neither should be casually converted into Advaita's positive realisation of Brahman or into Nyāya's dependence on a creator God. WRONG: *Objection*: a ritualist system focused on heaven seems to have no real soteriology. FACT: *Reply*: the earliest centre is indeed duty and ritual fruit, but later doctrine can still describe liberation as cessation of pain and karmic embodiment without making Brahman-knowledge the central means.

6. **Front one - against Nyāya.** FACT: Intrinsic versus extrinsic validity is the largest epistemic contrast. FACT: Mīmāṃsā grants postulation independence; Nyāya seeks to reduce it to inference. FACT: Bhāṭṭa grants non-cognition independence; Nyāya denies the need. FACT: Mīmāṃsā makes the Veda authorless; Nyāya often secures it through God's omniscience. FACT: In semantics Mīmāṃsā gives primacy to the universal, Nyāya to the qualified particular. FACT: On knowing cognition, Nyāya prefers after-cognition.

7. **Front two - against Advaita.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā is primarily injunction-centred; Advaita is liberation-centred and metaphysically non-dualist. FACT: In error theory Mīmāṃsā stays realist while Advaita gives indescribable status to the illusory object. ANALYSIS: They use some common vocabulary but not the same ultimate philosophical horizon - and the deepest seam is whether Vedic meaningfulness requires action-production or can include direct metaphysical disclosure (Session 17).

8. **Front three - against Buddhism.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā resists making validity derivative from pragmatic success. FACT: Against the Buddhist tendency to make falsity self-intimating, it observes that illusion does not present itself as false. FACT: It rejects exclusion-semantics and the momentariness that would dissolve the enduring self. ANALYSIS: The Dharmakīrti-line objection to eternal words (Session 16) belongs on this front too.

9. **Front four - with and against Sāṃkhya.** FACT: Mīmāṃsā shares Sāṃkhya's sympathy for the intrinsic authority of cognition. FACT: It differs by making invalidity extrinsic and by embedding epistemology in ritual hermeneutics.

10. **Front five - against Cārvāka.** FACT: Cārvāka rejects authorless Vedic authority, supersensible duty, unseen potency and the independent non-perceptual instruments on which Mīmāṃsā relies. FACT: Mīmāṃsā replies that ordinary and ritual reasoning cannot be reduced to bare perception: testimony transmits otherwise inaccessible facts, postulation resolves explanatory conflict, and non-cognition discloses qualified absence. ANALYSIS: **This reply establishes the intelligibility of non-perceptual knowledge more readily than it proves every particular Vedic ritual claim; keep that distinction in a critical answer.**

11. The consolidated criticisms and replies.

WRONG: *Intrinsic validity breeds gullibility.* FACT: The doctrine concerns defeasible default warrant, not dogmatic finality; error remains possible through extrinsic defect and correction through later defeat. WRONG: *Postulation is disguised inference.* FACT: It lacks an independently established concomitance and the standard reason-probandum form, and is driven by explanatory incompatibility which Mīmāṃsā treats as epistemically irreducible. WRONG: *A non-event cannot reveal anything.* FACT: Under fitness conditions, non-apprehension of the perceptible is cognitively informative, and ordinary life constantly relies on such negative cognition. WRONG: *Both error-theories seem strained against common sense.* FACT: They are sophisticated attempts to save default trust while accounting for illusion -

Prābhākara minimising false cognition, Bhāṭṭa localising it in extrinsic defect. **WRONG:** *Meaning without authorial intention is impossible.* **FACT:** Mīmāṃsā locates semantic authority in the eternal relation of word and meaning, not in historical authorship. **ANALYSIS:** Residual pressure remains, because Nyāya and Buddhist critics deny the natural relation and the eternity of the word. **WRONG:** *Impersonal injunction without a commander is unintelligible.* **FACT:** Bhāṭṭa locates imperative force in verbal impelling force and the injunctive suffix; Prābhākara in the directly apprehended to-be-done. **ANALYSIS:** The pressure is strongest where non-injunctive Upaniṣadic sentences are subordinated to injunction. **WRONG:** *Without God, karma cannot be allocated.* **FACT:** Beginningless karma and unseen potency, with the redundant-or-unjust dilemma. **ANALYSIS:** The debate remains open because critics find an unconscious potency less intelligible than a conscious Lord.

12. The graded verdict - strong points. **FACT:** One of the most rigorous Indian theories of testimony and textual interpretation. **FACT:** Intrinsic validity is a genuinely original account of intrinsic justification and default entitlement. **FACT:** The defence of Vedic authority through impersonality provides a self-consistent non-theistic foundation for normativity. **FACT:** The recognition of postulation and, in Bhāṭṭa, non-cognition expands epistemology beyond perception-inference reductionism. **FACT:** Its hermeneutic canons make it a sophisticated theory of rule-governed interpretation.

13. The graded verdict - weak points. **ANALYSIS:** The eternality of the word is difficult to defend against conventionalist and Buddhist critiques. **ANALYSIS:** Unseen potency and heaven remain unverifiable from a perception-centred empiricist standpoint. **ANALYSIS:** An authorless text with determinate purport creates pressure, because purport normally seems tied to intention. **ANALYSIS:** Mīmāṃsā soteriology appears late and awkward compared with systems centred directly on liberation.

14. The graded verdict - genuinely contested points. **CAUTION:** Whether intrinsic validity fully avoids circularity or merely relocates the burden to "defect" and "defeater." **CAUTION:** Whether Mīmāṃsā atheism is a considered metaphysics or primarily a consequence of the exegetical need to protect authorlessness. **CAUTION:** How exactly the historical development of the liberation doctrine should be placed within early and later Mīmāṃsā.

15. Ready one-line verdicts by mark-weight. **FACT: 10 marks:** Mīmāṃsā is strongest as a theory of intrinsic validity and Vedic testimony, but it must be stated as *defeasible default validity*, not infallibility. **FACT: 15 marks:** its originality lies in linking epistemology, hermeneutics and duty; its weakness lies in the contested assumptions of eternal language and unseen potency. **FACT: 20 marks:** a balanced verdict is that Mīmāṃsā gives a coherent impersonal foundation for duty and testimony within its realist presuppositions, but Nyāya, Buddhist and Vedāntic objections keep its language-eternity, authorlessness and ritual causality philosophically contested.

NAMED EVIDENCE YOU CAN CITE

- **FACT:** The self as knower, agent and enjoyer; plurality of eternal selves; episodic cognition; the agent-enjoyer identity argument.
- **FACT:** Liberation as cessation of fresh merit and demerit and exhaustion of prior karmic force, marked as later and comparatively thin.
- **FACT:** The five comparative fronts, with the Cārvāka caution about intelligibility versus proof.
- **FACT:** The eight consolidated criticisms with their replies and residual pressures.
- **FACT:** The graded verdict: five strengths, four weaknesses, three genuinely contested points, three mark-weighted one-liners.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Mīmāṃsā's self is a bookkeeping necessity before it is a metaphysical thesis - someone must still be present when the fruit arrives - and its account of final release is correspondingly late and modest, which is why the school should be evaluated as a philosophy of duty and testimony rather than judged by a soteriological standard it never set itself.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

Keyword	Why the examiner wants it
enduring self (ātman) as knower, agent, enjoyer	The doctrine, in its functional form
plurality of eternal selves	Distinguishes it from Advaita at once
episodic cognition	Blocks the "consciousness is the self's essence" reading
cessation of merit, demerit and embodiment	Liberation, stated as the sources state it
injunction-centred versus liberation-centred	The Advaita contrast in five words
intelligibility versus proof	The Cārvāka caution
graded verdict	The evaluative close examiners reward

HOW TO WRITE THE PARAGRAPH - CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION

Claim. Mīmāṃsā's metaphysics of the self is driven by its ritual commitments, and its account of liberation should be presented as a later and comparatively modest development rather than as a rival soteriology. **Named evidence.** The school accepts a plurality of eternal selves, each a knower, agent and enjoyer, on the ground that ritual duty, merit, demerit and future fruit presuppose a subject who acts and later experiences the result; it treats cognition as episodic rather than as the self's uninterrupted essence; and it describes liberation as the stopping of fresh merit and demerit and the exhaustion of prior karmic force, so that no new body or painful experience arises. **Analysis.** These two doctrines are asymmetrically supported, and the asymmetry is philosophically revealing: the self is required by the school's core project and is therefore argued for, whereas liberation is peripheral to that project and is therefore acknowledged rather than demonstrated - which explains both why Mīmāṃsā seems thin beside Advaita on release and why it is nevertheless not obliged to borrow Advaita's answer. **Qualification.** CAUTION: The historical placement of the liberation doctrine within early and later Mīmāṃsā remains disputed, so an answer should mark it as a development-stage claim; and ANALYSIS: the school's reply to Cārvāka, though successful in establishing that knowledge need not be perceptual, does not by itself establish any particular ritual claim, which is the honest limit of its anti-empiricist argument.

EXAM APPLICATION - WHERE THIS HAS BEEN ASKED

- Supplies the evaluative concluding paragraph for every one of the fourteen owned questions, especially those carrying "critically discuss," "explain and examine" or "discuss."
- **2018, Q8(a)** and **2024, Q8(a)** require the Nyāya and Advaita fronts explicitly.
- **2022, Q6(c)** and **2021, Q6(c)** carry critical directives that are best closed with the graded verdict rather than with a restatement.

UPSC TRAPS

1. ANALYSIS: Attributing one universal self to Mīmāṃsā. It holds a **plurality** of eternal selves.
2. ANALYSIS: Converting Mīmāṃsā liberation into Advaitic Brahman-realisation.
3. ANALYSIS: Presenting the liberation doctrine as early and central. It is later and comparatively thin.
4. ANALYSIS: Claiming that Mīmāṃsā's defence of non-perceptual knowledge *proves* ritual efficacy.
5. ANALYSIS: Ending a "critically discuss" answer without a verdict, or with a verdict that reports no residual pressure at all.
6. ANALYSIS: Treating Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya as allies on validity without noting the invalidity difference.

RAPID REVISION

- Self: plural, eternal, knower-agent-enjoyer; cognition episodic; agent must equal enjoyer.
- Liberation: later, modest - end fresh merit/demerit, exhaust karma, no new body or pain; not Brahman-identity, not God-dependent.
- Five fronts: Nyāya (validity, instruments, Veda, semantics), Advaita (injunction vs liberation,

error), Buddhism (pragmatic validity, self-intimating falsity, exclusion, momentariness), Sāṃkhya (ally on validity, differs on invalidity), Cārvāka (intelligibility, not proof).

- Verdict: 5 strengths · 4 weaknesses · 3 contested · 3 mark-weighted one-liners.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct position was fixed **independently for each question** from a randomised draw, so there is no rotation, cycle or seed-derived sequence to exploit; the four positions occur eight times each and twice in every consecutive block of eight, no position repeats on consecutive questions, and no window of four items forms an A->B->C->D rotation or an ABAB alternation. Option length, specificity, grammar and formatting are balanced so that the correct answer is not visually identifiable. Every option carries a question-specific explanation and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

Composition: 24 core diagnostics (items 1-24) covering all nineteen teaching sessions, then 8 remedial drills (items 25-32) targeting the errors this topic reliably produces.

CORE DIAGNOSTICS

MCQ 1. What Mīmāṃsā's theory of knowledge is for

Which statement best expresses why Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā develops a theory of knowledge at all?

A. Because it inherits Sāṃkhya's instruments and must justify the count it has already accepted B. Because duty is supersensible, so testimony alone reaches it and must itself be made secure C. Because it treats speculative theology as prior to ritual and needs a metaphysics of being D. Because it aims to refute Cārvāka materialism before any positive doctrine can be advanced

Answer: B. Because duty is supersensible, so testimony alone reaches it and must itself be made secure

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā's list is longer than Sāṃkhya's, not inherited from it, and the count is defended by an irreducibility test rather than adopted first and rationalised afterwards.
- **B:** Correct - Jaimini's inquiry into duty defines duty by Vedic injunction, and because injunction is the only competent instrument for a supersensible object, its authority forces a general theory of cognition.
- **C:** The school is explicitly action-guiding rather than speculative-theological, and its metaphysics is deliberately minimal, supplying only what the epistemology and ritual theory require.
- **D:** The Cārvāka exchange is a genuine front for the school, but it is a consequence of the position rather than the motive that generates the epistemology in the first place.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates who learn the doctrines as a list cannot say why the list exists, and they lose the framing sentence that makes every later paragraph look purposeful rather than assembled.

MCQ 2. Lineage and the ownership boundary

Consider the following statements about the Mīmāṃsā textual tradition.

1. Śabara's commentary is the foundational surviving exposition of Jaimini's aphorisms.
2. Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā owns injunction, duty, authorless verbal authority and ritual interpretation.
3. Śālikanātha is a major later expositor of the Bhāṭṭa line founded by Kumārila.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, since the commentarial ladder runs from Śabara through Śālikanātha B. Statement 2 only, because textual attribution in this school is too disputed to be asserted C. Statements 1 and 2 only, as Śālikanātha belongs to the Prābhākara rather than the Bhāṭṭa line D. All three statements, because ownership and lineage are jointly settled by the same tradition

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 2 only, as Śālikanātha belongs to the Prābhākara rather than the Bhāṭṭa line

- **A:** Keeps the true first statement but carries the misattribution in the third, and the resulting "ladder" runs through two lines that the tradition keeps separate.
- **B:** Over-corrects: the doctrinal ownership boundary and the identity of the foundational commentary are both securely held, and only fine chronology is genuinely disputed.
- **C:** Correct - Śabara's *Śābara-bhāṣya* is foundational, the four owned items belong to the earlier inquiry, and Śālikanātha expounds Prābhākara, not Kumārila.
- **D:** Accepts the misattribution of Śālikanātha, and treats disputed relative chronology as though it were settled alongside doctrinal ownership.

Examiner trap 2: Because both sub-schools descend from the same two-stage base, candidates assume any later name may be attached to either line, and Śālikanātha is the name this habit most often misplaces.

MCQ 3. Reading the Bhāṭṭa-Prābhākara grid

Which row correctly pairs a Bhāṭṭa position with the corresponding Prābhākara position?

A. Six instruments and real absence, against five instruments and the bare unqualified locus B. Self-luminous cognition and knownness, against inferred cognition and threefold awareness C. Non-discrimination in error and word-priority, against contrary apprehension and sentence-priority D. Categorical obligation and five instruments, against fruit-motivation and independent absence

Answer: A. Six instruments and real absence, against five instruments and the bare unqualified locus

- **A:** Correct - Kumārila admits non-cognition as a sixth instrument and treats absence as real with a counterpositive, while Prābhākara declines both and perceives the locus as unqualified.
- **B:** Reverses the pairing twice over: self-luminosity and threefold awareness are Prābhākara, while knownness and inferred cognition are Bhāṭṭa.
- **C:** Reverses both halves: non-discrimination is Prābhākara and contrary apprehension Bhāṭṭa, and word-priority is Bhāṭṭa while sentence-priority is Prābhākara.
- **D:** Attaches categorical obligation and the five-instrument list to Bhāṭṭa, when obligation-based motivation and the shorter list both belong to Prābhākara.

Examiner trap 3: The six paired differences are learned as isolated facts rather than as one methodological instinct applied six times, so a candidate who misremembers one row usually misremembers the rest in the same direction.

MCQ 4. The fourfold formulation of validity

Which statement gives the Mīmāṃsā position on all four cells of the validity question?

A. Validity is intrinsic in origin and extrinsic in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both B. Validity and invalidity are both intrinsic in origin, and both are ascertained extrinsically C. Validity is intrinsic in origin and in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both respects D. Validity is extrinsic in origin and intrinsic in ascertainment; invalidity reverses that pattern

Answer: C. Validity is intrinsic in origin and in ascertainment; invalidity is extrinsic in both respects

- **A:** Splits validity across the two cells, which would reintroduce exactly the external certifier that the school's anti-regress argument was designed to eliminate.
- **B:** Makes invalidity intrinsic in origin, which is the Sāṃkhya placement rather than the Mīmāṃsā one and would require falsity to announce itself at birth.
- **C:** Correct - the same conditions that generate the cognition generate its validity, the cognition presents itself as trustworthy unaided, and falsity requires a defect and a defeater.
- **D:** Assigns extrinsic origin to validity, which is the Nyāya thesis, and then adds an intrinsic ascertainment that no school in the standard grid actually holds.

Examiner trap 4: Answers state only that "validity is intrinsic" and omit the invalidity row, so they cannot explain error and forfeit the comparison the 2025 question is built on.

MCQ 5. What intrinsic validity does not claim

Identify the sentence that a Mīmāṃsaka would refuse to endorse.

A. A cognition carries authority on arrival and loses it only when a defeating condition appears B. Every cognition is indefeasible, so a cognition once had can never afterwards be surrendered C. The burden of proof lies on the challenger of a cognition rather than on the cognition itself D. Falsity is caused by defect and becomes known through contradiction, failure or later correction

Answer: B. Every cognition is indefeasible, so a cognition once had can never afterwards be surrendered

- **A:** This is the school's thesis in its ordinary formulation, and the phrase "defeating condition" is the standard marker of its defeasibility.
- **B:** Correct as the sentence to reject - intrinsic validity is defeasible default warrant, and the school explicitly distinguishes default validity from guaranteed incorrigibility.
- **C:** The burden-shift is precisely what the anti-regress argument establishes, and the school appeals to lived practice to support it.
- **D:** This states the extrinsic invalidity half of the doctrine accurately, including both the causal defect and the routes by which falsity is detected.

Examiner trap 5: The word "intrinsic" is read as "infallible," and the resulting answer cannot survive the dream-and-mirage objection that every examiner in this area expects to see handled.

MCQ 6. Nyāya's route and the Mīmāṃsā counter

Which pairing correctly states a Nyāya method of validation together with the Mīmāṃsā objection to it?

A. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that action never in fact confirms anything B. Confirming perception, objected to on the ground that perception is inherently untrustworthy C. Divine testimony, objected to on the ground that scripture cannot certify ordinary cognitions D. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that acting already presupposes trusting it

Answer: D. Successful activity, objected to on the ground that acting already presupposes trusting it

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā never denies that action can confirm; it denies only that confirmation *generates* the validity the cognition already possessed.
- **B:** The school is a robust perceptual realist, so an objection resting on the untrustworthiness of perception could not be its own.
- **C:** Divine testimony is not one of the two classical Nyāya routes to validation, which are successful activity and confirming perception.
- **D:** Correct - one must act before one is entitled to trust, but the action itself relies on trust, so Nyāya uses what it officially postpones.

Examiner trap 6: Only one of Nyāya's two routes is remembered, and the answer then fails to show that the regress objection applies to confirming perception exactly as it applies to successful activity.

MCQ 7. Placing four schools on validity and invalidity

Match each school with its standard placement on the intrinsic/extrinsic question.

School	Placement
1. Mīmāṃsā	P. validity extrinsic, invalidity intrinsic
2. Sāṃkhya	Q. validity intrinsic, invalidity extrinsic
3. Buddhist epistemology	R. validity intrinsic, invalidity intrinsic

A. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P B. 1-R, 2-Q, 3-P C. 1-Q, 2-P, 3-R D. 1-P, 2-R, 3-Q

Answer: A. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P

- **A:** Correct - Mīmāṃsā holds intrinsic validity with extrinsic invalidity, Sāṃkhya is presented as intrinsic on both, and the Buddhist placement is the exact mirror-image.
- **B:** Gives Mīmāṃsā the Sāṃkhya cell, which would commit the school to falsity announcing itself at the moment of cognition.
- **C:** Assigns the Buddhist cell to Sāṃkhya and the Sāṃkhya cell to Buddhism, reversing the two schools whose placements are most often swapped.
- **D:** Gives Mīmāṃsā the Buddhist cell, which contradicts the school's central thesis and its whole strategy against scepticism.

Examiner trap 7: Sāṃkhya and Buddhism are remembered only as "the other two," and because their placements are adjacent in every table they are routinely exchanged under time pressure.

MCQ 8. Counting the instruments, and the rule behind the count

Consider the following statements about the Mīmāṃsā list of instruments of valid knowledge.

1. Bhāṭṭa accepts six and Prābhākara five, and the difference concerns non-cognition.
2. An instrument is admitted only where reduction to another fails without remainder or circularity.
3. Memory is excluded from both lists because it fails the requirement of novelty.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 3 only, because the admission rule is Nyāya's rather than Mīmāṃsā's B. Statement 1 only, since novelty is a Nyāya condition that Mīmāṃsā does not itself impose C. Statements 2 and 3 only, as both sub-schools in fact accept the same number of instruments D. All three statements, since the same admission rule both licenses and restricts the list

Answer: D. All three statements, since the same admission rule both licenses and restricts the list

- **A:** Denies the school's own irreducibility principle, which is exactly what Mīmāṃsā invokes to justify admitting postulation and non-cognition.
- **B:** Nyāya does accept the novelty requirement, but so does Mīmāṃsā, and Prabhākara's five-step argument against memory turns on it directly.
- **C:** Contradicts the single most-tested numerical fact in this topic, since the two sub-schools differ precisely by one instrument.
- **D:** Correct - the irreducibility rule admits postulation and non-cognition, and the same rule excludes memory, which reproduces rather than produces cognition.

Examiner trap 8: The counts are memorised without the rule, so the candidate can state that Bhāṭṭa has six but cannot explain why six is principled rather than arbitrary.

MCQ 9. Comparison, stated in Mīmāṃsā's own form

A learner writes: "In Mīmāṃsā, comparison is the instrument by which one learns, from a reliable person's statement that a wild ox resembles a cow, what the word 'wild ox' denotes." What is the correct assessment of this sentence?

A. It is accurate, because Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya give identical accounts of comparison in every respect B. It is inaccurate, because it states the Nyāya word-reference account instead of the Mīmāṃsā one C. It is inaccurate, because Mīmāṃsā does not accept comparison as an independent instrument at all D. It is accurate, because comparison in Mīmāṃsā is defined through prior testimony about similarity

Answer: B. It is inaccurate, because it states the Nyāya word-reference account instead of the Mīmāṃsā one

- **A:** The two accounts are expressly distinguished, and treating them as identical erases the very contrast the sources use to define the Mīmāṃsā instrument.
- **B:** Correct - in Mīmāṃsā the new cognition is that the previously seen, presently absent cow is similar to this perceived wild ox, and no word-learning is involved.
- **C:** Comparison is accepted by both sub-schools and appears in both the five-item and the six-item lists, so the denial is simply false.
- **D:** Reproduces the same Nyāya mechanism under a different description, since prior testimony about similarity is precisely what Mīmāṃsā's account does not require.

Examiner trap 9: The wild-ox example is shared by both schools while the mechanism is not, so a candidate who remembers only the example imports the wrong account without noticing.

MCQ 10. Perception and testimony, correctly divided

Which statement about perception and testimony in Mīmāṃsā is correct?

A. Determinate perception falsifies the given, so realism must be defended by inference instead B. Testimony is admitted only where perception and inference have already been tried and failed C. Impersonal testimony depends on a divine speaker whose omniscience secures the Vedic text D. Determinate perception interprets what the indeterminate stage held, and Vedic testimony is impersonal

Answer: D. Determinate perception interprets what the indeterminate stage held, and Vedic testimony is impersonal

- **A:** Reverses the school's realism: the determinate stage unpacks what was implicitly available and does not invent an unreal predicate.
- **B:** Testimony is not a fallback here; for supersensible duty it is the only competent instrument, and the school gives it a corresponding dignity.
- **C:** Assigns the Nyāya God-guarantee to Mīmāṃsā, whereas impersonal testimony is authoritative precisely because it has no speaker at all.
- **D:** Correct - the two-stage account supports realism against the bare-particular reading, and Vedic testimony is impersonal rather than divinely authored.

Examiner trap 10: Candidates treat "impersonal" as a synonym for "divine," and the resulting answer quietly converts Mīmāṃsā into the Nyāya position it was constructed to avoid.

MCQ 11. Why memory is refused instrument-status

On what precise ground do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas both deny that memory is a means of valid knowledge?

A. Memory is frequently mistaken, and an instrument may not be liable to systematic error B. Memory has no object, since a past object is no longer available to be presented at all C. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and so fails the requirement of fresh disclosure D. Memory belongs to the internal organ rather than to the senses, and only sense-instruments qualify

Answer: C. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and so fails the requirement of fresh disclosure

- **A:** The exclusion is definitional rather than evaluative, and the school concedes that memory may be perfectly true and reliably action-guiding.
- **B:** Memory does have an object; the difficulty is that the object was already disclosed, not that it is missing from the cognition.
- **C:** Correct - an instrument must generate a new cognition, whereas memory depends on an earlier cognition and its latent impression and merely re-presents.
- **D:** Introduces a faculty-location criterion that neither school uses, and would wrongly exclude inference and testimony along with memory.

Examiner trap 11: "Memory is unreliable" is offered as the reason, which both concedes too much to the sceptic and misses the novelty condition the question is testing.

MCQ 12. The structure of postulation

Which sequence correctly reproduces the canonical postulation case?

A. Devadatta is stout; stoutness invariably accompanies eating; therefore Devadatta eats at night B. Devadatta is stout and does not eat by day; the two cannot stand together; therefore he eats at night C. Devadatta does not eat by day; night-eating is remembered from an earlier occasion; therefore he eats at night D. Devadatta is stout; a reliable witness reports night-eating; therefore the report is accepted as true

Answer: B. Devadatta is stout and does not eat by day; the two cannot stand together; therefore he eats at night

- **A:** Supplies a universal concomitance and thereby converts the case into an inference, which is exactly the Nyāya reduction the school rejects as circular.
- **B:** Correct - two accepted facts generate explanatory tension and the minimally reconciling postulate resolves it, with no prior concomitance and no sign.
- **C:** Makes the conclusion a recollection, whereas the whole point of the case is that night-eating is neither perceived nor remembered here.
- **D:** Turns the case into testimony, which would make the third fact reported rather than postulated and would remove the tension that drives the cognition.

Examiner trap 12: The case is retold with an added premise such as "whoever is fat eats," which silently concedes the Nyāya reduction the answer was supposed to refute.

MCQ 13. Why postulation is not inference

Which of the following is *not* one of the three arguments Mīmāṃsā gives against reducing postulation to inference?

A. Postulation is unreliable, since a postulated fact is never confirmed by later observation B. No universal concomitance is independently established before the postulating cognition arises C. The movement runs from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified D. The case cannot be parsed into a subject, a reason present in it, and a probandum derived from it

Answer: A. Postulation is unreliable, since a postulated fact is never confirmed by later observation

- **A:** Correct as the odd one out - the school never argues from unreliability, and its claim is that the postulate is *necessary*, not that it is unverified.
- **B:** This is the first argument: inference requires a concomitance known beforehand, and no such rule about stout day-fasters is available.
- **C:** This is the second argument, which contrasts the direction of reasoning in the two instruments and is the easiest of the three to state.
- **D:** This is the third argument, which denies that the case exhibits the subject-reason-probandum form that standard inference requires.

Examiner trap 13: Only one anti-reduction argument is offered, usually the concomitance point, and the answer then has nothing left to say when the examiner's directive asks for a critical discussion.

MCQ 14. The fitness condition on non-cognition

Which case satisfies the conditions under which non-apprehension yields knowledge of absence?

A. Failing to see the keys on a cluttered desk in poor light after a hurried glance at it B. Failing to detect atoms in the space directly in front of one's own functioning eyes C. Failing to hear a sound while attention is wholly absorbed in an unrelated conversation D. Failing to see a pot on a bare, well-lit table placed at normal distance before the eyes

Answer: D. Failing to see a pot on a bare, well-lit table placed at normal distance before the eyes

- **A:** Poor light and a hurried glance are exactly the conditions the fitness requirement excludes, so this is careless overlooking rather than a cognition of absence.
- **B:** Atoms are not the kind of thing that would be perceived if present, so the first and most basic fitness condition fails at once.
- **C:** Absorbed attention breaks the condition that attention be proper, which is why inattentive non-hearing discloses nothing about the sound.
- **D:** Correct - the object is perceptible in kind, the locus is suitable, the organ functions and light, distance and attention are all proper.

Examiner trap 14: The fitness condition is omitted altogether, leaving the doctrine indistinguishable from an argument from ignorance and defenceless against the charge of subjectivism.

MCQ 15. The three-way dispute about absence

Which statement correctly reports the positions of Bhāṭṭa, Prābhākara and Nyāya on absence?

A. Bhāṭṭa admits a separate instrument, Prābhākara perceives the bare locus, Nyāya perceives absence B. Bhāṭṭa perceives absence directly, Prābhākara admits a separate instrument, Nyāya denies absence C. All three admit absence as real but only Nyāya admits a separate instrument for knowing it D. Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya converge on a separate instrument while Prābhākara reduces absence to inference

Answer: A. Bhāṭṭa admits a separate instrument, Prābhākara perceives the bare locus, Nyāya perceives absence

- **A:** Correct - Kumārila admits non-cognition, Prābhākara perceives the locus as unqualified, and Nyāya accepts absence as a real category directly perceived.
- **B:** Reverses Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara and then adds the false claim that Nyāya denies absence, when Nyāya denies only the separate instrument.
- **C:** Attributes the separate instrument to Nyāya, which is precisely the school that argues absence is available to perception without one.
- **D:** Invents a Bhāṭṭa-Nyāya convergence, whereas the actual convergence is between Nyāya and Prābhākara against Bhāṭṭa on independence.

Examiner trap 15: "Nyāya rejects non-cognition" is compressed into "Nyāya rejects absence," which misrepresents a school that treats absence as one of its own categories.

MCQ 16. The four theories of error

Match each theory of error with the account it gives of the shell-silver case.

Theory	Account
1. akhyāti / vivekākhyāti	P. real silver known elsewhere is presented here
2. viparīta-khyāti	Q. two valid cognitions whose difference is not apprehended
3. anyathā-khyāti	R. the shell is positively miscognised as silver

A. 1-P, 2-Q, 3-R B. 1-R, 2-P, 3-Q C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P D. 1-Q, 2-P, 3-R

Answer: C. 1-Q, 2-R, 3-P

- **A:** Gives Prābhākara the Nyāya displacement account and Nyāya the Bhāṭṭa misidentification account, inverting the two theories most often confused.
- **B:** Assigns misidentification to Prābhākara, who admits no false cognition at all, and non-discrimination to Nyāya, which never uses it.
- **C:** Correct - non-discrimination is Prābhākara, contrary apprehension is Bhāṭṭa's positive misidentification, and displacement of real silver is Nyāya.
- **D:** Correctly places Prābhākara but then exchanges Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya, which is the single most damaging slip available in this area.

Examiner trap 16: Bhāṭṭa's contrary apprehension and Nyāya's displacement are both described loosely as "a false cognition," and the distinction between misidentifying this object and misplacing another is lost.

MCQ 17. Why two schools that share a thesis still divide on error

Both Bhāṭṭa and Prābhākara accept the intrinsic validity of knowledge. Which statement best explains why they nevertheless divide over erroneous cognition?

A. They divide because Prābhākara abandons intrinsic validity whenever illusion is under discussion B. They divide because Bhāṭṭa treats falsity as intrinsic while Prābhākara treats it as extrinsic C. They divide because only Bhāṭṭa accepts that illusion produces any action at all in the subject D. They divide because each protects the shared thesis differently - constituents versus the principle

Answer: D. They divide because each protects the shared thesis differently - constituents versus the principle

- **A:** Prābhākara never suspends the thesis; his whole strategy is designed so that no constituent cognition ever has to be called false.
- **B:** Both hold falsity to be extrinsic in origin, and intrinsic falsity is the standard Buddhist placement rather than anything Kumārila accepts.
- **C:** Both must explain the reaching behaviour, and the disagreement is over what explains it, not over whether it occurs.
- **D:** Correct - Prābhākara keeps every constituent cognition valid, while Kumārila keeps the principle governing normal cognition and quarantines falsity in defect.

Examiner trap 17: The "in spite of" clause is treated as scene-setting rather than as the question, and the answer describes two error-theories without ever explaining their compatibility with one shared thesis.

MCQ 18. Three answers to "how do I know that I know?"

Which option correctly assigns each mechanism to its school?

A. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Bhāṭṭa, after-cognition to Nyāya B. Threefold awareness to Bhāṭṭa, knownness to Nyāya, after-cognition to Prābhākara C. Threefold awareness to Nyāya, knownness to Prābhākara, after-cognition to Bhāṭṭa D. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Nyāya, after-cognition to Bhāṭṭa

Answer: A. Threefold awareness to Prābhākara, knownness to Bhāṭṭa, after-cognition to Nyāya

- **A:** Correct - Prābhākara's single act discloses knower, known and knowing; Kumārila infers cognition from the object's knownness; Nyāya posits a distinct second-order act.
- **B:** Moves every mechanism one place, giving Prābhākara the second-order act he expressly rejects because it would restart the regress.
- **C:** Makes Nyāya a defender of self-luminosity, when Nyāya is the school that denies it and supplies a higher-order cognition instead.
- **D:** Retains the correct Prābhākara assignment but exchanges Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya, which are the two non-self-luminous positions and therefore easiest to confuse.

Examiner trap 18: The three views are listed without naming the regress they all answer, so the response reads as an inventory of opinions rather than as three engineered solutions to one problem.

MCQ 19. Self-luminosity and intrinsic validity

Which school provides the decisive counterexample to the claim that self-luminosity necessarily entails intrinsic validity?

A. Nyāya, because it accepts self-luminosity while denying that validity can be intrinsic B. Advaita Vedānta, because it restricts self-luminosity to the empirical level of reality C. Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā, because it accepts self-luminosity but denies intrinsic validity D. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, because it denies self-luminosity while affirming intrinsic validity

Answer: D. Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, because it denies self-luminosity while affirming intrinsic validity

- **A:** Nyāya denies self-luminosity as well as intrinsic validity, so it accepts neither thesis and cannot serve as a counterexample to an entailment between them.
- **B:** Advaita affirms both, grounding self-luminosity in consciousness as such, so it illustrates the pairing rather than breaking it.
- **C:** Prābhākara affirms both theses together, which is exactly the combination the entailment-claim predicts and therefore proves nothing against it.
- **D:** Correct - Kumārila holds intrinsic validity while inferring cognition from acquired knownness, showing that the two doctrines come apart in practice.

Examiner trap 19: Nyāya is placed in the "self-luminous but extrinsically valid" cell, which destroys the comparative grid the 2018 question is entirely built upon.

MCQ 20. Sentence-unity and the two semantics

Consider the following statements about Mīmāṃsā philosophy of language.

1. Expectancy, semantic fitness and proximity are accepted by both sub-schools.
2. Connection-of-the-already-denoted is the Prābhākara thesis about sentence meaning.
3. Purport, added by Naiyāyikas, is difficult for Mīmāṃsā because the Veda has no author.

Which of the statements is or are correct?

A. Statements 1 and 2 only, because the two sub-schools agree entirely on sentence meaning B. Statement 2 only, because the three conditions belong to Nyāya rather than to Mīmāṃsā C. Statements 1 and 3 only, since connection-of-the-already-denoted is in fact the Bhāṭṭa thesis D. All three statements, since both sub-schools share the conditions and both accept purport

Answer: C. Statements 1 and 3 only, since connection-of-the-already-denoted is in fact the Bhāṭṭa thesis

- **A:** Keeps the misattribution and adds the false claim of agreement, when the two sub-schools differ precisely over which unit is semantically primary.
- **B:** Denies the three shared conditions to Mīmāṃsā, although both sub-schools invoke them to explain how a word-sequence becomes one sentence.
- **C:** Correct - the three conditions are shared, purport is a genuine difficulty for an authorless text, and word-priority belongs to Bhāṭṭa.
- **D:** Mīmāṃsā cannot simply accept purport as speaker-intention, and it must relocate purport into textual function and subordination to injunction.

Examiner trap 20: The two long compound labels are learned by sound rather than by sense, and the connected-denotation thesis is handed to the sub-school that actually denies it.

MCQ 21. Universals, particulars and the exclusion challenge

Which statement correctly represents the Mīmāṃsā position on what words denote?

A. Words denote the universal primarily, and the individual is reached through it in context B. Words denote the individual primarily, with the universal serving only as its qualifier C. Words denote neither, since generality is produced by excluding what the word does not apply to D. Words denote an indivisible sentence-entity in which universal and individual are undivided

Answer: A. Words denote the universal primarily, and the individual is reached through it in context

- **A:** Correct - repeatability of "cow" across many animals is explained by the word's relation to cow-ness, with the individual reached as its instance.
- **B:** States the Nyāya position, which takes the qualified individual as primary and treats the universal as its qualifier.
- **C:** States the Buddhist exclusion theory, which Mīmāṃsā rejects because pure negation cannot ground stable positive recognition.
- **D:** States the Grammarian sound-burst theory, which both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject as an unnecessary additional entity.

Examiner trap 21: The stem's "or both" is ignored, and the answer caricatures Mīmāṃsā as knowing only universals and Nyāya as knowing only particulars, when the dispute concerns priority alone.

MCQ 22. How authorlessness secures the Veda

Which statement gives the Mīmāṃsā ground for Vedic authority?

A. The Veda is authoritative because an omniscient author cannot err, deceive or forget anything B. The Veda is authoritative because it has no author and so has no locus for defect at all C. The Veda is authoritative because successful ritual results confirm its statements over time D. The Veda is authoritative because its sentences are inferred to be true from the world's order

Answer: B. The Veda is authoritative because it has no author and so has no locus for defect at all

- **A:** States the Nyāya God-guarantee, which Mīmāṃsā rejects because it requires proving existence, then omniscience, then truthfulness in turn.
- **B:** Correct - unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial ignorance, deceit, partiality or forgetfulness, and an authorless text supplies no such locus.
- **C:** Makes validity depend on later confirmation, which is the extrinsic thesis the school refuses on anti-regress grounds.
- **D:** Turns scriptural authority into an inference from cosmic order, which is a design argument Mīmāṃsā uses against theism rather than for scripture.

Examiner trap 22: "Revealed scripture" is glossed as "revealed by God," and the answer installs precisely the personal author whose removal is the whole point of the doctrine.

MCQ 23. Injunction, impelling force and the unseen potency

Which statement correctly reports the Bhāṭṭa analysis of "one desiring heaven should sacrifice"?

A. Verbal impelling force produces the fruit, while objective impelling force produces the impulse B. A single undivided impelling force produces both the impulse and the fruit without any division C. Verbal impelling force produces the impulse, and objective impelling force produces the fruit D. Obligation binds the agent directly, so no impelling force needs to be posited in the sentence

Answer: C. Verbal impelling force produces the impulse, and objective impelling force produces the fruit

- **A:** Exchanges the two results, assigning the fruit to the word and the impulse to the act, which reverses the very distinction the doubling was introduced to draw.
- **B:** Denies the doubling that defines the Bhāṭṭa analysis, whose whole point is that linguistic impelling and real production are different functions.
- **C:** Correct - the sentence impels the qualified agent to undertake the act, and the act performed with proper means produces the result, mediated by unseen potency.
- **D:** States Prabhākara's alternative, in which the directly apprehended to-be-done binds the agent without any two-fold analysis of force.

Examiner trap 23: The two forces are memorised as a pair of Sanskrit terms without their two results, so the candidate can name them but cannot say which one reaches heaven.

MCQ 24. Atheism inside an orthodox school

Which statement best expresses why Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator God is consistent with its defence of the Veda?

A. Because the school treats the Veda as a human composition whose value lies in its antiquity B. Because scriptural authority is grounded in impersonality, which divine authorship would destroy C. Because the ritual deities are denied altogether, leaving the sacrifice as the only reality D. Because the school accepts a creator for cosmology while denying him any role in scripture

Answer: B. Because scriptural authority is grounded in impersonality, which divine authorship would destroy

- **A:** Mīmāṃsā denies human composition as firmly as divine composition, and antiquity is not among the grounds it offers for authority.
- **B:** Correct - a God-authored Veda would depend on proving that author's competence and sincerity, which is a weaker foundation than authorlessness.
- **C:** Ritual deities are retained as mantra-denoted entities subordinate to the sacrifice; what is denied is their role as creators or dispensers of fruit.
- **D:** The school denies a creator in cosmology too, arguing from a beginningless world, the motive problem and the sufficiency of action and unseen potency.

Examiner trap 24: Atheism is reported as an embarrassing inconsistency in an orthodox school, when the sources present it as a consequence of the very doctrine that makes the school orthodox.

REMEDIAL DRILLS

MCQ 25. Repairing the instrument-count

A learner writes: "Both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools accept six means of valid knowledge, including non-cognition." Which correction is required?

A. None, because the six-item list including non-cognition is common to both sub-schools B. The list must be reduced to four for both, since comparison is not accepted in Mīmāṃsā C. Postulation should be removed from the Prābhākara list while non-cognition is retained D. Prābhākara accepts five and rejects non-cognition as an independent instrument of knowledge

Answer: D. Prābhākara accepts five and rejects non-cognition as an independent instrument of knowledge

- **A:** Endorses the error under repair, and the six-item list belongs to Kumārila's line alone rather than to the school as a whole.
- **B:** Comparison is accepted by both sub-schools and appears in the five-item and six-item lists alike, so the reduction to four is unfounded.
- **C:** Inverts the actual position, since postulation is precisely the instrument Prābhākara does accept and non-cognition the one he refuses.
- **D:** Correct - the single point of difference between the two lists is non-cognition, which Prābhākara explains away by perception of the bare locus.

Examiner trap 25: This is the most frequently repeated factual error in the topic, and it is fatal in any question that names Prābhākara, because it misstates his position in the first line.

MCQ 26. Repairing the two false-cognition theories

A learner writes: "Bhāṭṭa's contrary apprehension is the same as Nyāya's otherwise-apprehension, since both admit a false cognition." Which correction is required?

A. Neither school admits a false cognition, so both descriptions should be replaced by non-discrimination B. Nyāya does not admit a false cognition, and its account should be described as indescribability instead C. Both admit a false cognition, but Bhāṭṭa misidentifies this object while Nyāya displaces a real one D. Bhāṭṭa does not admit a false cognition, since he explains illusion by conflating perception and memory

Answer: C. Both admit a false cognition, but Bhāṭṭa misidentifies this object while Nyāya displaces a real one

- **A:** Non-discrimination is Prābhākara's theory, and applying it to two schools that expressly admit a false cognition erases three positions at once.
- **B:** Indescribability is the Advaita account, and Nyāya's theory turns on a real object presented in the wrong place rather than on indeterminate status.
- **C:** Correct - for Kumārila the shell before the subject is positively miscognised, whereas for Nyāya real silver known elsewhere is presented here.
- **D:** Attributes Prabhākara's non-discrimination to Kumārila, reversing the two Mīmāṃsā theories that the 2022 question requires to be kept apart.

Examiner trap 26: The shared phrase "false cognition" masks a difference of object, and an answer that merges the two theories cannot deliver the four-column comparison examiners look for.

MCQ 27. Repairing the account of Vedic authority

A learner writes: "The Veda is authoritative for Mīmāṃsā because God revealed it to the sages." Which correction is required?

A. The Veda is authorless, and its authority rests on the absence of any locus for authorial defect B. The Veda is authoritative because the sages who received it were verified as reliable witnesses C. The Veda is authoritative because its ritual prescriptions are confirmed by observed results D. The Veda is authoritative because inference from the world's order establishes a truthful author

Answer: A. The Veda is authorless, and its authority rests on the absence of any locus for authorial defect

- **A:** Correct - the school argues from no remembered author, the natural word-meaning relation and the eternality of word-units to a text free of authorial defect.
- **B:** Reintroduces personal authority through the sages, whereas Mīmāṃsā treats reciters and teachers as transmitters rather than as authors or guarantors.
- **C:** Grounds scripture in observed confirmation, which cannot reach a supersensible object and would surrender the school's intrinsic-validity thesis.
- **D:** Restates the design argument that Mīmāṃsā rejects, since the world as a whole is not observed to be manufactured and a bodiless agent cannot be shown to act.

Examiner trap 27: The English phrase "revealed scripture" is imported without examination, and one careless sentence converts the most anti-theistic orthodox school into a theistic one.

MCQ 28. Repairing the two semantic labels

A learner writes: "Prabhākara holds connection-of-the-already-denoted and Kumārila holds denotation-of-the-connected." Which correction is required?

A. Both labels belong to Kumārila, since Prabhākara has no distinctive theory of sentence meaning B. Both labels belong to Prabhākara, since Kumārila treats sentence meaning as indivisible C. Neither label is Mīmāṃsā's, since both were introduced by the Grammarian sound-burst tradition D. The labels are exchanged: word-priority is Kumārila's and connected denotation is Prabhākara's

Answer: D. The labels are exchanged: word-priority is Kumārila's and connected denotation is Prabhākara's

- **A:** Prabhākara's connected-denotation thesis, supported by the learning argument, is one of his most distinctive contributions and cannot be removed.
- **B:** Kumārila does not treat sentence meaning as indivisible; that is the Grammarian view which both sub-schools reject.
- **C:** Both labels are internal Mīmāṃsā terms, and the sound-burst theory is a rival that Mīmāṃsā argues against rather than a source of these theses.
- **D:** Correct - Kumārila's words denote first and are then connected, while Prabhākara's words denote only as already connected in the sentence.

Examiner trap 28: The two compound terms differ by a syllable and are memorised phonetically, so under time pressure the candidate reproduces the pair in whichever order comes first.

MCQ 29. Repairing the self-awareness mechanisms

A learner writes: "Bhātṭa explains knowledge of cognition by threefold awareness and Prabhākara by the object's knownness." Which correction is required?

A. Both explanations belong to Nyāya, which alone addresses how a cognition is itself known B. The mechanisms are exchanged: threefold awareness is Prabhākara's and knownness is Kumārila's C. Neither mechanism is needed, since both sub-schools accept the second-order after-cognition D. Both mechanisms belong to Kumārila, who uses threefold awareness for perception and knownness for memory

Answer: B. The mechanisms are exchanged: threefold awareness is Prabhākara's and knownness is Kumārila's

- **A:** Nyāya's own mechanism is the distinct second-order after-cognition, and it defends neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness.
- **B:** Correct - Prabhākara's single act discloses knower, known and knowing, while Kumārila denies self-luminosity and infers cognition from acquired knownness.
- **C:** The after-cognition is the Nyāya solution that both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject, each for its own reasons.
- **D:** Splits one thinker across two incompatible mechanisms and would leave Prabhākara with no account of self-awareness at all.

Examiner trap 29: Because Prabhākara is the economical thinker elsewhere, candidates expect him to hold the inferential account, when economy is exactly what makes him affirm self-luminosity.

MCQ 30. Repairing the claim about inference

A learner writes: "Mīmāṃsā rejects inference, which is why it needs postulation and non-cognition." Which correction is required?

A. Mīmāṃsā rejects inference only in ritual contexts, accepting it freely in ordinary matters B. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference but denies that it can be applied to any supersensible object C. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference fully and rejects only the claim that all mediate knowing is inferential D. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference as its primary instrument and treats perception as derivative from it

Answer: C. Mīmāṃsā accepts inference fully and rejects only the claim that all mediate knowing is inferential

- **A:** No such contextual restriction exists; the school uses standard sign-based inference wherever a concomitance is available, ritual or otherwise.
- **B:** Inference is indeed unable to reach duty, but that is a limitation of its object and not a rejection of the instrument as such.
- **C:** Correct - the school uses smoke and fire in the ordinary way and opposes only reductionism, which is what licenses postulation and non-cognition.
- **D:** Perception is the most basic disclosure of sensible objects, and no Mīmāṃsā text makes inference prior to it.

Examiner trap 30: The existence of two extra instruments is read as hostility to inference, and the answer then contradicts the school's own use of the smoke-and-fire example.

MCQ 31. Repairing the injunction taxonomies

A learner writes: "The three kinds of injunction are the act, its subsidiary application and the qualified agent." Which correction is required?

A. Those belong to a separate coordination grid; the three kinds are novel, restrictive and exclusionary B. Those are correct, but a fourth kind covering performance-order must be added to complete the list C. Those belong to the five-function sentence taxonomy, which also includes mantra and praise passages D. Those belong to the three factors of impelling force, namely result, means and procedure

Answer: A. Those belong to a separate coordination grid; the three kinds are novel, restrictive and exclusionary

- **A:** Correct - the act, subsidiary application, performance-order and qualified agent form a four-part scheme for coordinating a complex rite, not the logical classification of injunctions.
- **B:** Adding performance-order completes the coordination grid but leaves the logical classification of injunctions still unstated.
- **C:** The five-function taxonomy classifies injunction, prohibition, mantra, name and praise passage, and contains none of the four listed items.
- **D:** The three factors answer what is to be brought about, by what means and by what procedure, which is a different scheme again.

Examiner trap 31: Three separate schemes are collapsed into one long list of Sanskrit terms, and the answer then cannot show that Mīmāṃsā's hermeneutics is systematically organised.

MCQ 32. Repairing the account of liberation and the self

A learner writes: "Mīmāṃsā holds one universal self, and liberation is realisation of identity with Brahman." Which correction is required?

A. Mīmāṃsā denies any enduring self, and liberation is the cessation of the momentary series
B. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is release from karmic embodiment and pain
C. Mīmāṃsā holds one universal self, but liberation is granted by God to the qualified agent
D. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is the permanent attainment of heaven by ritual

Answer: B. Mīmāṃsā holds many eternal selves, and liberation is release from karmic embodiment and pain

- **A:** A momentary series is the Buddhist position, and it would destroy the agent-enjoyer identity that ritual responsibility requires.
- **B:** Correct - the school accepts a plurality of eternal selves as knower, agent and enjoyer, and later accounts describe release as the end of fresh merit, demerit and embodiment.
- **C:** Retains the Advaitic single self and adds a divine grant of liberation, importing exactly the creator the school argues against.
- **D:** Confuses the ritual fruit with liberation, whereas heaven is a karmically produced result and release is the cessation of such production.

Examiner trap 32: The liberation doctrine is late and comparatively thin, so candidates fill the gap with whichever neighbouring school they know best, usually Advaita.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Ownership. Mīmāṃsā owns fourteen primary parts in the 2018-2025 Paper I corpus and appears as a primary owner in every year of that window: one part each in 2018, 2019, 2020 and 2021, two each in 2022, 2023 and 2025, and four in 2024. All fourteen are reproduced and solved below.

Status of the model answers. UPSC Mains publishes no official answer key or model answer. Every solution below is independent learner practice written to the stated word band and directive, and it is never presented as an official key.

Declared answer bands. 10 marks: 150-200 words. 15 marks: 250-300 words. 20 marks: 340-400 words. Every solved answer states its exact word count.

VERIFIED PREVIOUS-YEAR QUESTIONS - 14 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. Does the admission of Svayaṃprakāśavāda necessarily lead to the admission of Svataḥprāmāṇyavāda? Discuss after the Naiyāyikas, the Mīmāṃsakas and the Advaita Vedāntins.

Directive read. "Necessarily" makes this a question about entailment, not about popularity. A survey without a verdict fails; a verdict without the survey is unsupported.

Model answer (398 words).

Self-luminosity (**svayaṃprakāśatva**) asks whether a cognition is manifest without another cognition. Intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**) asks whether a cognition is entitled to *prima facie* truth without external certification. Manifestation and truth-entitlement are distinct questions, so no entailment can be read off the definitions; it would have to be argued, and no school argues it.

The Naiyāyikas accept neither thesis. A cognition is known through a distinct later cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) of the form "I know the pot," and validity is ascertained extrinsically through successful activity (**pravṛtti-sāmarthya**) or confirming perception (**saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**). Nyāya is therefore not the awkward case of self-luminosity without intrinsic validity; it simply denies both.

The Mīmāṃsakas divide, and this division decides the question. Prabhākara holds that one cognition discloses knower, known and knowing together (**tripuṭī-saṃvit**), comparing cognition to a lamp that shows itself while showing the room; he also holds intrinsic validity. Kumārila denies self-luminosity: cognition is like a painter who does not paint himself, and its occurrence is inferred from the object's acquired knownness (**jñātātā**). Yet Kumārila is among the strongest defenders of intrinsic validity, arguing that if every cognition needed another to certify it an infinite regress (**anavasthā**) would follow.

Kumārila is therefore the decisive counterexample. A single actual case of intrinsic validity without self-luminosity refutes a claim of necessity. Nor is his combination unstable: cognition is inferred from what it leaves behind in the object, while its truth-entitlement is settled by the anti-regress argument, so the two issues are handled by different machinery.

The Advaita Vedāntins affirm both, but on different ground. Self-luminosity belongs to consciousness as such and not merely to cognitive episodes, while empirical cognition carries *prima facie* authority until sublated within a doctrine of levels of reality. Their pairing is therefore a substantive metaphysical commitment rather than a definitional consequence - which is exactly what the question's word "necessarily" is testing.

The answer is accordingly negative. The two doctrines travel together in Prābhākara and in Advaita, come apart in Bhāṭṭa, and are jointly rejected by Nyāya.

Two qualifications complete the discussion. First, independence is not irrelevance: a self-luminous cognition makes intrinsic validity easier to defend. Second, the standing objection that intrinsic validity cannot explain error is answered on both Mīmāṃsā routes - Prabhākara by admitting no false cognition, Kumārila by tracing falsity to extrinsic defect and later sublation.

The verdict, then, is that manifestation and truth-entitlement are two properties, not one under two names.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019, Question 5(e), 10 marks

Printed question. How does Mīmāṃsā establish the authority of Vedic knowledge?

Directive read. "How ... establish" asks for the argumentative route, not for the claim. State the mechanism, then one line of critical residue.

Model answer (199 words).

Mīmāṃsā establishes Vedic authority by removing its author. Duty (**dharmā**) is supersensible, and the formula **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah** makes Vedic injunction its distinguishing mark, so verbal testimony is not a fallback but the only competent instrument.

The argument proceeds by subtraction. Unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial defects: an author may err, deceive, be partial or forget. No author of the Veda is remembered, though an author of so momentous a text would have been; the word-meaning relation is natural (**autpattika**) rather than instituted convention; and word-units possess eternality (**śabda-nityatva**), so utterance manifests rather than produces them. A text with no author has no locus for such defect.

This is reinforced by intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**): cognition is authoritative on arrival and loses authority only through a defect (**doṣa**) or a defeater (**bādhaka**). Since duty is a domain no rival instrument reaches, no defeater arises there - which also blocks the charge that rival scriptures become equally self-valid, for those have authors and defect-loci.

Against Nyāya's omniscient author, Mīmāṃsā objects that one must prove God's existence, omniscience and truthfulness in turn.

Critically, the defence rests on two contested props: the absence of a remembered author, and the naturalness of word-meaning.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2020, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Why is memory not a valid knowledge according to Mīmāṃsā?

Directive read. A "why" question with a single-point answer. The mark lies in giving the correct reason and naming the condition, not in listing memory's defects.

Model answer (200 words).

Memory (**smṛti**) is excluded not because it is unreliable but because it is unoriginal. A means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) is the operative source of a *fresh* true cognition, and memory supplies none.

Prabhākara's argument runs in five steps. An instrument must generate a new cognition of an object; memory depends on an earlier cognition together with its latent impression (**saṃskāra**); it reproduces old content; it does not reveal a new object as presently known; therefore it is not an instrument. The condition it fails is novelty (**anadhigatatva**) - not-already-ascertained.

The distinction must be stated explicitly, because it is what the question tests. Memory may be true. It may be useful. It may guide action successfully. None of this confers instrument-status, because the title tracks novel valid disclosure alone. Seeing a temple now is perception; recalling yesterday's visit is memory, and the latter is not new knowledge of the temple.

Nyāya reaches the same verdict by the same route, treating memory as re-presentation rather than fresh disclosure.

The exclusion is nevertheless a verdict about status, not about irrelevance. Memory remains indispensable within comparison (**upamāna**), within Prabhākara's analysis of error, and within ordinary sentence-comprehension. Only retrieval's claim to the title is denied.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. What, according to Mīmāṃsakas, is the ontological status of abhāva (absence) and how does one know it? Explain and examine.

Directive read. Two demands - status and route - plus "examine," which requires the internal disagreement and a graded close.

Model answer (270 words).

For Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, absence (**abhāva**) is real. It is not a shadow cast by language but a structured content with a counterpositive (**pratiyogin**), the entity whose absence it is; "absence of pot" is therefore an ontological item, and negative cognition has a genuine object.

The route to it is a distinct instrument. Kumārila argues that we do know absences - "there is no pot on the table" - that the cognition is definite and action-guiding, that it is not perception, which yields positive content, not inference, which requires a positive sign, and not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case. An independent source is therefore required, and that source is non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**): non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present.

The instrument is tightly limited by fitness (**yogyatā**). The absent object must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper. Hence "no pot on this lit table" is knowledge, while "no atoms here" is not. This limitation answers the charge of subjectivism and simultaneously defeats the inferential reduction, since treating non-seeing as a sign already presupposes the evidentiary force fitness supplies.

Examining the position, the Mīmāṃsakas do not speak with one voice. Prabhākara holds that what is known is simply the locus as unqualified by the absent object, so no separate instrument is needed. Nyāya accepts absence as real but takes it to be directly perceived - "pot-absence-on-the-floor" - so Nyāya and Prabhākara converge against Bhāṭṭa on independence for different reasons.

The graded verdict is that Kumārila preserves the phenomenology of negative cognition most faithfully while carrying the heaviest ontology, a cost he expressly accepts.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2022, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. How do Mīmāṃsakas refute the Nyāya view that Implication (arthāpatti) is reducible to Inference (anumāna) and establish Implication as an independent means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)? Critically discuss.

Directive read. Two tasks - refute, then establish - and "critically" demands that the residual Nyāya pressure be recorded.

Model answer (273 words).

Postulation (**arthāpatti**) is the necessary postulation of an unperceived fact to remove an incompatibility (**anupapatti**) between facts already known. Devadatta is stout; he does not eat by day; stoutness cannot stand with total absence of nourishment; therefore night-eating is posited as the minimally reconciling supplement. It is neither perceived here nor remembered.

Nyāya attempts a reduction: fatness is the reason (**hetu**), eating the probandum (**sādhya**), and the concomitance is "whoever is fat eats." Mīmāṃsā refutes this on three independent grounds.

First, no concomitance is independently established. Inference requires **vyāpti** known beforehand, and no prior universal rule about stout day-fasters exists; the cognition arises because the facts would otherwise conflict. Second, the direction of reasoning differs: inference moves from observed sign to unobserved signified, whereas postulation moves from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate - not "this sign indicates that fact" but "without that postulate, these facts are inexplicable." Third, there is no subject-reason-probandum structure at all; there is a clash of accepted facts and a demanded supplementation.

The reduction is then shown to be circular. The concomitance Nyāya needs is not independently known; if it is claimed as known, it was abstracted from lived cases by exactly the tension-driven move under dispute. The reduction consumes its own conclusion.

Positively, an instrument is admitted wherever reduction fails without remainder, and this cognition is neither sign-based nor positively perceptual - hence its independent standing, accepted by both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools.

Critically, Nyāya can still press that "explanatory necessity" conceals a suppressed general premise. Mīmāṃsā's strongest reply is that its claim is stronger than inference to the best explanation: the postulate is not merely best, but required.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022, Question 7(a), 20 marks

Printed question. In spite of accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why and how Prabhākara and Kumārila differ in their interpretation of erroneous cognition? Discuss.

Directive read. The "in spite of" clause is the question. The answer must show that the two error-theories are two defences of one shared thesis.

Model answer (393 words).

Both Prabhākara and Kumārila hold that validity is intrinsic and invalidity extrinsic: a cognition is authoritative on arrival, and falsity requires a defect (**doṣa**) and is detected by a defeater (**bādhaka**). Precisely because the thesis is shared, illusion becomes the system's stress-test - and each thinker protects the thesis by protecting a different thing.

Prabhākara defends non-apprehension of difference (**akhyāti**, more precisely **vivekākhyāti**). In the shell-silver case the subject validly perceives *this shining thing*; the subject also validly recalls previously experienced silver; the failure lies in not apprehending the difference between the two. Because of this non-discrimination, the subject reaches for silver. No separate false cognition need be posited. The strategy therefore keeps *every constituent cognition valid*: the presentational cognition is valid, the memory is valid, and error lies only in their conflation.

Kumārila defends contrary apprehension (**viparīta-khyāti**). The shell is before the subject; bad light, distance, similarity of lustre or sensory defect cause it to be miscognised; a single erroneous cognition arises - "this is silver" - and it is false. Its falsity, however, is due to extrinsic defect and not to cognition's normal nature, and it is discovered extrinsically when the subject approaches and sees clearly. The strategy therefore keeps *the principle governing normal cognition*, quarantining falsity in abnormal conditions.

The costs are exactly complementary. Prabhākara must explain the assertive force of "this is silver" by a mere failure of discrimination, and critics reply that non-discrimination underrates the positive character of the judgement. Kumārila must admit a false cognition into a system built on default truth, and critics reply that this grants too much to falsity. Each replies by pointing to the price the other pays: Prabhākara's is a psychological implausibility, Kumārila's an apparent concession, and neither is a surrender of the shared thesis.

Both must also be kept distinct from Nyāya's otherwise-apprehension (**anyathā-khyāti**), in which real silver known elsewhere is presented here, and from Advaita's indescribable appearance (**anirvacanīya-khyāti**), which is neither real nor unreal. The Bhāṭṭa and Nyāya accounts are the pair most often conflated, because both admit a false cognition; the difference is that Kumārila *misidentifies the object present*, whereas Nyāya *misplaces an object known elsewhere*.

The difference between the two Mīmāṃsakas is therefore not a lapse from the shared thesis but two rival strategies for honouring it - one protecting every constituent cognition, the other protecting the principle that governs normal cognition.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023, Question 6(b), 15 marks

Printed question. Present Bhaṭṭa's view of anupalabdhi (non-cognition) as a valid means of knowledge.

Directive read. "Present" asks for a full, structured exposition: definition, argument, condition, refusals of reduction, rivals, and a closing evaluation.

Model answer (276 words).

Non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) is, for Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, the independent means of knowing absence through non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present. It is the sixth instrument by which Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsā exceeds Nyāya's four, and it is rejected by Prabhākara, whose list stops at five.

Kumārila's argument is cumulative. We do know absences, such as "there is no pot on the table"; the cognition is definite and action-guiding; it is not ordinary perception, since perception delivers positive content; it is not inference, since inference requires a positive sign; and it is not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case. An independent source is therefore necessary.

The instrument is disciplined by fitness (**yogyatā**), which is why it is properly called **yogyānupalabdhi**. The absent object must be the kind of thing that would be perceived if present; the locus must be suitable; the organ must function; light, distance and attention must be proper. "No pot on this bare, well-lit table" satisfies these; "no atoms here" does not, because atoms are not perceptible in kind.

Bhāṭṭa refuses both reductions. Perception gives the table, its colour, shape and spread; "absence of pot" is not a positive sensible datum of that kind, so perceiving an empty table is one thing and cognising the pot's absence another. Inference needs a positive sign and known concomitance; offering "not-seeing" as the sign requires explaining why not-seeing has evidentiary force, which already presupposes fitness - so the reduction is strained or circular.

Its object, absence (**abhāva**), is accordingly real, structured by its counterpositive (**pratiyogin**). Kumārila accepts the ontological cost in order to preserve a cognition that everyday life - no chalk, no key, no bus - constantly presupposes.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2023, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Do words refer to universals or particulars or both? Present an exposition of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā position with regard to above question along with suitable examples.

Directive read. The "or both" is a warning against caricature, and examples are demanded explicitly, so at least two must appear.

Model answer (273 words).

Both schools hold that language reaches universals *and* individuals. The dispute is about semantic priority, not coverage, and an answer that caricatures either side misses the question.

Mīmāṃsā holds that a word primarily denotes the universal (**jāti**). The argument is from repeatability: the same word "cow" applies to indefinitely many individual animals, and the most economical explanation of this is the word's relation to cow-ness. The individual is then reached through the universal as instantiated in a concrete context. Thus "cow" can pick out the animal before me because cow-ness is recognisable in it. This coheres with the school's two-stage perception, in which determinate perception - "this is a white moving cow" - interprets what the indeterminate stage implicitly held rather than imposing an unreal predicate.

Nyāya reverses the priority. The primary denotatum is the individual (**vyakti**) as qualified by universal and form, so that the word reaches the qualified particular first and the universal figures as its qualifier.

An objection presses Mīmāṃsā: a universal cannot be milked, brought or sacrificed. The reply distinguishes meaning from application - the universal is primary for meaning, while action reaches the qualified individual through contextual application. This matters ritually, since "bring the cow" must deliver an actual animal.

The sharpest challenge is Buddhist exclusion (**apoha**): no real universal is needed, since "cow" functions by excluding non-cows. Mīmāṃsā replies that pure exclusion cannot explain stable positive recognition and repeatable application unless a shared class-character is already available.

For depth, the Grammarian sound-burst theory (**sphoṭa-vāda**) treats sentence-meaning as an indivisible flash; both Mīmāṃsā sub-schools reject it, holding that eternal phonemes with ordered manifestation, together with expectancy, fitness and proximity, already suffice.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024, Question 5(d), 10 marks

Printed question. How does Bhaṭṭa's view of nature of word-meaning and sentential-meaning differ from Prabhākara's view? Critically discuss.

Directive read. A ten-mark comparison with a critical tail: shared conditions, the two theses, one objection each, and a verdict.

Model answer (198 words).

Both sub-schools face the problem of sentence-unity (**ekavākyatā**) and accept the same three conditions for it: mutual expectancy (**ākāṅkṣā**), semantic fitness (**yogyatā**) and proximity (**sannidhi**). They differ over which unit is semantically primary.

Kumārila holds connection-of-the-already-denoted (**abhihitānvayavāda**). Each word first denotes its own meaning (**padārtha**) through its denotative power (**abhidhā**); sentence-meaning then arises through a further connecting operation, explained as indirect signification (**lakṣaṇā**) or purport-power (**tātparya-śakti**). The word is primary and sentence-meaning derivative, and the two stages are logical rather than temporal.

Prabhākara holds denotation-of-the-connected (**anvitābhidhānavāda**). Words denote their meanings only as already connected with the other meanings in the sentence. His evidence is the learning situation (**vyutpatti**): a child hears an elder command "bring the cow," sees a younger person comply, and learns the words in their connected, action-guiding sense.

Critically, each is charged with what the other explains. Kumārila is charged with positing an unobserved isolated-word stage and an extra operation in every sentence; he replies that the distinction is explanatory, not introspective. Prabhākara is charged with making a word mean differently in every sentence; he replies that recurrent connected uses yield stable competence.

The verdict is complementary: Bhaṭṭa secures stable lexical meaning, Prabhākara contextual action-guidance.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2024, Question 8(a), 20 marks

Printed question. How do I know that I know? Answer this question with reference to the Naiyāyikas, the Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Prabhākaras.

Directive read. Three named columns. The mark-difference lies in naming the shared problem - regress - and showing that all three are engineered answers to it.

Model answer (384 words).

The question is not psychological but structural. If a cognition is not manifest in itself, another cognition must reveal it; that one needs a third; and an infinite regress (**anavasthā**) follows. Every classical answer is a device for stopping this regress, and the three schools stop it at different places.

The Prabhākaras stop it immediately. Cognition is self-luminous (**svaprakāśa**), and a single act discloses knower, known and knowing together - threefold awareness (**tripuṭi-saṃvit**). The lamp analogy carries the point: a lamp reveals itself while revealing the room, and needs no second lamp. Reflective statements such as "I know that I know" are later conceptual articulations of what was already manifest pre-reflectively. Objection: does simultaneous revelation confuse the three? Reply: they are disclosed together, not ontologically collapsed. There is no metacognitive gap.

The Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas deny self-luminosity. An object, once cognised, acquires a new relational status - knownness (**jñātatā**); observing that status, we infer that a cognition has occurred. Cognition is like a painter who paints objects but not himself, and its occurrence is established by what it leaves behind in the object. Objection: knownness looks like a mysterious posit. Reply: Kumārila accepts that cost rather than the stronger thesis of self-luminosity. The consequence is a temporal and logical gap: I know first, and I know that I know afterwards, inferentially.

The Naiyāyikas stop the regress by permitting exactly one further act. A distinct second-order cognition (**anuvyavasāya**) takes the first as its object, in the form "I know the pot." This is neither self-luminosity nor inference from knownness. Objection: does the second-order act not restart the regress? Reply: Nyāya treats it as sufficient without endless repetition.

The three positions are thus best ranked by the gap they tolerate - none, inferential, reflective - and each gap carries a matching cost: the risk of conflating the three items disclosed together, the positing of an obscure relational property, and the reappearance of the regress the higher-order act was meant to halt. Each school has an answer to its own cost, so the dispute is unresolved rather than won.

What can be asserted confidently is narrower and more useful. Kumārila's combination of non-self-luminous cognition with intrinsic validity is philosophically stable, and it shows that knowing-that-one-knows and being-entitled-to-believe are separate questions: manifestation is settled by knownness and inference, truth-entitlement by the anti-regress argument.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2024, Question 8(b), 15 marks

Printed question. "A candidate who is never seen to be studying during the day time secures a high position in a competitive exam." How would the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas and the Naiyāyikas explain the success of this candidate? Discuss.

Directive read. An applied case requiring *both* explanations to be written out, then compared. Stating only the Mīmāṃsā account answers half the question.

Model answer (285 words).

The Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas explain the case by postulation (**arthāpatti**). Two facts are accepted: the candidate tops the examination, and the candidate is never seen studying by day. Examination success is incompatible with no preparation at all, so the two facts generate explanatory tension. To let both stand, some unobserved preparation must be posited, and the minimally reconciling postulate is study at night or otherwise outside observed daytime. The night-study is neither perceived here nor remembered; it is postulated because otherwise the accepted data remain inexplicable. This is postulation from perceived facts (**dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti**), structurally identical to the canonical case of stout Devadatta who does not eat by day.

The Naiyāyikas frame the same case as an inference. Wherever there is examination success there is preparation; this candidate has examination success; therefore this candidate had preparation. The reason (**hetu**) is success, the probandum (**sādhya**) is preparation, and the transition runs through a concomitance (**vyāpti**).

The Bhāṭṭa reply is that the reduction misses what actually generates the cognition. The reasoning does not begin from a sign but from a clash of accepted facts; the movement is from explanatory tension to a reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified; and the case shows no subject-reason-probandum structure. Above all, the concomitance is slipped in too quickly: "wherever there is success there is preparation" is not independently established, and if it is claimed as known, it was abstracted from lived cases by exactly the postulating move under dispute. The reduction is therefore circular.

Discussion should end even-handedly. Nyāya's account is simpler and keeps the instrument-list short; the Bhāṭṭa account is more faithful to how the cognition actually arises, which is why Mīmāṃsā treats explanatory necessity as epistemically basic.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024, Question 8(c), 15 marks

Printed question. On what grounds do the Prābhākaras and the Naiyāyikas reject memory as a source of knowledge? Discuss.

Directive read. "On what grounds" and two named schools: give the shared ground, show the convergence explicitly, and mark what the exclusion does not claim.

Model answer (277 words).

Both schools reject memory (**smṛti**) on a single shared ground: an instrument of valid knowledge must produce a *fresh* cognition, and memory produces none. The technical name of the failed condition is novelty (**anadhigatatva**) - not-already-ascertained.

Prabhākara's argument runs in five steps. A means of valid knowledge (**pramāṇa**) must generate a new cognition of an object. Memory depends on an earlier cognition together with its latent impression (**saṃskāra**). It reproduces old content. It does not reveal a new object as presently known. Therefore it is not an instrument.

The Naiyāyikas reach the identical verdict by the identical route: memory presents what was already known, and is re-presentation rather than fresh disclosure. This convergence is philosophically notable, since the two schools are opposed on almost everything else in epistemology - intrinsic versus extrinsic validity, non-discrimination versus displacement in error, self-luminosity versus the second-order after-cognition. That they agree here shows that the exclusion follows from the definition of an instrument rather than from any school-specific commitment.

Three clarifications are essential. First, the ground is not unreliability: memory may be true, useful and successfully action-guiding, and none of this confers instrument-status. Second, the exclusion is definitional, which is its strength - it concedes everything a defender of memory might want to say while denying only the title. Third, it is a verdict about status and not about irrelevance, since memory remains indispensable within comparison (**upamāna**), within Prabhākara's own analysis of error, and within ordinary sentence-comprehension.

Discussion may note the cost: because the exclusion turns on a definition, a rival could contest the definition itself. The standing reply is that it is not arbitrary, since it tracks a real difference between disclosing and retrieving.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025, Question 5(c), 10 marks

Printed question. Delineate the main points of difference between the theory of intrinsic validation (svataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) and theory of extrinsic validation (parataḥ prāmāṇyavāda) in classical Indian philosophy.

Directive read. "Delineate the main points of difference" wants discrete contrasts; "in classical Indian philosophy" wants more than two schools.

Model answer (200 words).

The two theories divide on four cells, not one. Intrinsic validation, held by Mīmāṃsā, treats both the origin (**utpatti**) and the ascertainment (**jñapti**) of validity as intrinsic: the conditions that generate a cognition generate its validity, and the cognition presents itself as trustworthy unaided. Invalidity, by contrast, is extrinsic in both respects, arising from a defect (**doṣa**) and becoming known through a defeater (**bādhaka**), contradiction or practical failure. Extrinsic validation, held by Nyāya, treats both the origin and the ascertainment of validity as extrinsic relative to the mere occurrence of the cognition.

The points of difference follow. First, burden of proof: Mīmāṃsā places it on the challenger, Nyāya on the cognition. Second, mechanism: Nyāya certifies by successful activity (**pravṛtti-sāmarthya**) or confirming perception (**saṃvādi-pratyakṣa**), while Mīmāṃsā denies that later success can generate validity. Third, regress: a validating cognition would itself need validation, producing **anavasthā**. Fourth, the decisive distinction: validity itself versus our ascertainment of it.

Placed more widely, Sāṃkhya is presented as intrinsic on both counts, and Buddhist epistemology as the mirror-image, extrinsic validity with intrinsic invalidity - which Mīmāṃsā rejects, since illusion does not announce itself as illusion.

The essential qualification is that intrinsic validity is *defeasible default warrant*, not infallibility.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025, Question 6(c), 15 marks

Printed question. Discuss the debate between the Bhaṭṭa and the Prabhākara mīmāṃsakas with reference to the nature of Non-existence (Abhāva) and its knowledge.

Directive read. An *internal* Mīmāṃsā debate. Answering it as Mīmāṃsā versus Nyāya is off-target, though Nyāya may enter as a comparison.

Model answer (296 words).

The debate is intra-Mīmāṃsā and runs on two connected questions: what absence (**abhāva**) is, and how it is known.

Kumārila Bhaṭṭa treats absence as real. It is not a feature of language but a structured content determined by its counterpositive (**pratiyogin**), so that "absence of pot" has genuine ontological standing and negative cognition has a genuine object. Correspondingly, he admits a sixth instrument, non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**), defined as non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present and limited by fitness (**yogyatā**): the object must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper.

His reasons are two refusals. Perception yields positive content - table, colour, shape - whereas "absence of pot" is not a positive datum of that kind, so perceiving the empty table is not yet cognising the pot's absence. Inference needs a positive sign and a known concomitance; if "not-seeing" is offered as the sign, its evidentiary force already presupposes non-apprehension under fit conditions, so the reduction is strained or circular.

Prabhākara declines both the ontology and the instrument. What is known, he holds, is simply the locus as unqualified by the absent object: we perceive the table as bare, not as occupied by the pot, and the bare-locus cognition already carries the negative differentiation required. No special faculty for what is not there need be posited. His position is an economy thesis, not a denial that absences are known. Kumārila's counter is that economy purchased by flattening a determinate negative judgement into a positive perception is false economy.

For comparison, Nyāya converges with Prabhākara against Kumārila on independence while diverging in its reason, since it holds that absence is itself directly perceived. The graded verdict is that Kumārila is the more faithful phenomenologist and Prabhākara the more economical metaphysician.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

These six questions are written in the style and directive-vocabulary of the paper. They are original practice items, not previous-year questions.

Original 1 - 10 marks

Question. Explain why Mīmāṃsā treats Vedic testimony as the only competent means of knowing dharma rather than as a source of last resort. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (172 words).

In most systems testimony is a convenience: it saves labour where perception or inference could in principle have done the work. In Mīmāṃsā it is nothing of the kind, and the difference follows from the object rather than from any preference for scripture.

Duty (**dharma**) is supersensible. It is not a present sensible object, so perception is structurally disqualified. It is not reached by any sign standing in a known concomitance with it, so inference is disqualified too. The school's defining formula makes this explicit: duty is that whose distinguishing mark is Vedic injunction - **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah**.

An instrument is individuated in Mīmāṃsā by the manner in which it generates cognition, and matched to the kind of object it can disclose. Since only verbal testimony can disclose an object of this kind, testimony here is not second-best; it is the sole competent witness.

Two consequences follow. Vedic testimony must be impersonal, since a human speaker would import defect. And its authority must be intrinsic, since no external certifier for a supersensible domain exists.

Original 2 - 10 marks

Question. Discuss the significance of the claim that non-cognition operates only under conditions of fitness. Answer in about 175 words.

Model answer (168 words).

The fitness condition (**yogyatā**) is not a technical footnote to non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) but the clause that makes the doctrine defensible, and its significance is threefold.

First, it converts a non-event into evidence. Non-apprehension is informative only where the conditional holds that the object *would* have been apprehended if present: the thing must be perceptible in kind, the locus suitable, the organ functioning, and light, distance and attention proper. "No pot on this bare, well-lit table" satisfies this; "no atoms here" does not.

Second, it answers the standing objection that non-perception is too subjective. Careless overlooking is excluded by the same clause that admits genuine absence-cognition, so the instrument cannot be used to license an argument from ignorance.

Third, it defeats the inferential reduction. If "not-seeing" is offered as a positive sign, one must explain why not-seeing carries evidentiary force - and that force is exactly what fitness supplies. The reduction therefore presupposes the doctrine it was meant to replace.

Fitness thus does simultaneous work as definition, defence and refutation.

Original 3 - 15 marks

Question. Examine the view that Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator God strengthens rather than weakens its defence of the Veda. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (283 words).

The view is well founded, though it must be stated with two qualifications.

The strengthening argument is straightforward. Mīmāṃsā grounds Vedic authority in authorlessness (**apauruṣeyatva**): unreliability in testimony is traced to authorial defects - error, deceit, partiality, forgetfulness - and a text with no author has no locus for them. If God authored the Veda, the Veda would have an author, and its authority would then depend on establishing that author's existence, omniscience and truthfulness. Nyāya's three-stage burden is exactly this. By removing the author entirely, Mīmāṃsā removes the burden, and the text becomes self-valid in the domain of duty, where no rival instrument supplies a defeater.

The rejection is also independently argued rather than merely convenient. God is not perceptually given; the inference from world to maker fails, since pots are observed to be made by embodied artisans while worlds are not observed to be made by bodiless creators; a beginning of creation raises an unanswerable question about divine motive; and moral order is already regulated by action, merit, demerit and unseen potency (**apūrva**). Against the demand for a giver of karmic fruits, the decisive move is a dilemma: a God who distributes strictly by karma is redundant, and one who distributes otherwise is partial.

The first qualification is that the deities of ritual are not abolished. They remain mantra-denoted entities to whom offerings are made, subordinate to the sacrifice, with the fruit produced by act and unseen potency rather than by divine favour.

The second is that the strengthening is internal. Critics who find an unconscious potency less intelligible than a conscious Lord are unmoved, and it remains genuinely contested whether the atheism is a considered metaphysics or a by-product of exegetical necessity.

Original 4 - 15 marks

Question. Critically discuss whether Mīmāṃsā's theory of intrinsic validity can be defended without collapsing into credulity. Answer in about 275 words.

Model answer (285 words).

The charge of credulity is the most persistent objection to intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**), and the defence succeeds only partially.

The doctrine is that a cognition is valid by its own occurrence under normal conditions, while invalidity requires a defect (**doṣa**) and is disclosed by a defeater (**bādhaka**). Three considerations support it. The regress argument: if every cognition required another for validation, the validator would need a validator, generating **anavasthā**. The argument from practice: crossing a road, reading a page or obeying an instruction presupposes immediate trust, and no first action could be launched if certification came first. And economy: doubt is parasitic on a more basic trust.

Against credulity, the school makes two further moves. It insists that the thesis is defeasible default warrant and not infallibilism, so correction is welcomed rather than resisted. And it presupposes realism - cognitions are directed at real objects and normal causes tend toward truth - which prevents the doctrine from reducing to mere self-certification by the mind.

The dream and mirage objection is met by distinguishing the appearance of normalcy from normalcy itself: exhaustion and sleep in one case, heated air and optical distortion in the other, are extrinsic defects, so these cognitions do not arise from fully normal truth-producing conditions.

Critically, however, the reply relocates the difficulty rather than dissolving it. Everything now turns on identifying a genuine defect, and Nyāya can press that "abnormal conditions" is a label applied retrospectively whenever a cognition proves false. Whether the doctrine escapes circularity or merely shifts it into the notions of defect and defeater is genuinely contested.

The defensible verdict is that intrinsic validity avoids credulity in principle, provided defect is independently specifiable - which is precisely the point still under dispute.

Original 5 - 20 marks

Question. Analyse the claim that Mīmāṃsā's philosophy of language is shaped throughout by the requirement that an authorless text must be able to command. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (368 words).

The claim is largely correct, and tracing it explains why Mīmāṃsā's semantics takes the unusual shape it does.

Begin with the requirement. The Veda is authorless (**apauruṣeyatva**), and its central function is injunction (**vidhi / codanā**). A text with no speaker must therefore generate obligation out of its own structure. Every major semantic doctrine of the school can be read as a condition of that possibility.

First, sentence-unity. Obligation is carried by sentences, not by words, so the school must explain how a word-sequence yields one cognition (**ekavākyatā**). Both sub-schools accept expectancy (**ākāṅkṣā**), fitness (**yogyatā**) and proximity (**sannidhi**) as the conditions of that unity.

Second, the treatment of purport. Naiyāyikas add purport (**tātparya**), the speaker's intended thrust. Mīmāṃsā cannot use it, because there is no speaker; purport must be relocated into textual force, contextual unity and subordination to injunction. This is a direct consequence of the requirement.

Third, the two rival semantics. Kumāṛila's connection-of-the-already-denoted secures stable lexical meaning across contexts, which an eternal text needs if its words are not to shift with usage. Prabhākara's denotation-of-the-connected, supported by the learning argument (**vyutpatti**), secures that words are grasped in action-guiding wholes - which fits an injunction-centred scripture even more snugly.

Fourth, the theory of injunctive force. Kumāṛila locates imperative force in verbal impelling force (**śābdī bhāvanā**), whose result is the agent's impulse, distinguished from objective productive force (**ārthī bhāvanā**), whose result is the fruit; Prabhākara locates bindingness in the directly apprehended to-be-done (**niyoga**). Both answers exist because the command must issue from the sentence rather than from a commander.

Fifth, the eternal word and the rejection of the sound-burst. If word-units are eternal and merely manifested by utterance, the text does not depend on temporal composition; and the Grammarian sound-burst is rejected because phonemes with ordered manifestation already suffice.

Two qualifications are needed. The shaping is not total: the universal-particular dispute has its own motivations in the theory of perception and in the debate with Buddhist exclusion. And the requirement generates the school's most

contested commitments - the naturalness of word-meaning and the eternity of the word - which Nyāya and the Dharmakīrti line both deny.

The claim is therefore best stated as strong explanatory pressure rather than as complete determination.

Original 6 - 20 marks

Question. Evaluate Mīmāṃsā's expansion of the list of means of valid knowledge to six, with reference to postulation, non-cognition and the exclusion of memory. Answer in about 375 words.

Model answer (372 words).

The expansion is principled rather than promiscuous, but it is not uniformly successful, and the evaluation must be graded.

The governing rule is irreducibility: an instrument is admitted only where a type of knowledge cannot be reduced to another without remainder or without circularity. Perception handles the directly given, inference the sign-based, testimony the verbally transmitted, comparison the resemblance-based. The question is whether two further kinds of cognition resist all four.

Postulation (**arthāpatti**) has the stronger case, and both sub-schools accept it. Stout Devadatta who does not eat by day yields night-eating, not through a sign but through explanatory tension. Three arguments block reduction to inference: no concomitance (**vyāpti**) is independently established; the movement runs from tension to reconciling postulate rather than from sign to signified; and there is no subject-reason-probandum structure. The Nyāya reduction is further shown to be circular, since the concomitance it needs is itself abstracted from postulating moves. The claim is also stronger than modern inference to the best explanation: the postulate is required, not merely preferred.

Non-cognition (**anupalabdhi**) is the harder case, and only Kumārila accepts it. Its strength is phenomenological: "there is no pot on the table" is definite and action-guiding, and reducing it to perception of a bare locus flattens a negative judgement into a positive one. Its discipline is the fitness condition (**yogyatā**), which excludes careless overlooking and imperceptible objects alike. Its cost is ontological, since absence (**abhāva**) must be real and structured by a counterpositive (**pratiyogin**) - a cost Prabhākara and Nyāya both refuse, converging against Bhāṭṭa on independence while diverging in their reasons.

The exclusion of memory shows that the rule cuts both ways. Memory reproduces already-cognised content and fails the novelty condition (**anadhigatatva**), so it is denied instrument-status even though it may be true, useful and action-guiding - and Nyāya agrees. A school that merely wished to inflate its list would not have exercised this restraint.

The graded verdict is therefore that the expansion is defensible in method and unequal in result. Postulation is Mīmāṃsā's most robust epistemological contribution; non-cognition is its most faithful and most expensive; and the exclusion of memory is the clearest evidence that the school's longer list is the product of a rule rather than of appetite.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Prerequisite before this block is usable

Nothing in this block is needed for a competent answer to any of the fourteen previous-year questions owned by this syllabus item. The Basic block above is independently answer-complete: it carries the project, the lineage, the sub-school grid, intrinsic validity and its rival, the full instrument-list with postulation and non-cognition, the exclusion of memory, all four theories of error, the three accounts of knowing-that-one-knows, the entailment question, both semantics, the universal-particular dispute, authorlessness, injunction theory with unseen potency, the rejection of a creator, and the self, liberation and graded verdict.

Use this block only after the Basic block is secure and after a clean attempt at the relevant previous-year question. In a 15- or 20-mark answer, **one** enrichment move is usually enough and two is the ceiling; it belongs in the final evaluative or contextual paragraph, never in the exposition.

ADVANCED MODULE 1 - Unseen potency as a non-theistic bridge

The precise issue. How does Mīmāṃsā connect ritual action to a future fruit without appealing to God? The Basic block gives the answer - unseen potency (**apūrva**), established by postulation. The optional question is *what kind of thing* the potency is taken to be.

Two readings. ANALYSIS: A **stronger metaphysical reading** treats unseen potency as a real unseen capacity generated by the act and persisting until it matures. ANALYSIS: A **more restrained reading** treats it as naming the normative-causal continuity that Vedic action requires, rather than as an additional □-like entity in the ontology.

The strongest extra objection. WRONG: Unseen potency looks like a mysterious placeholder: it is named exactly where an explanation is missing, and it does no work that the word "somehow" would not do.

The counter-reply. FACT: The objection is fair as far as it goes, but the comparison is not between unseen potency and a clear alternative; it is between unseen potency and a divine reward-distributor. Mīmāṃsā's claim is that the latter is the costlier posit, since it must be established by an instrument before it can be used to establish anything, and it then faces the redundant-or-unjust dilemma.

Source trail. Jaimini, *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra*; Śābara, *Śābara-bhāṣya*; Kumārila Bhaṭṭa, *Ślokavārtika*.

Where one line of this belongs. In the evaluative paragraph of an answer on ritual causality, on the school's atheism, or on postulation's range - never in the exposition of what unseen potency is.

ADVANCED MODULE 2 - Injunction-centred language as a doctrinal choice

The precise issue. Is the Veda authoritative mainly because it *reports truths*, or because it *issues uniquely action-guiding injunctions* about duty? The Basic block records that Mīmāṃsā takes the second option; the optional question is what that choice costs and why the school pays it.

Two readings. ANALYSIS: A **descriptive reading** of scripture is the weaker option, because it would make the Veda one report among others and would surrender the domain-restriction on which its self-validity depends. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā's **stronger line** makes injunction (**vidhi**) central and demotes mantra, name and praise passage to supportive status secured by sentence-unity.

The strongest extra objection. WRONG: This narrows scripture to ritual command, converting a vast and various literature into an instruction manual with footnotes.

The counter-reply. FACT: Mīmāṃsā accepts the narrowing openly, because its project is inquiry into duty and not speculative theology or literary appreciation. ANALYSIS: The cost becomes visible precisely at the Vedānta seam: if knowledge is not an action, an identity-sentence cannot be governed by injunctive hermeneutics, and Advaita's appeal to an accomplished fact (**siddha-vastu**) is the standing reply.

Source trail. Jaimini, *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra*; Śābara, *Śābara-bhāṣya*; studies on Mīmāṃsā hermeneutics in the K. Kunhan Raja line.

Where one line of this belongs. In a comparative conclusion on Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta, or in a critical answer on injunction theory.

ADVANCED MODULE 3 - Intrinsic validity as a general anti-sceptical epistemology

The precise issue. Is intrinsic validity (**svataḥ-prāmāṇya**) only a ritual doctrine designed to protect scripture, or a wider epistemic conservatism about cognition as such?

Two readings. ANALYSIS: A **narrow ritualist reading** treats the doctrine as serving the Veda, so that its generality is incidental. ANALYSIS: A **broader epistemic reading** treats it as a general realism and a theory of default entitlement, of which the defence of scripture is one application.

The strongest extra objection. WRONG: Default trust makes error too hard to explain: if cognition is authoritative on arrival, the theory owes an account of illusion that does not simply relabel it.

The counter-reply. FACT: The school's standing answer is that error is parasitic and later defeated, and that scepticism need not be the starting point; both sub-schools supply detailed theories of error precisely to discharge this debt. CAUTION: Whether the doctrine finally escapes circularity or merely relocates the burden into "defect" and "defeater" remains genuinely open.

Source trail. Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa, *Ślokavārttika*; Prabhākara Miśra, *Bṛhaṭī*; studies in Indian epistemology in the J. N. Mohanty line.

Where one line of this belongs. In the opening or closing sentence of an answer on intrinsic validity, to lift it from doctrine-reporting to philosophical placement.

What not to over-study

ANALYSIS: Once the Basic block and the fourteen routed questions are secure, do **not** invest further time in exhaustive injunction and praise-passage taxonomies, in ritual minutiae, or in post-classical scholastic cross-classifications. These consume preparation time and are not what the printed questions test. The same applies to expanding the hermeneutic canons into a syllabus of their own; the sources hold them as a controlled comparison with rule-governed legal interpretation, and that is the level at which they should be used.

When this block would stop being optional

FACT: Promote this material to Core if a future paper explicitly asks about unseen potency, about injunction theory as such, or about whether intrinsic validity is best read as a full anti-sceptical epistemology rather than a scriptural convenience. Until then it is enrichment, and no core answer depends on it.

Three genuinely contested matters to report as contested

- CAUTION: Whether intrinsic validity fully avoids circularity, or merely relocates the burden onto the notions of defect and defeater.
- CAUTION: Whether Mīmāṃsā's rejection of a creator is a considered metaphysics in its own right, or primarily a consequence of the exegetical need to protect authorlessness.
- CAUTION: How the historical development of the liberation doctrine should be placed within early and later Mīmāṃsā, given that the earliest orientation is toward duty and ritual fruit.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

These are compressed revision notes for the complete topic, arranged in the teaching order of the nineteen sessions. They prioritise definitions, exact terminology, argument-steps, comparisons, traps, previous-year routes and rapid-recall facts, and they do not repeat the introductory prose already given above. The Basic/Optional-Advanced distinction is preserved: parts A-S are Core; the Optional Advanced block above is not summarised here because no core answer depends on it.

A. The project and the formula

- **Inquiry into duty (dharma-jijñāsā)**; formula **codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah** - duty is that whose distinguishing mark is Vedic injunction.
- Duty is supersensible => perception and inference disqualified => verbal testimony is the *only* competent instrument, not a fallback.
- Defending the Veda therefore requires defending cognition => intrinsic validity.
- Minimum metaphysics: real enduring objects; plurality of selves as knower-agent-enjoyer; no creator needed; unseen potency carries the act to the fruit; beginningless moral order.
- Three enabling propositions: knowledge possible because objects are real; obligation possible because injunction is meaningful; future fruit possible because action leaves a potency.
- Error must remain exceptional or ritual instruction collapses into uncertainty.
- ANALYSIS: Read narrowly the school looks ritualist; read philosophically it is a general epistemic realism.

B. Lineage and the ownership boundary

- Jaimini, *Mīmāṃsā-sūtra* -> Śābara, *Śābara-bhāṣya* (foundational surviving commentary) -> Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa (*Ślokaṇṭika*, *Tantravārttika*) = **Bhāṭṭa**; Prabhākara Miśra (*Bṛhatī*), with **Śālikanātha** as major later expositor = **Prābhākara**.

- Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā owns **injunction · duty · authorless verbal authority · ritual interpretation**.

Uttara-Mīmāṃsā (Vedānta) owns the Brahman-centred reading of the Upaniṣads.

- CAUTION: Chronology and attribution are debatable; doctrinal ownership is not. Assert doctrine confidently, sequence cautiously.

- ANALYSIS: **Bhāṭṭa** (Kumāṛila's school) ≠ **Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa** (the sceptical Cārvāka-adjacent author).

C. The two sub-schools - one instinct, six consequences

Issue	Bhāṭṭa	Prābhākara
Instruments	six, including non-cognition	five
Absence	real, with counterpositive; own instrument	bare locus, unqualified; no instrument
Error	contrary apprehension (viparīta-khyāti)	non-discrimination (akhyāti / vivekākhyāti)
Cognition of cognition	knownness (jñātātā) => inference	threefold awareness (tripuṭī-saṃvit)
Sentence meaning	connection-of-the-denoted (abhihitānvaya)	denotation-of-the-connected (anvitābhidhāna)
Motivation	desired fruit (bhāvanā-vāda)	command itself (niyoga-vāda)

- Shared: Vedic authority · realism · ritual efficacy through unseen potency · intrinsic validity ·

irreducibility as the admission test. ANALYSIS: Say **unity in difference** explicitly.

D. Intrinsic validity

- Thesis: a cognition is valid by its own occurrence under normal conditions; every cognition carries *prima facie* validity unless and until defeated.

- Fourfold: validity intrinsic in **origin (utpatti)** and **ascertainment (jñapti)**; invalidity extrinsic in both - needs a **defect (doṣa)** and a **defeater (bādhaka)**.

- Argument: (i) cognition discloses an object; (ii) external validation regresses; (iii) **anavasthā**; (iv) some cognition must be self-valid; (v) most economically, each is; (vi-viii) lived practice confirms default trust; (ix) otherwise no first action; (x) economy; (xi) burden on the challenger.

- Presupposition: realism - objects are real, normal causes tend to truth.

- ANALYSIS: **Not infallibilism**. Default validity, not incorrigibility.

- Example: seeing a pot; no certificate sought; revoked only on discovering defect or contradiction.

- Objections/replies: error impossible? -> extrinsic defect. Gullibility? -> defeasible. Correction proves prior invalidity? -> proves an unnoticed defect. Why call valid before checking? -> correspondence-checking must itself start from trust.

E. The extrinsic rival and the comparative strip

- Nyāya **parataḥ-prāmāṇya**: validity extrinsic in origin and ascertainment; routes = **successful activity (pravṛtti-sāmarthya) and confirming perception (saṃvādi-pratyakṣa)**.

- Mīmāṃsā counters: (i-iii) acting presupposes trust, so Nyāya uses what it postpones; (iv-v) regress returns; (vi-vii) success confirms, never generates => **validity ≠ ascertainment of validity**.

- Dream/mirage: WRONG: normal-seeming yet false. FACT: Appearance of normalcy is not normalcy - exhaustion, sleep-state, heated air, optical distortion are extrinsic defects.

- Strip: Mīmāṃsā I/E · Nyāya E/E · Sāṃkhya I/I · Buddhist E/I. FACT: Against Buddhism: if falsity were intrinsic, illusion would announce itself - it does not.
- Doubt is parasitic on trust. ANALYSIS: Residual: distinguishing default trust from credulity.

F. The instrument-list and its rule

- Counts: Sāṃkhya 3 · Nyāya 4 · Prābhākara 5 · Bhāṭṭa 6.
- Definitions: perception = sense-object contact; inference = sign through known concomitance; comparison = fresh cognition of similarity of a remembered absent object to a perceived one; testimony = valid verbal testimony, especially Vedic, on duty; postulation = necessary postulation reconciling incompatible facts; non-cognition = knowledge of absence through non-apprehension of the presentable.
- Rule: admit only where reduction fails **without remainder or without circularity**; instruments are individuated by the *manner* of generation, not by topic.
- Three-term vocabulary: **pramāṇa** (means) -> **pramā** / **pramiti** (true cognition) -> **successful action** (confirms, never creates).
- ANALYSIS: Not a psychology of faculties; a taxonomy of logical structures.

G. The four shared instruments, Mīmāṃsā-tuned

- Perception: **indeterminate (nirvikalpaka / ālocana-jñāna)** -> **determinate (savikalpaka)** - "this is a white moving cow"; the second interprets, does not falsify. Anti-Buddhist realism.
- Inference: fully accepted (smoke => fire); only **reductionism about inference** is refused.
- Comparison: remembered cow <-> perceived **gavaya**; new cognition = *the absent cow is similar to this*. ANALYSIS: Not the Nyāya word-reference account. CAUTION: Wider analogical reading of Śābara exists.
- Testimony: by source **personal (pauruṣeya) / impersonal (apauruṣeya)**; by function **fact-stating (siddhārtha) / action-enjoining (vidhāyaka)**. Kumāṛila keeps the distinction while centring injunction; Prabhākara reads language through action-guidance more radically.

H. Memory excluded

- Ground: an instrument produces a **fresh** cognition; memory reproduces => fails **novelty (anadhigatatva)**.
- Prābhākara's five steps: must generate new cognition -> depends on earlier cognition + impression (**saṃskāra**) -> reproduces old content -> reveals no new object -> not an instrument.
- Nyāya concurs => the 2024 pairing of the two schools.
- ANALYSIS: True, useful and action-guiding ≠ instrument-status. Temple example.
- ANALYSIS: Memory still operates inside comparison, inside Prābhākara's error-theory, and inside sentence-comprehension.

I. Postulation

- Structure: A and B known; incompatible unless C; therefore C. Necessity = explanatory reconciliation; output is the **minimally reconciling** postulate.
- Devadatta: stout (perception) + no day-eating (testimony/observation) + stoutness □ no nourishment => night-eating, neither perceived nor remembered.
- Forms: **dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti** (perceived facts) and **śrutārthāpatti** (heard words; ellipsis, contextual completion). Both are necessity, not hypothesis.
- Three anti-reduction arguments: no independently established **vyāpti**; direction runs from tension to postulate, not sign to signified; no **pakṣa-hetu-sādhya** structure.

- Nyāya reduction (fatness = hetu, eating = sādhyā) is **circular**, since its concomitance is itself postulation-derived.
- ANALYSIS: Stronger than inference to the best explanation: required, not merely best.
- Reappears as the instrument establishing **apūrva** and as the *form* of the authorlessness argument.

J. Non-cognition and absence

- Definition: non-apprehension of what would be apprehended if present; **Bhāṭṭa** only.
- Seven steps: we know absences -> definite and action-guiding -> not perception (positive content) -> not inference (positive sign) -> not memory/comparison/testimony -> independent source needed -> **anupalabdhi**.
- Fitness (**yogyatā** / **yogyānupalabdhi**): perceptible in kind · suitable locus · functioning organ · proper light, distance, attention. FACT: "no pot on this lit table"; □ "no atoms here".
- Two refusals: perception gives positive data, so an empty table ≠ pot-absence; inference needs a positive sign, and "not-seeing" borrows its force from fitness => strained or circular.
- Ontology: **abhāva** real, structured by **counterpositive (pratiyogin)**.
- Rivals: Prābhākara = bare locus, unqualified (economy thesis); Nyāya = absence ****directly perceived****, "pot-absence-on-the-floor". ANALYSIS: Nyāya + Prābhākara converge against Bhāṭṭa on independence only.
- ANALYSIS: Not "I failed to notice"; a determinate verdict of absence. Everyday vindication: no chalk, no key, no bus.

K. Theories of error

Theory	School	Shell-silver	Status of "silver"
akhyāti / vivekākhyāti	Prābhākara	two valid cognitions, difference not apprehended	no false silver at all
viparīta-khyāti	Bhāṭṭa	shell positively miscognised as silver	really wrong identification
anyathā-khyāti	Nyāya	real silver known elsewhere presented here	real but displaced
anirvacanīya-khyāti	Advaita	indescribable appearance, later sublated	neither real nor unreal

- Prābhākara's five steps: valid perception of "this shining thing" + valid memory of silver -> difference not apprehended -> behaviour follows -> no extra false cognition needed.
- Bhāṭṭa's seven steps: shell present -> defect (light, distance, lustre, organ) -> single false cognition "this is silver" -> false -> falsity extrinsic -> correction on approach -> invalidity known extrinsically.
- **2022 answer**: same thesis, two defence strategies - Prābhākara protects every ****constituent cognition, Bhāṭṭa protects the principle**** governing normal cognition.
- ANALYSIS: Highest-value distinction: Bhāṭṭa **misidentifies this object**; Nyāya ****misplaces one known elsewhere****.
- ANALYSIS: **akhyāti** = non-apprehension *of difference*, not total non-apprehension.

L. Knowing that one knows

- Problem: regress of cognitions-of-cognitions.
- **Prābhākara**: self-luminous (**svaprakāśa**); one act discloses **jñātṛ / jñeya / jñāna** (**tripuṭī-saṃvit**); **lamp** analogy; no metacognitive gap; reflection is later articulation.
- **Bhāṭṭa**: not self-luminous; object acquires **knownness (jñātātā)**; cognition inferred; **painter** analogy; temporal and logical gap.
- **Nyāya**: distinct second-order **after-cognition (anuvyavasāya)**, "I know the pot"; reflective

gap; treated as sufficient without endless repetition.

- Objections: Prābhākara conflates the three? -> disclosed, not collapsed. Bhāṭṭa's knownness mysterious? -> cost accepted. Nyāya regress? -> one act suffices.
- Three gaps: **none / inferential / reflective**.

M. Self-luminosity and intrinsic validity

- Two different questions: **manifestation** versus **truth-entitlement**. No entailment follows from definitions.
- Nyāya: neither (after-cognition + extrinsic validity). Prābhākara: both. Advaita: both, with self-luminosity of consciousness *as such* and empirical validity until **sublation**. **Bhāṭṭa: intrinsic validity WITHOUT self-luminosity** => decisive counterexample.
- ANALYSIS: Nyāya is not "self-luminous but extrinsically valid."
- Verdict first, then the grid, then the qualification that independence is not irrelevance.

N. Sentence-unity and the two semantics

- Problem: **ekavākyatā** - many words, one cognition. Vedic obligation is grasped through sentence-meaning.
- Shared conditions: **expectancy (ākāṅkṣā)** - "Bring ..."; **fitness (yogyatā)** - "sprinkle with fire"; **proximity (sannidhi / āsatti)** - separated discourse.
- Contested fourth: **purport (tātparya)**, added by Naiyāyikas. ANALYSIS: Mīmāṃsā must relocate it into textual force, contextual unity and subordination to injunction, because the Veda has no author.
- **Bhāṭṭa abhihitānvayavāda**: word denotes via **abhidhā**, then meanings connect via ****lakṣaṇā / tātparya-śakti****; word primary; stages logical, not temporal; explains stable lexicon.
- **Prābhākara anvitābhidhānavāda**: words denote only as connected; ****learning argument (vyutpatti)**** - elder commands, younger complies, child learns; sentence primary; explains action-guidance.
- Four cross-objections: unobserved isolated stage / word meaning differently each time / learning begins in sentences / single-word commands - with replies.
- Test sentence **svargakāmo yajeta**. Verdict: stable lexicon versus contextual action-guidance.

O. Universals, exclusion and the rejected sound-burst

- Mīmāṃsā: **universal (jāti)** primary; individual reached through it in context. Nyāya: **individual (vyakti)** qualified by universal and form, primary. ANALYSIS: Both reach both - **priority, not coverage**.
- Argument: repeatability of "cow" requires a stable semantic ground.
- WRONG: A universal cannot be milked => FACT: primary for *meaning*; action reaches the qualified individual.
- WRONG: Buddhist **apoha**: "cow" excludes non-cows => FACT: pure exclusion cannot ground stable positive recognition and repeatable application.
- ANALYSIS: Grammarian **sphoṭa-vāda** (Bharṭṛhari): indivisible **vākya-sphoṭa** because sounds perish => FACT: both sub-schools reject it: eternal **phonemes (varṇa)** + ordered manifestation + the three conditions suffice; memory of the ordered series supplies unity.

P. Authorlessness

- Thesis: **apauruṣeyatva** - not composed by any human or divine person; hence no locus for ignorance, deceit, partiality, forgetfulness.
- Eight steps: no remembered author -> such an author would be remembered -> **autpattika** word-meaning relation -> **śabda-nityatva**, utterance manifests -> transmission without located composition -> not a composed book -> authorial defects explain unreliability -> authorless text free of them.
- Four-defect argument; three-stage burden against Nyāya's God-guarantee (exists -> omniscient -> truthful).
- ANALYSIS: Not a denial of reciters and transmitters. **Kaṭha**, **Kauṣītaki** = schools/branches, not composers.
- Circularity charge, two forms; six replies: ordinary reasoning not quotation · **arthāpatti**-form · defeasibility with **doṣa/bādhaka** · rivals have defect-loci · **domain restriction to dharma** · divine author is worse.
- Residual: **Jayanta**, **Udayana** on **saṅketa** and the Veda as **āpta**-testimony; **Dharmakīrti** line on timed cognition from an eternal word => FACT: "manifested, not produced."

Q. Injunction, impelling force, obligation and unseen potency

- Five sentence-functions: **vidhi** · **niṣedha** · **mantra** · **nāmadheya** · **arthavāda**; the last three gain Vedic force by **ekavākyatā** with an injunction.
- Three kinds of injunction: **apūrva-vidhi** (novel) · **niyama-vidhi** (restrictive) · **parisaṃkhyā-vidhi** (exclusionary). ANALYSIS: Separate grid: **utpatti** · **viniyoga** · **prayoga** · **adhikāra**.
- **Bhāṭṭa**: **śābdī bhāvanā** (locus = the sentence) => **pravṛtti**; **ārthī bhāvanā** (locus = agent's effort) => **phala**, mediated by unseen potency.
- **Three factors (aṃśa-traya)**: **sādhya/bhāvya** (*kim?*) · **karaṇa/sādhana** (*kena?*) · **itikartavyatā** (*katham?*). Objective force: heaven / sacrifice / procedure. Verbal force: impulse / injunctive suffix and knowledge of it / eulogistic support.
- **Prābhākara**: **kārya** / **niyoga** binds directly => **niyoga-vāda** versus **bhāvanā-vāda**. ANALYSIS: Kant comparison only with the disanalogy - heteronomous, impersonal Veda, ritually qualified **adhikārin**.
- Imperative force carried by the **liṅ/vidhi** form, whose relation to meaning is **autpattika**.
- **Apūrva**: act limited in time, fruit remote; without a remainder the connection is unintelligible; therefore postulated by **arthāpatti**. Flames do not travel to heaven.
- Vedānta seam: "**tat tvam asi**"; Advaita's **siddha-vastu** and "knowledge is not an action."
- ANALYSIS: Hermeneutic canons **śruti-liṅga-vākya-prakaraṇa-sthāna-samākhyā** and **utsarga-apavāda** are held as a controlled comparison with rule-governed legal interpretation; disanalogy = infallible authorless text, no amendment by legislative intention.

R. No creator God

- **Nirīśvaravāda**: rejects a creator and a **karmaphaladātṛ**; retains **devatā** as mantra-denoted, subordinate to the sacrifice.
- Consistency: authority through **impersonality**, not divine authorship. Five steps: Veda authorless -> God-authored Veda is not authorless -> authority would need God's existence, omniscience, sincerity, freedom from defect -> weaker foundation -> rejection is part of the *defence* of Veda.
- Eight arguments: no perception · failed inference (embodied potter vs bodiless creator) · no decisive testimony · motive problem for a beginning · pre-creation problem · karma suffices · evil and partiality · loss of authorlessness.

- Objector's four steps (karma unconscious -> allotment precise -> needs omniscient dispenser -> God as fruit-giver) => replies: beginningless series · unseen potency · God's own status needs proof · **dilemma: redundant or unjust.**
- **WRONG:** Apūrva cannot "execute" results => **FACT:** less burdensome than an omniscient person managing every result.
- Kumārila also denies that any individual **sarvajña** is established by an instrument; Jaina and Buddhist traditions reply that omniscience is spiritually attained.
- **CAUTION:** Later softening of the anti-theistic edge in some traditions.

S. Self, liberation, comparisons and the graded verdict

- **Self:** enduring **ātman** as knower, agent, enjoyer; **plurality** of eternal selves; body, senses and internal organ mediate; not momentary; cognition **episodic**. Argument: the agent who sacrifices must be the enjoyer of the fruit.
- **Liberation:** **CAUTION:** explicit only in later Mīmāṃsā; not Brahman-identity; release from embodied suffering and karmic experience; requires stopping fresh merit and demerit and exhausting prior karma. **ANALYSIS:** Do not over-Vedāntise; do not make it God-dependent.
- **Five fronts.** Nyāya: validity, postulation, non-cognition, Veda, semantics, after-cognition.
Advaita: injunction- versus liberation-centred; realist versus indescribable error. Buddhism: pragmatic validity, self-intimating falsity, exclusion, momentariness. Sāṃkhya: ally on intrinsic validity, differs on invalidity and on ritual hermeneutics. Cārvāka: **ANALYSIS:** the reply establishes the **intelligibility** of non-perceptual knowledge, not the **proof** of every ritual claim.
- **Criticisms and replies:** gullibility -> defeasible; disguised inference -> no concomitance, no hetu-form; non-event -> fitness; strained error-theories -> sophisticated defences of default trust; meaning without intention -> eternal word-meaning relation; impersonal command -> verbal force or obligation; karma without allocator -> beginningless series plus the dilemma.
- **Strengths:** rigorous theory of testimony and interpretation · original account of default entitlement · self-consistent non-theistic normativity · expansion beyond perception-inference reductionism · sophisticated rule-governed interpretation.
- **Weaknesses:** **ANALYSIS:** eternality of the word · **ANALYSIS:** unverifiability of unseen potency and heaven · **ANALYSIS:** purport without intention · **ANALYSIS:** late and awkward soteriology.
- **Contested:** **CAUTION:** circularity of intrinsic validity · **CAUTION:** status of the atheism · **CAUTION:** placement of the liberation doctrine.
- **Ready verdicts.** 10 marks - strongest as a theory of intrinsic validity and Vedic testimony, stated as defeasible default validity, not infallibility. 15 marks - original in linking epistemology, hermeneutics and duty; weak in its contested assumptions of eternal language and unseen potency. 20 marks - a coherent impersonal foundation for duty and testimony within realist presuppositions, with language-eternity, authorlessness and ritual causality left philosophically contested by Nyāya, Buddhist and Vedāntic objections.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

This is the terminal-friendly, data-complete master flow. It is authored separately from the graphical package and is validated against the same Basic, Advanced and previous-year ledger. The same 24 panels are installed as a standalone text artifact and rendered as a standalone PDF.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/24: Syllabus, controlling question, and why epistemology serves duty

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/24: Syllabus, controlling question, and why epistemology serves duty

SYLLABUS ITEM 18, PRINTED VERBATIM: "Mīmāṃsā: Theory of Knowledge."

normalised: Mīmāṃsā (Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā) · theory of knowledge = pramāṇa-vada in service of dharma

CONTROLLING QUESTION how can a human being know what he OUGHT to do, when what he ought to do cannot be seen, touched, or inferred from anything visible?

```
+---- THE DEFINING FORMULA -----+
| dharma-jijñāsā ..... the school IS an inquiry into duty          |
| codanā-lakṣaṇo'rtho dharmah ..... duty is that good whose DISTINGUISHING MARK is |
|                                     Vedic injunction (codanā)         |
| consequence ..... epistemology is INSEPARABLE from hermeneutics |
+-----+
|
```

WHY EACH FAMOUS DOCTRINE EXISTS (read downwards: each repairs a specific hole)

duty is supersensible perception disqualified; inference has no sign

only verbal testimony reaches it . śabda is NOT a fallback here; it is the sole witness

but WHOSE word? a person may err, deceive, be partial, forget

=> AUTHORLESSNESS (apauruṣeyatva) removes the locus

but why trust ANY cognition? external certification regresses

=> INTRINSIC VALIDITY (svataḥ-prāmāṇya)

a text that binds with NO commander => injunction (vidhi) + bhāvanā / niyoga

an act that pays with NO paymaster => unseen ritual potency (apūrva)

therefore NO CREATOR GOD IS NEEDED ANYWHERE IN THE CHAIN (nirīśvaravāda)

MINIMUM METAPHYSICS (sparse, but load-bearing)

real enduring objects · plurality of selves as knower-agent-enjoyer

moral order regulated by action + apūrva · beginningless karmic series

THREE ENABLERS: objects real => knowledge possible · injunction meaningful =>

obligation possible · action leaves potency => future fruit possible

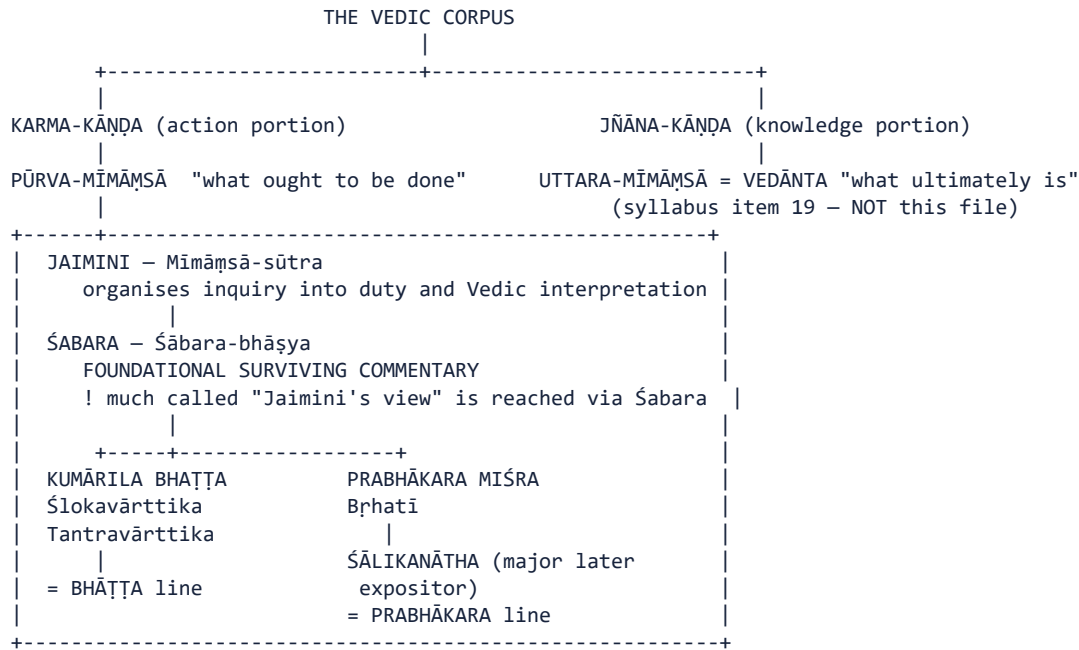
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+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE
| Mīmāṃsā's theory of knowledge is not an epistemology that happens to defend a
| scripture; it is a scripture-defence that HAD to become a general epistemology,
| because a text with no author can borrow no authority from outside cognition.
+-----+
|
```

! TRAP 1: do not write "Mīmāṃsā is only ritualism". The orientation is ritual; the epistemology is general.

! TRAP 2: do not treat verbal testimony as an emergency source. For duty it is the ONLY competent instrument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/24: Textual lineage and the Pūrva / Uttara ownership boundary

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/24: Textual lineage and the Pūrva / Uttara ownership boundary



OWNERSHIP FIREWALL – held HERE, not by Vedānta

injunction · duty · authorless verbal authority · ritual interpretation

OWNED THERE, not here

Brahman · maya · superimposition · identity-sentences as finally disclosive

SOURCE CONTROL

? relative chronology of Kumārila and Prabhākara, and the internal layering of the commentaries, are GENUINELY DISPUTED in scholarship

= assert DOCTRINAL OWNERSHIP confidently; assert HISTORICAL SEQUENCE cautiously

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+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE
| Pūrva- and Uttara-Mīmāṃsā are not two levels of one doctrine but two answers to the
| question of what a scripture is FOR: the earlier reads the Veda as a command, the
| later as a disclosure.
+-----+
```

! TRAP 1: BHĀṬṬA (school of Kumārila Bhaṭṭa) is NOT Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa, the sceptical Cārvāka-adjacent author.

! TRAP 2: never write "the Mīmāṃsā view" on error, absence or semantics without naming a sub-school; on all three there is no single Mīmāṃsā view.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/24: One instinct, six consequences - the Bhāṭṭa / Prabhākara grid

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/24: One instinct, six consequences – the Bhāṭṭa / Prabhākara grid

SHARED COMMITMENTS (never broken by either sub-school)

=====

Vedic authority · realism about objects and selves · ritual efficacy through apūrva
intrinsic validity of cognition · IRREDUCIBILITY as the admission test for instruments

=====

	BHĀṬṬA (Kumārila): ADMIT what resists reduction; pay the ontological cost	PRABHĀKARA: ECONOMISE, avoid positing extra faculties
1 INSTRUMENTS	SIX	FIVE
2 ABSENCE	abhāva is REAL, with a counterpositive (pratiyogin); known by anupalabdhi	the LOCUS is perceived as bare and unqualified; no separate instrument is needed
3 ERROR	viparīta-khyāti: a REAL false cognition, caused by defect	akhyāti / vivekākhyāti: failure to DISCRIMINATE two valid cognitions; NO false cognition at all
4 COGNITION OF COGNITION	NOT self-luminous; inferred from the object's jñātātā	IS self-luminous; knower, known and knowing revealed together
5 SEMANTICS	abhihitānvayavāda: words denote first, then meanings connect	anvitābhīdhānavāda: words denote only AS ALREADY CONNECTED
6 MOTIVATION	bhāvanā-vāda: the desired fruit moves the qualified agent	niyoga-vāda: the COMMAND ITSELF binds – duty for duty's sake

=====

EXAMINATION WEIGHT: of the 14 primary-owned parts, SIX name Bhāṭṭa or Prabhākara explicitly, and several more are unanswerable without the distinction.

+-----+

| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE |

| The Bhāṭṭa-Prabhākara dispute is not six quarrels but one: whether a philosopher |

| should enlarge his inventory to fit the phenomenon or trim the phenomenon to fit his |

| inventory. |

+-----+

! TRAP 1: PRABHĀKARA ACCEPTS FIVE, NOT SIX. The single most repeated error in this topic.

! TRAP 2: threefold awareness is Prabhākara's and knownness is Bhāṭṭa's – never reversed.

! TRAP 3: leanness is not superiority; Kumārila's reply is that economy purchased by distorting the phenomenon is false economy.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/24: Intrinsic validity - the four cells and the argument

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/24: Intrinsic validity – the four cells and the argument

A THEORY OF VALIDITY MUST ANSWER FOUR QUESTIONS, NOT ONE

	ORIGIN (utpatti) "what MAKES it so?"	ASCERTAINMENT (jnapti) "how is it KNOWN to be so?"
VALIDITY (prāmāṇya)	MĪMĀṂSĀ: INTRINSIC the same conditions that generate the cognition generate its validity	MĪMĀṂSĀ: INTRINSIC cognition presents itself as trustworthy, unaided
INVALIDITY (aprāmāṇya)	MĪMĀṂSĀ: EXTRINSIC requires a DEFECT (doṣa): bad light, distance, organ- damage, dream-state	MĪMĀṂSĀ: EXTRINSIC requires a DEFEATER (bādhaka): contradiction, failure, correction

THE STATEMENT: every cognition carries PRIMA FACIE validity unless and until defeated.

THE ARGUMENT (eleven steps as the school gives them)

- 1 cognition is meant to disclose an object
- 2 if every cognition needed another to validate it, the validator needs validation
- 3 => ANAVASTHĀ (infinite regress)
- 4 to avoid regress, SOME cognition must be valid without external validation
- 5 most economically, EACH cognition is prima facie valid on its own
- 6 we in fact live by trusting cognitions unless a defeating condition appears
- 7 practical life confirms DEFAULT TRUST, not default doubt
- 8 hence validity is intrinsic and invalidity adventitious
- 9 if confirmation were required for every cognition, no FIRST ACTION could be launched
- 10 therefore epistemic economy favours intrinsic validity
- 11 the BURDEN OF PROOF lies on the challenger, not on every fresh cognition

PRESUPPOSITION: REALISM – cognitions are aimed at real objects and normal causes tend toward truth. Without it the doctrine collapses into subjectivist self-certification.

WORKED EXAMPLE: I see a pot; I do not suspend judgement pending a certificate; I walk round it, lift it, refer to it. Only poor light, hallucination or contradiction revokes it.

OBJECTION -> REPLY BANK

- ! error should be impossible -> error needs an EXTRINSIC DEFECT
- ! this licenses gullibility -> the thesis is DEFEASIBLE and welcomes correction
- ! correction proves prior invalidity -> it proves an unnoticed defect was operating
- ! why call it valid before checking? -> checking must itself begin from a trusted cognition

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE
Intrinsic validity is Mīmāṃsā's refusal to let scepticism set the terms: doubt is parasitic on a trust that must already be in place before any doubt can be raised.

! TRAP: "intrinsic validity" is DEFEASIBLE DEFAULT WARRANT, never INFALLIBILISM.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/24: The extrinsic rival and the decisive distinction

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/24: The extrinsic rival and the decisive distinction

NYĀYA: PARATAH-PRAMANYAVADA – validity extrinsic in ORIGIN and in ASCERTAINMENT

ROUTE 1 successful practical activity (pravṛtti-sāmarthya)
"I walked over, touched it, drank it – so it was water"
ROUTE 2 confirming later perception (saṃvādi-pratyakṣa)
"a later perception agrees with the earlier one – so the earlier was valid"

MĪMĀMSĀ'S SEVEN-STEP CRITICISM

- 1 if action-success is needed before validity is granted, one must act BEFORE being entitled to trust the cognition
- 2 but that action ITSELF presupposes some trust already
- 3 so Nyāya secretly relies on what it officially postpones
- 4 if a later cognition validates the earlier, a further cognition must validate IT
- 5 the regress returns
- 6 therefore later success can at most CONFIRM or DISCLOSE validity, not GENERATE it
- 7 => VALIDITY ITSELF is distinguished from our reflective ASCERTAINMENT of it

+-----+
| THE DECISIVE DISTINCTION |
| if validity and the ascertainment of validity are the SAME thing, Nyāya wins; |
| if they COME APART, Mīmāṃsā wins. Write that sentence and the paragraph writes itself. |
+-----+

NYĀYA'S BEST SHOT – THE DREAM / MIRAGE OBJECTION

- ! dreams and mirages arise spontaneously, FEEL entirely normal, and are FALSE
- ! if normal-looking cognitions can be false, why privilege intrinsic validity?

MĪMĀMSĀ'S REPLY – "APPEARANCE OF NORMALCY IS NOT NORMALCY"

- dream -> extrinsic defect: exhaustion, sleep-state, internal disturbance
- mirage -> extrinsic defect: heated air, optical distortion
- => these do NOT arise from fully normal truth-producing conditions; they are ABNORMAL
- => the principle stands: cognition under GENUINELY normal conditions is valid

DEFAULT TRUST AS THE STRUCTURE OF EMBODIED LIFE

- crossing a road · reading a page · recognising a friend · obeying an instruction
- all presuppose IMMEDIATE trust => the practical inevitability becomes an epistemic principle: DOUBT IS PARASITIC UPON A MORE BASIC TRUST.

DISTINCTIONS THE EXAMINER IS CHECKING

- validity is not certainty · intrinsic validity is not incorrigibility
- extrinsic invalidity does not mean error is impossible
- later confirmation is not the SOURCE of truth but one way of DETECTING correction

! RESIDUAL PRESSURE (state it in a critical answer): Nyāya can press that "abnormal conditions" is a label applied AFTER a cognition turns out false, so the line between warranted default trust and credulity is drawn by stipulation.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/24: The comparative strip - four schools on validity

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/24: The comparative strip – four schools on validity

SCHOOL	VALIDITY	INVALIDITY	RELATION TO MĪMĀṂSĀ
MĪMĀṂSĀ	INTRINSIC	EXTRINSIC	the position itself
NYĀYA	EXTRINSIC (pravṛtti-sāmarthya, saṃvādi-pratyakṣa)	EXTRINSIC	the CHIEF RIVAL on the largest epistemic contrast
SĀṂKHYA	INTRINSIC	INTRINSIC truth AND falsity both disclosed from within	ALLY that goes too far: falsity does NOT self-announce
BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY	EXTRINSIC tied to causal efficacy / success	INTRINSIC falsity reveals itself in failure	the EXACT MIRROR- IMAGE of Mīmāṃsā

(Sāṃkhya and Buddhist placements follow standard survey presentation.)

THE DECISIVE COUNTER TO THE BUDDHIST PLACEMENT

if falsity were INTRINSIC, illusion should reveal itself AS illusion immediately
but illusion DECEIVES precisely because it does not
=> the asymmetry is rejected

WHERE MĪMĀṂSĀ AGREES AND WHERE IT STOPS

with SĀṂKHYA: yes to the intrinsic side of VALIDITY
against SĀṂKHYA: no to intrinsic INVALIDITY – falsity is discovered through later defeat
against NYĀYA: no to extrinsic validity – success confirms, never creates
against BUDDHISM: no to pragmatic validity and to self-intimating falsity

MEMORISE AS A FOUR-ROW STRIP

MĪMĀṂSĀ I / E NYĀYA E / E SĀṂKHYA I / I BUDDHIST E / I

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE
Every classical Indian theory of validity occupies one cell of a two-by-two grid;
Mīmāṃsā's originality is that it is the only school that makes truth free and
falsehood expensive.

! TRAP: Sāṃkhya and Buddhism sit adjacent in every table and are routinely EXCHANGED
under time pressure. Sāṃkhya = intrinsic/intrinsic. Buddhist = extrinsic/intrinsic.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/24: The instrument list and the admission rule

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/24: The instrument list and the admission rule

	pratyakṣa	anumāna	upamāna	śabda	arthāpatti	anupalabdhi	
	perception	inference	compar.	testim.	postulation	non-cognition	
SĀMKHYA	X	X		X			= 3
NYĀYA	X	X	X	X			= 4
PRABHĀKARA	X	X	X	X	X		= 5
BHĀṬṬA	X	X	X	X	X	X	= 6

+---- THE TWO SEATS BY WHICH ----+
MĪMĀṢĀ EXCEEDS NYĀYA

THE ADMISSION RULE (shared by both sub-schools)

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+-----+
| Admit a new instrument ONLY where a type of knowledge cannot be reduced to another |
| WITHOUT REMAINDER or WITHOUT CIRCULARITY. |
+-----+
```

ONE-LINE DEFINITIONS (learn verbatim)

pratyakṣa immediate knowledge produced by sense-object contact
 anumāna mediate knowledge from a sign through known concomitance
 upamāna fresh knowledge that a previously known but ABSENT object is similar
 to a presently perceived object
 śabda valid verbal testimony, especially Vedic testimony regarding dharma
 arthāpatti necessary postulation of an unseen fact to reconcile incompatible facts
 anupalabdhi ... knowledge of absence through non-apprehension of what WOULD be
 apprehended if present

THE EIGHT-STEP JUSTIFICATION

- 1 perception handles directly given objects
- 2 inference handles sign-based mediated knowledge
- 3 testimony handles verbally transmitted content
- 4 comparison handles resemblance-based identification
- 5 yet some cognitions arise NEITHER through signhood NOR positive direct perception
- 6 postulation resolves contradiction-like TENSION among known facts
- 7 absence-cognition, for Bhāṭṭa, discloses what is NOT there under proper conditions
- 8 if these cannot be reduced without circularity, they deserve INDEPENDENT status

THE THREE-TERM VOCABULARY

pramāṇa (the operative MEANS) -> pramā / pramiti (the TRUE COGNITION produced)
 -> pravṛtti-sāmarthyā (successful action: CONFIRMS correspondence, never MANUFACTURES
 validity after the cognition arose)

SUMMARY FORMULA: Bhāṭṭa = six · Prabhākara = five · the difference turns on ANUPALABDHI ·
 the whole list is governed by IRREDUCIBILITY, not by inflation.

- ! TRAP 1: instruments are individuated by the MANNER of generation, not by topic.
 ! TRAP 2: Mīmāṃsā does not oppose anumāna; it opposes REDUCTIONISM ABOUT ANUMĀNA.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/24: Perception - two stages, and the realism it protects

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/24: Perception – two stages, and the realism it protects

NIRVIKALPAKA-PRATYAKṢA ----->	SAVIKALPAKA-PRATYAKṢA
(indeterminate; also ālocana-jñāna)	(determinate)
-----	-----
first NON-VERBAL awareness that an object is PRESENT, before explicit classification and predication	the object grasped AS QUALIFIED by class, quality, action and name: "this is a white moving cow"
THE CONTROLLING CLAIM	
+-----+	
	the determinate stage INTERPRETS what was IMPLICITLY AVAILABLE in the first stage.
	It does NOT invent an unreal predicate.
+-----+	
supports two positions elsewhere in the system:	
(a) REALISM against the Buddhist claim that perception gives only a unique NON-CONCEPTUAL PARTICULAR	
(b) REALISM against any view on which classification NECESSARILY FALSIFIES the given	
(c) and it underwrites Panel 21's defence of REAL UNIVERSALS against apoha	
WHAT BOTH SUB-SCHOOLS SHARE	
perception is accepted · it is immediate · it is realist · it is the most basic disclosure of sensible objects	
WHERE THEY DIVIDE – INSIDE PERCEPTION ITSELF	
PRABHĀKARA	perception is SELF-LUMINOUS as part of tripuṭi-saṃvit: the object, the subject and the cognition are simultaneously revealed
BHĀṬṬA	the OBJECT is perceived, but the COGNITION is not self-luminous; its occurrence is INFERRED from the object's jñātātā
=> the instrument is shared; its REFLEXIVE STRUCTURE is disputed (see Panel 18)	
+-----+	
	ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE
	Mīmāṃsā allows perception two stages precisely so that classification need not
	become falsification: what the second stage says, the first stage already held.
+-----+	
! TRAP: do not treat determinate perception as an overlay imposed on a pure given. That reading concedes the Buddhist premise and destroys the school's semantic realism.	

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/24: Inference and comparison - acceptance, and the Nyāya contrast

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/24: Inference and comparison – acceptance, and the Nyāya contrast

INFERENCE (anumāna) – ACCEPTED IN FULLY STANDARD FORM

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-----+
smoke SEEN + smoke-fire concomitance (vyāpti) KNOWN -> fire INFERRED
the school has NO general hostility to inference
its distinctive move is ONLY to deny that ALL mediate cognition is inferential
+-----+
| Mīmāṃsā opposes REDUCTIONISM ABOUT ANUMĀNA, not anumāna. |
| This is what licenses arthāpatti (Panels 12-13) and anupalabdhi (Panels 14-15). |
+-----+
```

COMPARISON (upamāna) – THE MOST MISREPORTED INSTRUMENT

MĪMĀṂSĀ'S ACCOUNT

- 1 one has PREVIOUSLY SEEN a cow
- 2 one now PERCEIVES a wild ox (gavaya) in the forest as similar to it
- 3 from that perceived similarity arises the NEW cognition:
"the previously seen cow is SIMILAR to this gavaya"
- 4 not PERCEPTION – the absent cow is not presently sensed
- 5 not MEMORY – its similarity to this new animal was not previously known
- 6 not INFERENCE – no universal concomitance is used

NYĀYA'S ACCOUNT (do NOT write this as the Mīmāṃsā definition)
prior TESTIMONY "a gavaya is like a cow" + later perception
=> one learns the WORD-OBJECT RELATION

? Śābara is sometimes read as allowing a WIDER ANALOGICAL FORM, such as reasoning from one's own experienced self to other selves. The later similarity-cognition account is the SAFE EXAM DEFAULT.

```
+-----+
| ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE |
| Mīmāṃsā keeps every instrument its rivals keep and quietly re-tunes each: inference |
| is honoured but forbidden to annex its neighbours, and comparison is redefined around |
| similarity rather than vocabulary. |
+-----+
```

- ! TRAP 1: the gavaya EXAMPLE is shared by both schools; the MECHANISM is not. A candidate who remembers only the example imports the Nyāya account without noticing.
- ! TRAP 2: never write "Mīmāṃsā rejects inference".

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/24: Testimony - two independent classifications

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/24: Testimony – two independent classifications

CLASSIFICATION BY SOURCE

PERSONAL (pauruseya-śabda)	depends on a COMPETENT HUMAN SPEAKER and remains vulnerable to SPEAKER-DEFECT
IMPERSONAL (apauruseya-śabda)	Vedic testimony; INTRINSICALLY VALID in the supersensible domain of duty; NO speaker, hence NO defect-locus

this split is the ENTRY POINT to Panel 22 (authorlessness)

CLASSIFICATION BY FUNCTION

FACT-STATING (siddhārtha-vākya)	states an existent fact
ACTION-ENJOINING (vidhayaka-vākya)	enjoins an action

KUMĀRILA recognises the distinction WHILE MAKING INJUNCTION CENTRAL to Vedic purpose
PRABHĀKARA more radically interprets cognition AND language through action-guidance

this split is the ENTRY POINT to Panel 23 (injunction theory)

WHY TESTIMONY IS DIGNIFIED HERE

in ordinary matters it depends on a competent source
in matters of DUTY the decisive verbal source is the VEDA

It is NOT a fallback after perception fails.
It is the ONLY ROUTE to supersensible duty.

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE

Mīmāṃsā promotes testimony from a convenience to the sole competent witness, and then removes the one thing that could discredit a witness – the witness himself.

! TRAP 1: "impersonal" does NOT mean "divine". Divine authorship is the NYĀYA route.
! TRAP 2: the source-split and the function-split are TWO INDEPENDENT CUTS across testimony; do not merge them into one classification.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/24: Memory excluded - the novelty condition

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/24: Memory excluded – the novelty condition

WHAT A MEANS OF VALID KNOWLEDGE MUST DO

(a) operate as the SOURCE of a cognition
(b) disclose an OBJECT
(c) do so FRESHLY – NOVELTY (anadhigatatva), i.e. not-already-ascertained

MEMORY (smṛti) TESTED AGAINST (a) (b) (c)

(a) YES it operates (b) YES it has an object (c) NO – IT FAILS HERE
it depends on an EARLIER
cognition + a latent
impression (saṃskāra) and
RE-PRESENTS known content

=> MEMORY IS NOT A PRAMĀṆA (both sub-schools; Nyāya agrees)

PRABHĀKARA'S FIVE STEPS

NYĀYA'S CONCURRENCE

1 a pramāṇa must generate a NEW cognition	memory presents what was ALREADY known
2 memory depends on an earlier cognition and a latent impression	it is RE-PRESENTATION, not fresh disclosure
3 it reproduces OLD content	hence it is not a pramāṇa
4 it does not reveal a new object as presently known	=> THIS IS WHY THE 2024 PAPER PAIRS "the Prābhākaras AND the Naiyāyikas"
5 therefore it is NOT a pramāṇa	IN ONE QUESTION

WHAT THE EXCLUSION DOES *NOT* SAY

memory may be TRUE · may be USEFUL · may GUIDE ACTION successfully
but USEFULNESS IS NOT ENOUGH for the title; NOVEL VALID DISCLOSURE is required
example: seeing a temple NOW is perception; recalling yesterday's visit is memory,
and the latter is not new knowledge OF THE TEMPLE

WHERE MEMORY STILL DOES REAL WORK

comparison (upamāna) uses a REMEMBERED cow
Prabhākara's error-theory (akhyāti) uses a REMEMBERED silver
Bhāṭṭa sentence-comprehension uses MEMORY OF THE ORDERED SERIES of phonemes
=> memory is a working COMPONENT of cognitive life; it is simply not an INSTRUMENT

! TRAP 1: "memory is unreliable" is the WRONG reason and concedes ground to the sceptic.
! TRAP 2: over-correcting by writing memory out of the system altogether.
! RESIDUAL: because the exclusion is DEFINITIONAL, a rival may contest the definition.
Reply: the definition tracks a real difference between DISCLOSING and RETRIEVING.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/24: Postulation - structure, the canonical case, two forms

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/24: Postulation – structure, the canonical case, two forms

THE BARE STRUCTURE

Fact A is known
Fact B is known
A and B CANNOT stand together
 unless C is admitted
therefore C is POSTULATED
NECESSITY = explanatory reconciliation

THE CANONICAL CASE – STOUT DEVADATTA

1 Devadatta is stout (perception)
2 he does not eat by day (testimony /
 repeated observation)
3 stoutness is INCOMPATIBLE with total absence
 of nourishment
4 => the two known facts produce EXPLANATORY
 TENSION
5 to resolve it, he must eat at ANOTHER time
6 the natural and sufficient postulate: AT NIGHT
7 night-eating is NOT directly perceived here
8 it is NOT supplied by memory either
9 it is POSTULATED, because otherwise the known
 data remain INEXPLICABLE

PRESUPPOSITIONS

bodily conditions have intelligible causes · stoutness normally requires nourishment
rational cognition SEEKS COHERENCE among accepted facts

THE DISTINCTION INSIDE THE CASE

the reasoning does NOT begin from a sign like smoke; it begins from TENSION BETWEEN
FACTS – and the output is not merely "he eats" but the MINIMALLY RECONCILING POSTULATE.
("Minimally" is what stops postulation licensing extravagant explanations.)

TWO FORMS

dr̥ṣṭārthāpatti (from PERCEIVED facts) – the Devadatta case above
śrutarthāpatti (from HEARD WORDS) – supplies what an utterance needs to be
 coherent: ellipsis, contextual completion
both are EXPLANATORY NECESSITY, not tentative hypothesis; only the source of the
initiating tension differs

EXAMPLE BANK

stout Devadatta, no day-eating -> eats at night (use FIRST, always)
candidate never seen studying by day, tops the exam -> studies at another time
person never seen leaving home yet present at office daily -> leaves unobserved
! canonical example first; modern examples only to illustrate

OBJECTION -> REPLY

! why not simply suspend judgement? -> the facts as accepted PRESS toward
 reconciliation; postulation is the cognition produced by that necessity
! any explanation could be relabelled postulation -> only postulations NECESSARY to
 resolve an ESTABLISHED incompatibility qualify

! TRAP: retelling the case with an added premise such as "whoever is fat eats" silently
concedes the Nyāya reduction the answer was supposed to refute.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 13/24: Postulation - three anti-reduction arguments and circularity

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 13/24: Postulation – three anti-reduction arguments and circularity

WHY ARTHĀPATTI IS NOT ANUMĀNA – three INDEPENDENT arguments

=====

(1) NO INDEPENDENTLY ESTABLISHED CONCOMITANCE

inference requires vyāpti KNOWN BEFOREHAND, relating hetu to sādhyā
we possess NO prior universal rule "all stout non-day-eaters eat at night"
the cognition arises because the facts would OTHERWISE CONFLICT
=> the engine is NOT vyāpti

(2) THE DIRECTION OF REASONING DIFFERS

INFERENCE : observed SIGN -----> unobserved SIGNIFIED
"this sign INDICATES that fact"
POSTULATION : explanatory TENSION -----> reconciling POSTULATE
"WITHOUT that postulate, THESE facts are inexplicable"

(3) NO SUBJECT / REASON / PROBANDUM STRUCTURE

standard inference parses into pakṣa (subject) · hetu (reason) · sādhyā (probandum)
postulation lacks that form entirely: no identified hetu sitting in a pakṣa
what there IS: a CLASH of accepted facts and a DEMANDED supplementation

=====

THE NYĀYA REDUCTION AND THE CIRCULARITY REPLY

NYĀYA : hetu = fatness · sādhyā = eating · vyāpti = "whoever is fat eats"
MĪMĀṂSĀ : that vyāpti is NOT INDEPENDENTLY KNOWN.
If you claim it IS known, it was learned FROM LIVED CASES by exactly the
tension-driven move under dispute.

+-----+
| THE REDUCTION USES AS ITS PREMISE WHAT POSTULATION ALONE SUPPLIES. |
| IT IS THEREFORE CIRCULAR. |
+-----+

THE 2024 APPLIED CASE – worked in the Bhāṭṭa manner

- 1 the candidate TOPS the examination
 - 2 the candidate is NEVER SEEN studying by day
 - 3 examination success is incompatible with NO preparation at all
 - 4 therefore some UNOBSERVED preparation must be posited
 - 5 natural postulate: study at night or otherwise outside observed daytime
- NYĀYA FRAMING: "wherever there is success there is preparation; this candidate has
success; therefore he had preparation" – misses the explanatory TENSION and slides in
a vyāpti far too quickly

POSTULATION AND MODERN EXPLANATORY REASONING

it RESEMBLES inference to the best explanation, but the classical claim is STRONGER:
not "best among options" but "the postulate WITHOUT WHICH the known facts remain
untenable". That NECESSITY is why it earns instrument-status.

DISTINCTIONS TO WRITE OUT

arthāpatti is NOT a guess · NOT a probabilistic hunch · NOT standard anumāna
arthāpatti IS explanatory postulation compelled by unresolved incompatibility

WHERE IT REAPPEARS IN THE SYSTEM

it ESTABLISHES apūrva (Panel 23) and supplies the FORM of the authorlessness
argument (Panel 22) => postulation is load-bearing, not ornamental

! TRAP 1: giving only ONE of the three arguments.

! TRAP 2: omitting the circularity reply, which is the move that actually defeats Nyāya.

! TRAP 3: writing that Prabhākara rejects postulation. It is his FIFTH instrument.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 14/24: Non-cognition - seven steps and the fitness filter

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 14/24: Non-cognition – seven steps and the fitness filter

DEFINITION: the independent means of knowing ABSENCE through NON-APPREHENSION of what WOULD be apprehended if present. Characteristic of BHĀṬṬA Mīmāṃsā.

KUMĀRILA'S SEVEN-STEP ARGUMENT

- 1 we DO know absences: "there is no pot on the table"
- 2 this cognition is DEFINITE and ACTION-GUIDING
- 3 not ordinary PERCEPTION – perception gives POSITIVE content
- 4 not INFERENCE – inference requires a POSITIVE SIGN
- 5 not memory, comparison or testimony in the typical case
- 6 therefore an INDEPENDENT source is needed
- 7 that source is ANUPALABDHI

THE FITNESS FILTER (yogyatā) – ALL FOUR must hold => yogyānupalabdhi

- * the absent object must be the KIND of thing perceivable if present
- * the LOCUS must be suitable
- * the SENSE ORGAN must be functioning
- * LIGHT, DISTANCE and ATTENTION must be proper

PASSES -> knowledge of absence FAILS -> mere non-noticing, no knowledge
YES "no pot on this bare, lit table before me"
NO "there are no atoms here" (atoms are not perceptible => filter fails)
NO keys unseen on a cluttered desk in poor light after a hurried glance
NO a sound unheard while attention is absorbed elsewhere

WHY BHĀṬṬA DENIES REDUCTION TO PERCEPTION

perception reveals what is POSITIVELY PRESENT: table, colour, shape, spatial spread
"absence of pot" is NOT a positive sensible datum of that kind
perceiving the EMPTY TABLE is one thing; cognising that THE POT IS ABSENT is another

WHY BHĀṬṬA DENIES REDUCTION TO INFERENCE

inference requires a positive sign and known concomitance
in absence-cognition NO independent positive sign is typically identified
if "not-seeing the pot" is offered as the sign, one must explain WHY not-seeing has
evidentiary force – and that force ALREADY presupposes the relevance of
non-apprehension under FIT conditions
=> the inferential reduction is either STRAINED or CIRCULAR

ORDINARY-LIFE VINDICATION

no chalk on the tray · no key in the drawer · no bus at the stop
philosophy must explain what everyday life constantly presupposes

ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE

Kumārila's claim is not that something can be learned from failing to see, but that
it can be learned only when failing to see is GUARANTEED to be informative – and the
doctrine is the specification of when that guarantee holds.

! TRAP 1: attributing anupalabdhi to Mīmāṃsā generally. It is BHĀṬṬA's.

! TRAP 2: describing it as "not noticing". It is a DETERMINATE VERDICT of absence.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 15/24: Absence - ontology and the three-way dispute

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 15/24: Absence – ontology and the three-way dispute

THE ONTOLOGICAL STATUS OF ABHĀVA (the 2021 core)

+-----+		
	BHĀṬṬA: abhāva is REAL. It is NOT merely a feature of language.	
	It has a COUNTERPOSITIVE (pratiyogin) – the entity whose absence is involved.	
	"absence of pot" is therefore a STRUCTURED ONTOLOGICAL CONTENT.	
	=> negative cognition has a REAL OBJECT.	
+-----+		

THE THREE-WAY DISPUTE

+-----+		
SCHOOL	WHAT IS KNOWN	IS A SEPARATE INSTRUMENT NEEDED?
+-----+		
BHĀṬṬA	a REAL absence, structured by its counterpositive	YES – anupalabdhi
+-----+		
PRABHĀKARA	the LOCUS as UNQUALIFIED by the absent object; we perceive the table as BARE	NO – the bare-locus cognition ALREADY carries the negative differentiation needed
+-----+		
NYĀYA	ABSENCE ITSELF, DIRECTLY PERCEIVED; abhāva is accepted as a real category	NO – "pot-absence-on-the-floor" is itself a perceptual object
+-----+		

=> NYĀYA AND PRABHĀKARA CONVERGE AGAINST BHĀṬṬA ON INDEPENDENCE, for DIFFERENT reasons
! do NOT therefore say "Nyāya denies abhāva". Nyāya denies the separate INSTRUMENT.

THE INTRA-MĪMĀṢĀ DEBATE (the 2025 core)

BHĀṬṬA : abhāva is real AND known by an independent instrument
PRABHĀKARA : what is known is simply the locus as unqualified; no instrument needed
! answer the 2025 question as an INTERNAL dispute, not as Mīmāṃsā versus Nyāya
KUMĀRILA'S COUNTER: economy purchased by flattening a determinate NEGATIVE judgement
into a POSITIVE perception is FALSE ECONOMY

OBJECTION -> REPLY

! if absence is real, reality becomes overcrowded with negatives
-> Bhāṭṭa ACCEPTS this ontological cost to preserve the reality of negative cognition
! non-perception is too subjective
-> only YOGYĀNUPALABDHI under fit conditions counts, never careless overlooking

GRADED VERDICT

Kumārila preserves the PHENOMENOLOGY of negative cognition most faithfully while
carrying the HEAVIEST ONTOLOGY – a cost he expressly accepts.
Prabhākara is the more ECONOMICAL metaphysician; Nyāya is the most PERCEPTUALLY direct.

! TRAP: in a question about ONTOLOGICAL STATUS, forgetting the pratiyogin.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 16/24: Error - the four theories, stated precisely

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 16/24: Error – the four theories, stated precisely

THE SHARED DATUM: a shell (nacre) lies before the subject, who says "this is silver" and reaches for it.

THEORY	SCHOOL	HOW SHELL-SILVER IS EXPLAINED	THE "SILVER" IS
akhyāti / vivekākhyāti (non-apprehension of DIFFERENCE)	PRABHĀKARA	TWO VALID cognitions whose DIFFERENCE is not apprehended: perception of "this shining thing" + memory of silver	NO false silver at all
viparīta-khyāti (contrary apprehension)	BHĀṬṬA	the shell is POSITIVELY MISCOGNISED AS silver; ONE erroneous cognition	a really WRONG IDENTIFICATION
anyathā-khyāti (otherwise- apprehension)	NYĀYA	REAL silver known ELSEWHERE is presented HERE, wrongly	real, but DISPLACED
anirvacanīya-khyāti (indescribable- apprehension)	ADVAITA	an INDESCRIBABLE appearance is projected and later sublated	NEITHER real NOR unreal

^ ^
+--- these two BOTH admit a false cognition and are CONSTANTLY CONFLATED ---+
BHĀṬṬA: the object HERE is MISIDENTIFIED
NYĀYA : an object KNOWN ELSEWHERE is MISPLACED
=> "wrong identification" is NOT "right object, wrong location"

PRABHĀKARA'S FIVE STEPS	BHĀṬṬA'S SEVEN STEPS
1 valid perception of "this shining object here"	1 the shell is before the subject
2 that perception is of the shell's present appearance	2 bad light, distance, similar shine or sensory defect causes miscognition
3 valid MEMORY of silver	3 a SINGLE erroneous cognition arises: "this is silver"
4 failure to DISTINGUISH the two	4 the cognition is FALSE
5 behaviour follows; NO separate false cognition need be posited	5 its falsity is due to EXTRINSIC DEFECT, not to cognition's intrinsic nature
	6 correction on approaching and seeing clearly
	7 invalidity is then known EXTRINSICALLY

MĪMĀṂSĀ VERSUS THE OTHER TWO

Mīmāṃsā stays more EPISTEMOLOGICALLY ANCHORED and REALIST: it neither disperses the object elsewhere like Nyāya nor renders it metaphysically indeterminate like Advaita.

- ! TRAP 1: translating akhyāti as "TOTAL non-apprehension". It is non-apprehension OF DIFFERENCE – which is why vivekākhyāti is the more precise label.
- ! TRAP 2: merging viparīta-khyāti with anyathā-khyāti.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 17/24: Error - two defences of one shared thesis

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 17/24: Error – two defences of one shared thesis

THE 2022 PUZZLE, STATED

"IN SPITE OF accepting the intrinsic validity of knowledge, why and how do Prabhākara and Kumārila differ in their interpretation of erroneous cognition?"
=> the "in spite of" clause IS the question.

WHY ERROR IS THE SYSTEM'S STRESS-TEST

any theory of intrinsic validity MUST explain illusion
if cognition is prima facie valid, what exactly GOES WRONG in false experience?
=> the theories of error are not an appendix to the epistemology; they are its proof

THE TWO DEFENCE STRATEGIES

+-----+-----+	
PRABHĀKARA PROTECTS	BHĀṬṬA PROTECTS
*** EVERY CONSTITUENT COGNITION ***	*** THE PRINCIPLE GOVERNING NORMAL
	COGNITION ***
+-----+-----+	
the presentational cognition of	falsity IS admitted, but it is QUARANTINED
"this" is valid	in DEFECT-RIDDEN conditions
the memory of silver is valid	validity belongs to cognition under NORMAL
error lies ONLY in their conflation	conditions; falsity belongs to defect
=> NO individual cognition is ever	=> invalidity is known EXTRINSICALLY, through
labelled false	later defeat
+-----+-----+	

THE COSTS ARE EXACTLY COMPLEMENTARY

PRABHĀKARA must explain the ASSERTIVE FORCE of "this is silver" by a mere failure of discrimination
! objection: this UNDERESTIMATES the assertive force of illusion
-> reply: non-discrimination can explain assertive behaviour without adding a false cognition
BHĀṬṬA must admit a FALSE COGNITION into a system built on default truth
! objection: this GRANTS TOO MUCH to falsity
-> reply: it grants falsehood ONLY under abnormal conditions, preserving the default truth of cognition

THE BEHAVIOURAL FACT THAT DIVIDES THEM

reaching for the silver must be explained
BHĀṬṬA: best explained by a POSITIVE FALSE JUDGEMENT
PRABHĀKARA: NON-DISCRIMINATION suffices
=> the debate concerns PHILOSOPHICAL PSYCHOLOGY as much as epistemology

SHARED PRESUPPOSITIONS

error must be explainable WITHOUT collapsing trust in cognition
memory and perception CAN interact
defect and correction are intelligible features of cognitive life

+-----+-----+	
ANSWER-GRABBING SPINE	
Prabhākara saves intrinsic validity by refusing to admit a false cognition anywhere,	
and Kumārila saves it by admitting one and then quarantining it. The disagreement is	
about what price is worth paying to keep the same trust intact.	
+-----+-----+	

! TRAP: concluding that Bhāṭṭa ABANDONS intrinsic validity because he admits falsity.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 18/24: How cognition is known - three answers to one regress

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 18/24: How cognition is known – three answers to one regress

THE PROBLEM

if a cognition is NOT manifest in itself, another cognition must reveal it
... and THAT one needs a third ... and so on => INFINITE REGRESS (anavasthā)
ALL THREE CLASSICAL ANSWERS ARE DEVICES FOR STOPPING THIS REGRESS.

```
+--- PRABHĀKARA -----+
| ONE ACT, THREE DISCLOSURES      jñātr (kower) --+
| cognition is SELF-LUMINOUS      jñeya (known) --+-- revealed TOGETHER, at once
| (svaprakāśa)                   jñāna (knowing)--+
| SIX STEPS: 1 cognition illuminates its object · 2 if it were not itself manifest,
| another cognition would be needed · 3 that needs a third => regress · 4 therefore
| cognition reveals ITSELF in the act of revealing the object · 5 the subject is also
| disclosed as the one who knows · 6 hence a THREEFOLD revelation
| LAMP ANALOGY: a lamp reveals itself and other things at once => economy + no regress
| ! reflection ("I know that I know") is a LATER conceptual articulation of what was
| already manifest PRE-REFLECTIVELY
| ! objection: this confuses subject, object and cognition
|   -> reply: they are simultaneously DISCLOSED, not ontologically COLLAPSED
| => NO METACOGNITIVE GAP
+-----+
+--- BHĀṬṬA -----+
| cognition is NOT self-luminous
| FOUR STEPS: 1 an object, once cognised, stands in a NEW RELATION: it is now KNOWN
| 2 that new status is JÑĀTATĀ (knownness) · 3 observing the object's knownness, we
| INFER that a cognition has occurred · 4 therefore awareness of cognition is
| INFERENTIAL, not immediate
| PAINTER ANALOGY: it paints objects but does not paint ITSELF; its occurrence is
| established through what it LEAVES BEHIND in the object
| ! objection: jñātātā is a mysterious property -> reply: the cost is accepted in order
| to avoid the stronger thesis of self-luminosity
| ! objection: self-awareness feels too immediate for inference -> reply: felt immediacy
| need not equal non-inferential STRUCTURE
| => TEMPORAL AND LOGICAL GAP: "I know" first, "I know that I know" afterwards
+-----+
+--- NYĀYA -----+
| FOUR STEPS: 1 first-order cognition reveals the object · 2 a LATER inner awareness
| takes that cognition as its OBJECT · 3 it has the form "I know the pot" / "I knew the
| pot" · 4 therefore knowing-that-I-know is NEITHER self-luminosity NOR inference from
| knownness, but SECOND-ORDER APPREHENSION = ANUVYAVASĀYA
| ! objection: second-order awareness threatens regress -> reply: Nyāya treats the
| higher-order awareness as SUFFICIENT without endless repetition
| => REFLECTIVE GAP
+-----+
```

THREE GAPS, IN THREE WORDS: NONE · INFERENTIAL · REFLECTIVE

! TRAP: swapping the mechanisms. tripuṭi-saṃvit = PRABHĀKARA · jñātātā = BHĀṬṬA ·
anuvyavasāya = NYĀYA.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 19/24: Self-luminosity and intrinsic validity - the entailment grid

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 19/24: Self-luminosity and intrinsic validity – the entailment grid

TWO INDEPENDENT QUESTIONS

Q1 MANIFESTATION : is cognition / consciousness SELF-LUMINOUS?

Q2 TRUTH-ENTITLEMENT : is VALIDITY INTRINSIC?

they answer DIFFERENT questions, so NO entailment follows from the definitions alone

SCHOOL	Q1 SELF-LUMINOUS?	Q2 VALIDITY INTRINSIC?	CONSEQUENCE
NYĀYA	NO – known through a subsequent anuvyavasāya	NO – ascertained extrinsically	accepts NEITHER thesis
PRABHĀKARA MĪMĀṢĀ	YES – one cognition manifests knower, known and knowing	YES	CONNECTS both theses
BHĀṬṬA MĪMĀṢĀ	NO – cognition inferred from acquired jñātātā	YES	*** DECISIVE COUNTEREXAMPLE TO ENTAILMENT
ADVAITA VEDĀNTA	YES – fundamentally of CONSCIOUSNESS ITSELF, not merely of episodes	at the EMPIRICAL level, prima facie until SUBLATED	CONNECTS them within a wider NON-DUAL theory

THE ARGUMENT IN ONE LINE

Kumārila = NOT self-luminous + intrinsically valid => self-luminosity is NOT NECESSARY for intrinsic validity => and since the theses answer different questions, NEITHER ENTAILS THE OTHER a SINGLE actual case refutes a claim of NECESSITY; the survey of the other schools shows that the pairing in Prabhākara and Advaita is a SUBSTANTIVE COMMITMENT, not a definitional consequence

WHY KUMĀRILA'S COMBINATION IS STABLE

manifestation is handled by jñātātā and inference · truth-entitlement is handled by the anti-regress argument => different machinery, so the two need not move together

QUALIFICATION FOR A HIGH-MARK ANSWER

independence is NOT irrelevance: a self-luminous cognition plainly makes intrinsic validity EASIER to defend – it simply does not COMPEL it

! TRAP 1: placing Nyāya as "self-luminous but extrinsically valid". Nyāya DENIES self-luminosity. Getting this cell wrong destroys the whole grid.

! TRAP 2: treating "the Mīmāṃsakas" as ONE column. The question is decided INSIDE Mīmāṃsā.

! TRAP 3: surveying the schools and never answering the word "NECESSARILY".

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 20/24: Sentence-unity - shared conditions and the purport problem

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 20/24: Sentence-unity – shared conditions and the purport problem

THE PROBLEM: EKAVĀKYATĀ – how does a sentence made of MANY words, each apparently carrying its own meaning, yield ONE unified cognition?

Mīmāṃsā MUST solve this: Vedic obligation is grasped through SENTENCE-meaning, never through isolated word-meanings.

WHY THE PROBLEM IS NOT ARTIFICIAL

- 1 the Veda works through meaningful sentences: injunctions, prohibitions, mantras, names, explanatory passages
 - 2 an injunction cannot guide action unless its words form ONE determinate action-guiding meaning
 - 3 mere SUCCESSION does not produce unity – unrelated words can be uttered side by side
 - 4 therefore the conditions of sentencehood must be specified
- ! objection: ordinary people understand sentences instantly; why a technical theory?
 -> reply: Mīmāṃsā explains the LOGICAL STRUCTURE of comprehension, not the hearer's conscious procedure

THE THREE SHARED CONDITIONS (accepted by BOTH sub-schools)

CONDITION	MEANING	FAILURE CASE	FUNCTION
ākāṅkṣā (expectancy)	words mutually REQUIRE completion	"Bring..." leaves an open expectation of WHAT	why words lean
yogyatā (semantic fitness)	meanings must be semantically COMPATIBLE	"sprinkle with fire" is unfit in ordinary usage	blocks absurdity
sannidhi / āsatti (contiguity)	words must occur in proper PROXIMITY	words separated by unrelated discourse	protects Vedic boundaries

THE CONTESTED FOURTH – AND MĪMĀṂSĀ'S REAL DIFFICULTY

TĀTPARYA (purport / intended thrust) is added by NAIYĀYIKAS

! but the Veda is APAURUSEYA – there is NO speaker whose intention could be consulted

-> Mīmāṃsā must relocate purport into TEXTUAL FORCE, CONTEXTUAL UNITY and SUBORDINATION TO VIDHI

! objection: if purport is needed for human sentences, an authorless Veda becomes unintelligible

-> reply: Vedic purport is not psychological intention but SENTENCE-FUNCTION disclosed by textual relations

=> this creates GENUINE INTERNAL PRESSURE and a strong answer says so

TEST SENTENCE FOR EVERYTHING THAT FOLLOWS

"svargakāmo yajeta" – "one desiring heaven should sacrifice"

the hearer must grasp not "heaven-desirer" + "sacrifice" but the UNIFIED INJUNCTION that the QUALIFIED AGENT ought to perform sacrifice

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 21/24: The two semantics, universals, exclusion and the sound-burst

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 21/24: The two semantics, universals, exclusion and the sound-burst

BHĀṬṬA – abhihitānvayavāda "connection of the ALREADY DENOTED"	PRABHĀKARA – anvitābhīdhānavāda "denotation of the CONNECTED"
step 1 each word denotes its ISOLATED meaning (padārtha) via ABHIDHĀ	there is NO such first step
step 2 meanings are CONNECTED via LAKṢAṆĀ / TĀTPARYA-ŚAKTI	words denote meanings ONLY AS CONNECTED with agent, action, object and context
PRIMARY UNIT = THE WORD sentence-meaning is DERIVATIVE	PRIMARY UNIT = THE SENTENCE word-meaning is grasped IN RELATION
STRENGTH: explains STABLE LEXICAL MEANING across contexts; meaning is COMPOSITIONAL	STRENGTH: explains LANGUAGE-LEARNING and ACTION-GUIDANCE; meaning is CONTEXTUAL
! the two stages are LOGICAL, not a slow temporal sequence in consciousness	! does NOT deny that words are repeatable; denies that their PRIMARY life is isolated
PRABHĀKARA'S EVIDENCE – THE LEARNING ARGUMENT (vyutpatti): a child observes an elder command "bring the cow" and a younger person comply, and learns the CONNECTED sense from the whole event. Dictionaries are SECONDARY ABSTRACTIONS from repeated connected uses.	
FOUR CROSS-OBJECTIONS	
! vs BHĀṬṬA: the isolated-word stage is never observed and requires an extra lakṣaṇā or purport-operation in every sentence -> reply: the distinction is EXPLANATORY, not INTROSPECTIVE; stable lexical meaning requires word-priority	
! vs PRABHĀKARA: the same word would mean differently in every sentence -> reply: recurrent connected uses yield stable competence without context-free meanings	
! vs BHĀṬṬA: language-learning begins in SENTENCES -> reply: learning-history does not settle SEMANTIC STRUCTURE	
! vs PRABHĀKARA: single-word commands "Cow!" "Fire!" seem meaningful -> reply: these are ELLIPTICAL SENTENCES supplied by context	
VERDICT: Bhāṭṭa secures STABLE LEXICAL MEANING; Prabhākara secures CONTEXTUAL ACTION-GUIDANCE.	
=====	
UNIVERSALS OR PARTICULARS? (both schools reach BOTH; the dispute is PRIORITY)	
MĪMĀṂSĀ : the UNIVERSAL (jāti) is primary; the individual is reached THROUGH it as instantiated in a concrete context. ARGUMENT: repeatability of "cow" requires a STABLE SEMANTIC GROUND across changing individuals.	
NYĀYA : the INDIVIDUAL (vyakti) as QUALIFIED by universal and form is primary ! a universal cannot be milked, brought or sacrificed -> reply: the universal is primary FOR MEANING; ACTION reaches the qualified individual by contextual application	
! BUDDHIST APOHA: "cow" works by EXCLUDING non-cows; no real universal is needed -> reply: pure exclusion cannot explain STABLE POSITIVE RECOGNITION and REPEATABLE APPLICATION unless a shared class-character is already available	
=====	
GRAMMARIAN SPHOṬA-VĀDA (Bhartṛhari) – AND ITS REJECTION	
individual sounds PERISH and cannot by themselves yield the whole meaning, so a unitary VĀKYA-SPHOṬA is posited as the real bearer of meaning	
-> MĪMĀṂSĀ (BOTH sub-schools) REJECTS the extra entity: eternal PHONEMES (varṇa) and their ORDERED MANIFESTATION suffice; MEMORY of the ordered series + ākāṅkṣā + yogyatā + sannidhi already yields unity	
=> preserves ECONOMY and the theory of ETERNAL WORD-UNITS without Grammarian holism (and this is what Panel 22 needs)	
! TRAP: A-BHI-hita goes with BHA-tta. Never hand connected-denotation to Kumārila.	

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 22/24: Authorlessness - argument, circularity charge, six replies

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THE EIGHT-STEP ARGUMENT FOR APAURUṢEYATVA

- 1 NO AUTHOR of the Veda is REMEMBERED in the tradition
- 2 an author of so momentous a text would NORMALLY have been remembered
- 3 the word-meaning relation is NATURAL (autpattika), not instituted by a person
- 4 word-units (varṇa) possess ŚABDA-NITYATVA => utterance MANIFESTS, never PRODUCES
- 5 transmission is maintained by disciplined recitation; NO event of composition located
- 6 therefore the Veda need not be treated as a composed book with a fallible author
- 7 authorial DEFECTS explain unreliability in human testimony
- 8 therefore an AUTHORLESS Veda is free of that class of defect => SELF-VALID FOR DHARMA

THE FOUR-DEFECT ARGUMENT

AGAINST NYĀYA'S GOD-GUARANTEE

a personal author MAY ERR	first PROVE God exists
MAY DECEIVE	then PROVE God is omniscient
MAY LACK COMPLETE KNOWLEDGE	then PROVE God intends truth
=> authority would depend on PROVING competence and sincerity	each stage needs INDEPENDENT support => cumbersome; authorlessness avoids it entirely

WHAT APAURUṢEYATVA DOES *NOT* CLAIM

it does NOT deny that anyone recited, taught or arranged Vedic branches
transmission and recension are NOT original authorship
KATĪHA, KAUSĪTAKI etc. can mark SCHOOLS, TRANSMITTERS or BRANCHES, not composers
example: a teacher who recites a mantra is a TRANSMITTER, not its author

THE CIRCULARITY CHARGE, IN TWO FORMS

- ! FORM 1: the Veda is authoritative because authorless – but authorlessness seems accepted BECAUSE THE TRADITION SAYS SO
- ! FORM 2 (sharper): intrinsic validity PROVES TOO MUCH – rival scriptures would become self-valid too, unless an external criterion is smuggled in

SIX REPLIES

- R1 authorlessness rests on ORDINARY REASONING + absence of a remembered author, NOT on a Vedic quotation
- R2 the reasoning has an ARTHĀPATTI FORM: extraordinary authority + no remembered authorial event => authorless transmission is the REQUIRED postulate
- R3 intrinsic validity is NOT indefeasibility; invalidity is known through doṣa or bādhaka
- R4 rival scriptures WITH known or claimed human authors possess a LOCUS OF DEFECT; an authorless Veda lacks that locus
- R5 the Veda is authoritative ONLY FOR DHARMA, where no rival instrument operates and no defeater can arise; it does not compete with perception on colour
- R6 the DIVINE-AUTHOR alternative is WORSE: a person, even a divine person, becomes a further object needing proof

RESIDUAL FORCE – state this in a critical answer

- ! weight rests on "no remembered author" and on the NATURALNESS of word-meaning
- ! JAYANTA and UDAYANA deny naturalness: the relation is SAṆKETA (convention), grounded in Īśvara's institution, and the Veda is the testimony of an ĀPTA
 - > reply: conventionalism needs an INSTITUTOR whose reliability must first be proved
- ! DHARMAKĪRTI-line Buddhists reject eternal words: how can an eternal, changeless word produce a cognition AT A PARTICULAR TIME?
 - > reply: the eternal word is MANIFESTED by utterance under auditory conditions, so the timed cognition depends on MANIFESTATION and HEARER-CONDITIONS
- ! Buddhist: intrinsic validity would license sectarian texts
 - > reply: intrinsic validity is DEFEASIBLE; a text with an author, contradiction or detectable defect CAN be defeated

! TRAP: writing that the Veda is "God-given" or "revealed by God". The single most damaging error available on this topic.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 23/24: Injunction, impelling force, obligation, unseen potency, no God

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THREE CLASSIFICATIONS THAT MUST NOT BE CONFLATED

(i) FIVE SENTENCE-FUNCTIONS

vidhi injunction enjoins a duty or rite not otherwise known [PRIMARY]
niṣedha prohibition forbids an act; negative determination of duty
mantra mantra recalls deity, material, ritual detail in performance
nāmadheya name names a rite, substance or component
arthavāda praise / explanation praises, condemns, narrates in support of a vidhi
! mantra, name and arthavāda are NOT meaningless: their Vedic function is secured by
 EKAVĀKYATĀ with an operative injunction

(ii) THREE LOGICAL KINDS OF INJUNCTION

apūrva-vidhi (novel) · niyama-vidhi (restrictive) · parisamkhyā-vidhi (exclusionary)

(iii) SEPARATE RITUAL-COORDINATION GRID

utpatti (the act) · viniyoga (subsidiary application) · prayoga (performance-order)
· adhikāra (qualified agent)

BHĀṬṬA – THE DOUBLE FORCE, on "svargakāmo yajeta"

ŚĀBDĪ BHĀVANĀ locus = the Vedic sentence

word-force IMPELS the hearer => PRAVṚTTI (impulse to act)

aṃśa-traya: kim? the agent's pravṛtti (sādhya/bhāvya) · kena? the

injunctive suffix and knowledge of it (karaṇa/sādhana) · katham?

arthavāda and eulogistic supports (itikartavyatā)

ĀRTHĪ BHĀVANĀ locus = the agent's own effort and ritual performance

the ACT brings about the result => PHALA (svarga), mediated by apūrva

aṃśa-traya: kim? SVARGA (sādhya/bhāvya) · kena? YĀGA, sacrifice

(karaṇa/sādhana) · katham? procedure, materials, sequence and

subsidiary acts (itikartavyatā)

=> WORD-FORCE PRODUCES UNDERTAKING; ACTION-FORCE PRODUCES FRUIT

! objection: the doubling is artificial -> reply: linguistic IMPELLING and real
 PRODUCTION are not the same function

PRABHĀKARA – THE SINGLE BINDING

the sentence directly presents an act as TO-BE-DONE (karya) => OBLIGATION (niyoga)

bindingness does NOT wait upon attraction toward svarga

PRABHĀKARA = NIYOGA-VĀDA (duty for duty's sake) · BHĀṬṬA = BHĀVANĀ-VĀDA (fruit-mediated)

! objection: if the fruit does not motivate, why act? -> reply: the cognition of the
 act AS ENJOINED is itself action-guiding for the qualified agent

! Kant comparison ONLY with the disanalogy: niyoga is HETERONOMOUS, grounded in an
 impersonal eternal Veda, and addressed to the ritually qualified ADHIKĀRIN

HOW A SENTENCE COMMANDS WITH NO COMMANDER

imperative force is carried by the LIṆ / VIDHI verbal form itself, whose relation to
its meaning is AUTPATTIKA => obligation is IMPERSONAL and STRUCTURAL

APŪRVA – THE BRIDGE, ARGUED NOT ASSERTED

1 a ritual act is TEMPORALLY LIMITED

2 its promised fruit may be TEMPORALLY REMOTE and not visibly produced

3 if the act simply PERISHED WITHOUT REMAINDER, the Vedic connection is unintelligible

4 therefore apūrva is posited as the UNSEEN LINK

5 and this postulation is defended through ARTHĀPATTI (Panels 12-13)

=> THE FLAMES DO NOT TRAVEL TO HEAVEN; THE POTENCY PERSISTS UNTIL THE FRUIT MATURES

! objection: apūrva is unverifiable and ad hoc -> reply: it is established by
 explanatory necessity, not asserted

THE VEDĀNTA SEAM

"tat tvam asi" · MĪMĀṂSĀ: Vedic purposiveness requires action-guidance

ADVĀITA: knowledge is NOT an action; Brahman is an ACCOMPLISHED FACT (siddha-vastu),
so such sentences are independently valid

=> the disagreement is whether Vedic meaningfulness REQUIRES action-production

NIRĪŚVARAVĀDA – EIGHT ARGUMENTS AND THE DILEMMA

no perception · failed inference (embodied potter vs bodiless creator) · no decisive
testimony · motive problem for a beginning of creation · pre-creation problem about
souls and karma · karma + apūrva SUFFICE · evil and partiality · a God-authored Veda
LOSES apauruṣeyatva

OBJECTOR: karma is unconscious; allotment is precise; hence God as KARMAPHALADĀTR

-----+
| THE DILEMMA: if God distributes STRICTLY BY KARMA => karma is the real |
| principle => GOD IS REDUNDANT. If God distributes OTHERWISE => partiality and |
| injustice => GOD IS MORALLY PROBLEMATIC. |
-----+
+-----+

QUALIFICATION: DEVATĀS ARE NOT SIMPLY DENIED. They are largely MANTRA-DENOTED

entities subordinate to the sacrifice; an offering may be addressed to Agni, but the fruit depends on CORRECT PERFORMANCE and APŪRVA, not on Agni's discretionary favour. Kumārila also denies that any individual SARVAJÑA is established by an instrument. ? later Mīmāṃsakas and Mīmāṃsā-influenced Vedāntic traditions sometimes SOFTEN the anti-theistic edge.

! TRAP 1: reversing the two forces. SABDI => impulse. ARTHI => fruit.

! TRAP 2: equating bhāvanā-vāda with niyoga-vāda. They are RIVALS, not synonyms.

! TRAP 3: "Mīmāṃsā rejects the gods". It rejects a CREATOR and FRUIT-DISPENSER.

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 24/24: Self, liberation, comparisons, PYQ route and qualified verdict

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 24/24: Self, liberation, comparisons, PYQ route and qualified verdict

THE SELF – A BOOKKEEPING NECESSITY BEFORE A METAPHYSICAL THESIS
ritual duty · merit · demerit · future fruit ALL presuppose

|
AN ENDURING ĀTMAN – knower · agent · enjoyer
* PLURALITY of eternal selves, NOT one Advaitic universal subject
* body, senses and the internal organ MEDIATE each embodied stream
* NOT a momentary stream: persists across cognition, action, memory, responsibility and enjoyment of the phala
* COGNITION IS EPISODIC, not an uninterrupted essence
PRABHĀKARA: the self is revealed in the THREEFOLD structure of cognition
BHĀṬṬA : awareness of cognition runs through acquired KNOWNNESS
ARGUMENT: if the self were momentary, THE AGENT WHO SACRIFICES WOULD NOT BE THE ENJOYER OF ITS FRUIT => ritual responsibility collapses

LIBERATION – STATE IT CAUTIOUSLY

? mokṣa becomes MORE EXPLICIT IN LATER MĪMĀṢĀ than in the earliest ritual orientation
NOT Advaitic identity with Brahman; release from EMBODIED SUFFERING and from karmically generated experience
requires STOPPING fresh merit and demerit + EXHAUSTING prior karmic forces
=> thereafter no new body, no sense-mediated cognition, no painful experience
! later Bhāṭṭa and Prabhākara accounts differ in detail; do NOT convert either into Advaita's realisation of Brahman or into Nyāya's dependence on a creator
! objection: a heaven-focused ritualism has no real soteriology -> reply: the earliest centre IS duty and ritual fruit, but later doctrine describes release as cessation of pain and karmic embodiment

FIVE INTER-SCHOOL FRONTS

vs NYĀYA intrinsic vs extrinsic validity (largest contrast) · arthāpatti independent here, reduced there · anupalabdhi independent for Bhāṭṭa, denied there · Veda authorless here, God-secured there · universal primary here, qualified particular there · anuvyavasāya there
vs ADVAITA injunction-centred vs liberation-centred and non-dualist · realist error theory vs indescribable status => common vocabulary, DIFFERENT HORIZON
vs BUDDHISM resists PRAGMATIC validity · denies SELF-INTIMATING falsity (illusion does not present itself as false) · rejects apoha · rejects momentariness
vs SĀṂKHYA SHARES the intrinsic authority of cognition · DIFFERS by making invalidity extrinsic and by embedding epistemology in ritual hermeneutics
vs CĀRVĀKA Cārvāka rejects authorless authority, supersensible duty, apūrva and the non-perceptual instruments -> reply: testimony transmits inaccessible facts, postulation resolves conflict, non-cognition discloses absence
! BUT this establishes the INTELLIGIBILITY of non-perceptual knowledge more readily than it PROVES any particular ritual claim

PYQ OWNERSHIP, 2018-2025 – 14 PRIMARY-OWNED PARTS, EVERY YEAR REPRESENTED

2018 Q8(a)	20 self-luminosity => intrinsic validity?	[Panels 18-19]
2019 Q5(e)	10 authority of Vedic knowledge	[Panels 1, 22]
2020 Q5(c)	10 why memory is not valid knowledge	[Panel 11]
2021 Q6(c)	15 ontological status of abhāva	[Panels 14-15]
2022 Q6(c)	15 refuting the reduction of arthāpatti	[Panels 12-13]
2022 Q7(a)	20 Prabhākara vs Kumārila on error	[Panels 16-17]
2023 Q6(b)	15 Bhāṭṭa's anupalabdhi	[Panel 14]
2023 Q8(c)	15 universals or particulars	[Panel 21]
2024 Q5(d)	10 word- and sentence-meaning	[Panels 20-21]
2024 Q8(a)	20 how do I know that I know	[Panel 18]
2024 Q8(b)	15 the candidate never seen studying	[Panel 13]
2024 Q8(c)	15 Prabhākaras and Naiyāyikas on memory	[Panel 11]
2025 Q5(c)	10 intrinsic vs extrinsic validation	[Panels 4-6]
2025 Q6(c)	15 Bhāṭṭa vs Prabhākara on non-existence	[Panel 15]

THE ANSWER SPINE (any mark-weight)

- 1 NAME the sub-school before stating any doctrine
- 2 DEFINE in English first, IAST immediately after
- 3 GIVE the canonical example (shell-silver · stout Devadatta · pot on the table · svargakāmo yajeta · the gavaya)
- 4 STATE the rival (Nyāya first, then Buddhist or Advaita as the question requires)
- 5 GIVE the objection AND the reply
- 6 CLOSE with a QUALIFIED verdict, never a knockout

GRADED VERDICT

STRENGTHS rigorous theory of testimony and interpretation · original account of default entitlement · self-consistent NON-THEISTIC normativity ·

	expansion beyond perception-inference reductionism • rule-governed interpretation
WEAKNESSES	! eternality of śabda against conventionalist and Buddhist critique ! apūrva and svarga unverifiable on perception-centred empiricism ! determinate purport without intention ! late and awkward soteriology
CONTESTED	? does intrinsic validity avoid circularity or relocate it into "defect" and "defeater"? ? is the atheism considered metaphysics or exegetical necessity? ? how should the development of the mokṣa doctrine be placed?
10 MARKS	strongest as a theory of intrinsic validity and Vedic testimony – stated as DEFEASIBLE DEFAULT VALIDITY, not infallibility
15 MARKS	original in linking epistemology, hermeneutics and duty; weak in its contested assumptions of eternal language and unseen potency
20 MARKS	a coherent IMPERSONAL foundation for duty and testimony within realist presuppositions, with language-eternity, authorlessness and ritual causality left philosophically contested by Nyāya, Buddhist and Vedāntic objections